She's A Keeper

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

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She's A Keeper

by DandyVela

Summary

Adora and Catra are high school exes who meet again at Soccer Camp Etheria where they both work as coaches. Romcom chaos ensues.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

saturday

The warm breeze combs through Adora's ponytail as she drives, windows rolled down. She has one hand on the wheel, resting her free elbow on the side of the car.

The old pickup truck had never seen better days before it belonged to Adora. She bought it for herself as a graduation gift with the money she saved from summer jobs. She tried her best to keep it as clean and neat as she could, but she is pretty fond of the scratches and dents; they all have their own stories Adora doesn't know anything about, which is exciting.

She drives past wavy mountains covered in deep green forests, endless sunflower and corn fields laying at their feet. Green, yellow, green, blue. The shaky radio is playing; it makes every pop song sound raspy and jaggy, but that doesn't stop Adora from tapping on the wheel and singing along, loud and off-key, fumbling through the lyrics of every song that comes on.

Several songs later Adora leaves the highway, and she gets a whiff of the scent of the ocean. Layer by layer, the scenery around her shifts into something more bare and coastal.

Adora inhales deeply. The air already tastes salty on her tongue, summer sun warming up her skin and coloring it pink.

*

Adora turns the key and the engine stops with a wobbly puff and some clashing. She gets out of the truck and decides to leave her bags and suitcase in the bed, checking out the campsite first. She only grabs her fanny pack laying on the passenger's seat and slams

the door. Then slams the door again, since it opened up on its own after the first try.

The parking lot is empty yet, except for a pink Beetle, parked crookedly to one side in the corner. Adora smiles at it fondly as she walks past, heading towards the enormous wooden gate and the plank hanging above it on iron chains: "Etheria Soccer Camp".

Adora follows the curly pebbled pathways; the first main ones lead to the office cabins and the dining area, the smaller ones growing from them connect the bungalows in the distance, close to the shore. Most of the bungalows lined up by the sand are pretty roomy, six-bedded sleeping quarters, each of them having its own bathroom attached. The two farthest ones are double-bedded, much smaller which only makes them cozy. One of those two will be Adora's home for the next two weeks.

The air is heavy with heat, seawater spraying on Adora's face. The sun lights up the white beach, the sand shining like blinding crystals. She closes her eyes to the sight, then turns on her heels and takes the steps leading up to the main office. Before she could reach out and turn the knob, the door bursts open, and the air is knocked out of Adora's lungs by a pink hurricane wrapping arms around Adora's neck and legs around her waist.

" *Whoawhoawhoa-* " Adora clings to the wooden rail for dear life, her other hand holding the attacker in place.

"You're here!"

"I'm here!"

The next strike comes soon after, and Adora is embraced by another pair of arms, squeezing both of them even tighter.

"Hey, Glimmer. Bow," Adora croaks, throwing her head back so she could breathe. "I missed you guys, too."

Bow lets her go after another loving squeeze. Glimmer climbs down from Adora as well, her hands looking for Adora's to hold.

"How have you been?" Glimmer asks, tilting her head to the side. There's a worried light in her gaze. "You've been so quiet for so long. You didn't even reply to our congratulations song we wrote for you!"

"Yeah, sorry," Adora says and chews on her lower lip. "I've been so busy with... everything, you know. I loved the song, though." She looks at Bow. "You're getting pretty good with the lute."

"Aw, thanks. Really though, we *have to* celebrate tonight," Bow says, resting his hands on both Adora and Glimmer's shoulders. "You're gonna play in the National Championship, and we couldn't even toast to that before!"

Adora's throat closes up even more.

"It's not that big of a deal-"

"But we're so proud of you," Glimmer says. "Please, Adora? *Please*?"

Glimmer and Bow give their best puppy eyes to Adora, who folds under the pressure pretty quickly. Adora breathes out a sigh that ends in a whimper, but nods anyway.

"Fine. But until then, it's strictly you guys' turn to tell me everything. You don't just start dating behind your best friend's back like that!"

"Deal," Glimmer says and comes 'round Adora. "Let's get to work! We've been waiting to unpack the new dining chairs until you'd arrived."

Adora gasps with delight. "Ooh, that's my favorite part!"

Bow pats her on the back. His voice is already tired. "We know. Just.keep the five chairs rule this time, okay?"

*

The evening descends quickly. The sun dips behind the horizon; it paints the sky dusty pink and the clouds burning orange, swirling into one another like sea and foam. The salty breeze makes the temperature drop a couple degrees, which Adora does not register at all.

After all the heavy lifting and carrying, Adora is soaked, her skin warm and sensitive. She gracelessly flops down onto the floor of the dining area. She pinches her loose tank top and flutters it, letting the air cool her skin a bit. Sitting next to her cross-legged, Bow dries his forehead with his wrist and breathes out in a little huff.

Glimmer has already walked back to the office bungalow to call her mom about the progress they've made, reassuring her that everything will be in order by the time the kids and other staff arrive. Bow takes his phone out to order some celebrational food;the phone immediately starts ringing as soon as he unlocks the screen.

"It's Scorpia," Bow tells Adora before tapping on Accept. He stretches his arm as far as he can. "Hey!"

Adora crawls closer, resting her chin on Bow's shoulder. She waves at the screen.

"Hey you guys," Scorpia says. She is facetiming them lying on her back, pastel pillows and various items of clothes and accessories surrounding her. "Adora, buddy, you made it too! Oh, it's so good to see you. I'm so sorry for not calling you sooner, but my first substitute nominee didn't work out. She cancelled this morning and I was *panicking*- "

"Oh no," Adora says.

"Tell me you have someone else," Bow begs.

"I have someone else."

There's a moment of silence. Bow raises his eyebrows.

"Do you really have someone else or are you just saying what I told you to say?"

Scorpia lets out a breathy laugh.

"Oh no, no, I do have someone else. I texted her all the details, she said k' so she's basically all over herself from excitement. She was the best striker at our college, and she's *great* with kids-"

Before Scorpia could continue, someone is yelling for her in the background, asking about a pair of mint Birkenstocks. Scorpia jerks up in bed, looking around the mess she's been laying on. She starts rummaging through a smaller pile, knick knacks and jewelry flying everywhere. The jingling is ear-piercing as her titanium fingers knock into all that stuff.

"Yeah!" Scorpia finally stops and shouts back, raising a pair of sandals like a trophy. "They're here!"

"Wonderful!" The voice sounds to be coming closer, the claps of bare feet on the wooden floor growing louder. Then, the girl gasps apologetically. "Sorry love, are you on a call?"

Scorpia turns the screen towards the owner of the voice; it's Perfuma, whose face brightens when she sees them. "Oh, Bow! Adora!"

"Hi, Perfuma!"

"It's so nice to finally see you both."

Adora knows Perfuma meant nothing malicious by that, but she still feels bile at the back of her throat. She tries to swallow it before saying:

"I'm so sorry I couldn't make it to the wedding."

"Don't you sweat it," Scorpia says, her voice genuinely threatening. "Really, don't. We know you had that interview booked for months ahead."

"And it got you one step closer to your dreams," Perfuma adds.

"Our dreams came true the same time, huh?" Adora asks. She forgot how to smile so it reaches her eyes; thankfully, Scorpia and Perfuma were busy looking at each other at the sentiment. "Did you get my present?"

"Oh, it's marvelous," Perfuma says, turning back to beam at the screen. "Our morning tea ceremonies have become such a blessing since we use your lovely set."

Adora is way too proud to confess that the idea of engraving Scorpia and Perfuma's pet names for each other inside the cups was Bow's idea.

"We are taking it with us, you know?" Perfuma says.

Scorpia leans her head in the hollow of Perfuma's neck.

"Doesn't trust hotels with their paper cups, this one."

"I'm telling you it is just not the same."

"Oh I know, I'm right there with ya," Scorpia hurries to agree. "Paper's too hot when you start, and then the tea gets cold too fast, and don't even get me started on how the paper sags as you hold it-"

Bow clears his throat politely.

"So, who is this new coach you have for us? What do we know about her?"

Scorpia and Perfuma share a quick, all-too-knowing glance and toothy grins.

"Well-"

Perfuma acts quick; she slides her fingers on Scorpia's mouth, gently squeezing her words back in. Her hundreds of bracelets clink together as she moves. "I think you'll just have to wait and see. Remember, the universe is full of surprises."

"You mean pleasant surprises?" Adora asks, hopeful in tone but conflicted otherwise.

Scorpia tries her best to talk through Perfuma's hand, voice muffled:

"Wouldn't know. I mean really, I couldn't. I wish I did. Have I made a fatal mistake? Probably not. Could it all result in something I did not want and am regretting just now, terrified of the possibility of an awkward outcome?" Perfuma's hand slides down to Scorpia's bare shoulder. Scorpia eases under the touch, mumbling: "I hope not."

Oh, Adora hates this conversation.

"We're just thankful for you making this easier for us," Bow says. "Glimmer has been so busy with preparing everything alone for the first time, we really wouldn't have the time to find someone to replace you. And we trust your decision," he adds with a soft arch of his brows.

"Aw, you guys," Scorpia's voice is higher now. "I really hope we can all meet again this summer."

"We will," Adora says, barely trusting her own words as they roll off of her tongue.

She was never one to flake out on anything, but the uncertainty of her life right now, the ever growing chaos, already missing out on so much so far leaves a gaping hole of guilt in her chest.

"We're still ready for the annual grill party," Bow says, throwing a hand over Adora's shoulder to make it clear he means the three of

them, not just him and Glimmer. "Right, Adora?"

Adora only nods. Perfuma gets all too excited, jumping in her seat.

"Ooh, I shall make those veggie sausages again that you liked so much! Remember?"

Adora remembers. Adora remembers eating a dozen of them, and thinking she was definitely going to die over the following three days. Her stomach twists into a little ball at the memory, feeling acid on the back of her tongue.

"That would be great," she blurts out, mouth barely moving.

Adora is still fighting back her nausea a moment later, when Perfuma and Scorpia excuse themselves, having a lot left to do before they leave for the airport. Once they hang up, Bow is immediately back on his food ordering quest.

"What are you in the mood for?" Bow asks Adora, who staggers to her feet. Her knee buckles under her for a moment. *Not vegan sausage.* "Pizza? Sushi? I'm getting Glimmer a veggie stir-fry and some panko shrimp, she's been talking about those all day." Bow smiles to himself. "It's like once she starts craving something, she can't get it out of her head until she has it."

Adora chuckles and leans down to hit Bow on the shoulder.

"You're sooo into her," Adora coos. Bow's skin darkens on his nose, the color creeping on his cheeks and ears too. His embarrassment entertains Adora even more, but she decides to spare him from teasing. For now. "You know I'll eat anything." *Except vegan sausage.*

"I was thinking I could go to town and grab a bottle of champagne, get the food on my way back. Wanna tag along?"

"All I want is a cold shower," Adora says, stretching her arms behind her back. "And I still need to get my own bags from the truck. Which bungalow is mine? Last one?"

Bow grins.

"As always. Meet you there in an hour?"

Adora points finger guns at him and turns around. Her body feels too heavy to carry.

*

When Adora closes the door of the bungalow on herself, dragging all her stuff in, she doesn't really feel like unpacking anymore. Her knee is pulsing uncomfortably, sweat and sand sticking to her skin. The AC humming in the room sends shivers up her spine now.

Adora squeezes her bags tighter and throws them on the bed closer to the tiny bathroom. Her glance finds the other bed in the corner, empty and illuminated by pink sunbeam stripes that break through the blinds.

She wonders what kind of person she will be sharing the room with. Adora is not picky; while she knows that it is nearly impossible for anyone to be a better roommate than Scorpia, all she needs is someone decent. Just… don't be the world's biggest asshole, basically, and things will be fine. And there's like a ghost of a chance that the new coach will be that much of a pain in her ass if Scorpia is fond enough of them to offer them the job.

Adora tears her gaze away and peels her clothes off before even reaching the bathroom. She runs the shower for so long that she is still in there by the time Bow and Glimmer knock on her door, hands full of takeout and a bottle of champagne.

*

The evening melts into a warm night. The three of them sit outside, huddled up on the stairs and talk and laugh until the stars come up. Adora's chest is warming up from the champagne and the bubbly feeling of being close to her friends again; she is sleepy already, but it's the kind of comfortable exhaustion that flows through her after spending a beautiful day outside and letting the sun carry her worries away.

Glimmer rests her head on Bow's shoulder. Bow wraps his arm around her waist in return, gently drawing her closer. Glimmer tries to fight back a yawn mid-sentence; it only makes Bow and Adora yawn in agreement.

Adora wishes this moment would never end. The weather is perfect; comfortably warm with a cool breeze that flutters the leaves of the palm trees. The quiet rustling is met with the rumbling of the sea, the gently splashing waves. Stars are twinkling above them on the clear summer sky. Adora looks up and blinks back at the stars, tears pooling at the corners of her eyes.

Whether it is just the eye strain, or the exhaustion, or even the overwhelming happiness, Adora doesn't let the tears flow. She peeks at her friends, seeing that Glimmer is already asleep huddled up to Bow. Bow and Adora share a look, both trying to swallow back laughter.

As Bow quietly says his goodnight and carries Glimmer to bed, Adora stays on the porch for a little longer, temple resting on the wooden rail, watching the roaming waves calming into foam as they reach the shore.

Things could not be more perfect.

sunday

The next morning, Glimmer gets an early call from an unknown number; the new coach couldn't take the whole day off on such short notice, so she would arrive later in the afternoon, meaning she'd miss the staff bus. Naturally, this makes Adora spend the whole day focused on the plans she forges in her mind about all the possible scenarios that might happen. It makes her mess up a couple of the tasks she's given but it's fine, she will fix everything *and* get to Plan T in no time.

What if the new girl snores? What if she doesn't use slippers when she comes out of the shower and soaks the whole room? What if she wants to sleep with the blinds up? What if she hates how Adora sings in the shower? What if she won't even like her? Or, what if she is pretty? Like, really pretty. Adora hasn't dated anyone in so long. What if they hit it off but Adora's rusty flirting will make her hate Adora? What if she is beautiful but painfully straight and Adora will have to spend the whole two weeks trying to not fall in love with the girl of her dreams?

"Adora?"

Adora jumps at the mention of her name, head jerking up. She turns towards the voice. Glimmer walks to her, wearing her lavender coach cap and a worried smile. It makes Adora realise how strained her own expression is; jaw clenched, eyebrows knit. She forces her features to relax and takes her own yellow cap from Glimmer.

"Are you just gonna stand here until she arrives?"

Yes.

"No," Adora says, putting the cap on. "I just came to the parking lot to, uh, check if I locked Darla's doors." She nods her head towards the truck. "I did."

"Uh huh," Glimmer says. "Well, she just texted. She's already downtown."

"Oh."

Oh no. Adora is so not ready. She bites her lower lip, barely noticing that Bow pins them in his own blue cap and stands by Adora's left side.

The three of them are staring at the only narrow, dusty road leading to camp.

"Does anyone else have a feeling that we should hold a welcome banner?" Bow asks. No one answers him. "Just me? Okay ."

Glimmer shushes him and raises a hand.

"Do you guys hear that?"

Adora certainly does. It's a low, popping rumble that gets louder by the second. Just a moment later, a motorcycle turns into the parking lot. It is mostly black with deep purple accents; Adora knows nothing about bikes so all she can see is that it looks pretty cool.

The rider parks the bike right next to the trio and sharply toes the kickstand down to prop the cruiser. She is a small, slender figure dressed in ripped leather and combat boots, hopping off the bike with easy elegance. She takes her helmet off; her long, grey bangs and side curls stand up and out, ruffled and adorable.

Wow .

The biker's face is still mostly covered with the huge lenses of her aviators. Adora only sees her turned up button nose and hundreds of dark freckles covering her face. Strange. She looks and moves a bit like...

The new coach takes her glasses off, and Adora can feel the blood rush up her neck and under her cheeks. Well, that's… something none of her plans included. Shit.

"Catra?" Adora asks, eyes wide.

"Oh," the girl says, voice flat. Her lips curl into an unimpressed smirk as she squints. "Hey , Adora."

Adora's face brightens immediately, despite anxiety rising up in her just a moment ago. She leaps closer to Catra, a loopy grin on her face that does not fade when she nearly trips on a pebble.

"Oh my God, it's been so long! I can't believe it's you! We have so much to ta-"

"Hey , I'm Catra." Catra walks past Adora and holds out her hand. "You must be Glitter."

Glimmer puffs herself up immediately. "Gli *mmer* ."

Catra ignores her. "And Bow?"

Glimmer grudgingly shakes Catra's hand and shoots Adora a " *whatthefuckishappening* " glare over Catra's shoulder. Adora looks just as lost, her arm still froze n mid air in a friendly wave. She draws it back to her side, slow and awkward.

"Welcome to Camp Etheria!" Glimmer changes back into her professional self, and Bow adds, taking Catra's hand after Glimmer:

"We're so glad you could join us, you saved our lives." And then, a moment later: "Have we met?"

"Dunno," Catra says. She yanks on the strap of her backpack; the motion makes her tube top slide higher on her stomach. Adora's jaw pops open a little. "Anyway . Scorpia told me the gist of this coach thing, so. Sounded cool enough."

"Scorpia, of course," Bow slaps his forehead. "You were at the wedding!"

" *She was?* "Adora hates the sound of her own voice.

"Don't you catch on fast,"Catra mutters sourly . "Where's my room?"

"Right, you should unpack before dinner." Glimmer claps her hands. "I'll show you. This way."

Glimmer gestures towards the pathways, and walks ahead to lead Catra. As the two of them disappear behind the office bungalow, Bow turns to Adora.

"What was that?" he asks carefully, causing Adora to cross her arms.

"Right? What's her problem?"

"I mean, how do *you* two know each other?"

Adora sucks her lips in, then lets them pop. She blurts out like she would confess breaking something insanely expensive:

"We used to date in high school."

Bow gasps loudly, hands on his cheeks. Seeing Adora's face, he collects himself and says carefully: "So... heh. I guess the breakup was pretty nasty."

Adora opens her mouth, then closes it without saying anything. She stares blankly at Bow for a long moment.

"I don't. I don't know."

"You *don't know*?"

Before Adora could at least try to explain herself, Glimmer walks back to them with a sour grimace on her face.

"So, problem… Catra refuses to share a bungalow with you. She wants her own." Glimmer peeks back where she came from. "Certainly a charmer. Are we sure she's great with kids?"

"She really acts like one," Adora huffs.

"What the hell happened between you two? You weren't even at the wedding!" Glimmer says, voice high with frustration. Bow quickly catches her up on the scoop, leaning towards her like he is sharing a secret:

"High school exes."

Glimmer bursts out laughing, waving her hand with her palm down.

"Riiight. Like Adora would ever date an edgy prick like that. Good one, babe."

"I wasn't joking."

Glimmer freezes and glares at them in turn for a moment that feels like a devastating eternity. When no one denies or revokes it as a joke, she breathes out in a very long sigh.

"Seriously?" She sounds more disappointed than anything. "Didn't end well, did it? Hm. No wonder."

Adora groans and flaps her arms down.

"Why does everyone keep saying that?" Her voice crawls higher with every word. "It wasn't a bad breakup! It was barely even a breakup-"

Glimmer slides her palms onto Adora's shoulders, squeezing them gently.

"Hey, it's okay. I'm sure you're right. Also, this might just be the first shock. Meeting our exes is always awkward."

Adora pouts and glances away. Well it's not like *she* made it awkward, Catra did. She is just so… frustrating. Dumbass, mean Catra. In those dumbass leather pants. Ugh.

"You just have to talk to her," Bow offers. "Ask her how she's feeling, what she's thinking, how she's been." Adora's head jerks up like she

was stung by a bee, and Bow continues as quickly as he can: "Just maybe not right nnn-nd she's gone."

Glimmer and Bow share a quick glance before Glimmer cups her hands around her mouth and shouts after Adora:

"Keep it civilized, okay? We can't have any drama between us now!"

"I know!"

Adora rushes towards the bungalow, sneakers sinking in the sand so she's pulling her feet up with every step like a swamp monster. She is too distracted to take the pathway that is right there, more determined to find out what Catra's deal is than using her common sense for mundane things.

Adora hops up all three stair steps and barges into the room. Inside, she finds Catra standing by Adora's clearly occupied bed, holding up one of her old shirts which Adora knows was packed deep inside her suitcase. Catra doesn't even turn to look at her as she says:

"I can't believe you still have this ugly shirt. I always hated it."

Adora grabs onto the door frame. *Keep it civilized* , Glimmer told her.

"What the hell was that, Catra?"

Civilized.

Catra lets the shirt fall onto the bed, turning towards Adora.

"What?" she practically purrs, voice low and raspy. "I didn't do anything."

"You know exactly what I mean."

Catra crosses her arms and gives Adora a little shrug.

"Sorry I wasn't gonna jump into your arms after everything." The corner of Catra's mouth twitches. She covers it with a crooked smirk. "I didn't know you were gonna be here. If I did, I wouldn't have come."

This should not have the effect it does on Adora. She exhales sharply, straightening and letting go of the doorframe she did not realise she was holding onto as hard as she was. Her skin is deep pink and striated, fingers shaking. She takes an uncertain step towards Catra; Adora expects her to get further away from her, but Catra stays put, chin raised challengingly.

"I'm sorry if I hurt you with anything, Catra," Adora says sheepishly. She slides her palm to her own chest. "I really didn't mean to, and I'm sorry for messing up. But it's been so long and it was so exciting to see you again! Can we just.. be adults and start over?"

Catra raises a brow as if saying "is that all?" Adora licks her lips. She feels her fingers itching to reach out for Catra's hand; she curls them into a fist.

"Can we?" Adora asks again, pleading.

Catra is just staring at her, sharp eyes narrow and piercing. Adora is unsure what to make out of it; does not matter how long she has known Catra, she never seems to know what is going on in her head. She feels like she is thrown back into high school again by those mismatched eyes, her heart pounding on her eardrums loud and annoying.

Catra breaks the agonizing wait with a grimace. She reaches behind her back, leaning onto the dresser.

"Whatever," she sighs, tilting her head. "I knew I couldn't get my own room anyway. I just wanted to stir the pot a little bit."

Of course she did. Adora is smiling at her from ear to ear now, humming. All she earns is an annoyed snarl from Catra.

"Just to be clear , we're not friends, okay?" Catra says.

"Okay ," Adora says, way too chipper and satisfied. She manages to bounce on the balls of her feet unperceived.

"We're just colleagues who tolerate each other a normal amount."

"Okay ."

"Okay ." Catra squints at Adora. There is a mischievous flare in her eyes. "And I still don't like your face."

"I know for a fact that's not true."

Adora gets her own pillow in her face. The impact is pretty violent and painful, Adora still snorts with laughter as she catches the pillow rolling off her face.

"Oh no," Adora says. "My beautiful face you like so much!"

"Shut up!"

Adora can't help it; she keeps laughing until her lungs start whistling.

She does not notice Catra watching her the whole time.

*

Despite Adora's best efforts to smooth things over between her and Catra, Catra is not eager to hang out with her. Adora figures it is best to let her be and give her some space, so the two of them unpack their stuff in complete silence.

Catra finishes earlier, only bringing one trekker backpack. Adora is a notorious overpacker;she does not own much, but that just gives her permission to bring all of her belongings everywhere with her, no matter how far or how long she leaves for, so she is about halfway done now.

Catra flops down onto her bed with her phone in her hand. She puts her earbuds in, further ignoring Adora. Adora can hear the quick beat of rock songs that Catra is listening to way too loudly; a distorting ruckus of heavy drums and scream-singing.

After Adora has put everything away and pushed her suitcases and bags under her bed, she peeks at the clock on the wall. It is almost time for dinner. Her stomach growls at the thought.

Catra is still listening to music, knees drawn up, one leg thrown over the other, eyes closed. She moves her foot to the beat so Adora knows she is not asleep. Also, Catra is wearing her boots to bed. Which is. Why.

Adora contemplates her options for a minute, trying to walk off the jitters. Her heart is beating faster in her chest for some reason, and she feels like she is vibrating in her skin. Is she nervous? She knows she has no reason to be. It is just Catra. She doesn't bite.

Well, that is a lie.

Adora clears her throat as loudly as she can. No answer. She steps closer to Catra now, calling her name. No answer. Adora reaches out to tap on Catra's shoulder, doing so quickly.

Catra growls; it reminds Adora of the sound cats make when you stroke them while they are fast asleep. Adora bites the inside of her cheek.

Catra opens her eyes very, very slowly.

"What?" She asks. Adora points at her own ears, so Catra begrudgingly takes one earbud out. "What?" She repeats, popping the T.

"Dinner is gonna be ready soon," Adora says. "You can meet the others. The community is really nice here, if you give them a chance-
"

"I'm not hungry," Catra says, twisting the earbud between her fingers.

"Oh. Okay. Really? I'm starving. Um. Well also have a coach meeting after? We light a bonfire by the beach and talk through stuff. It's not obligatory, but it would be really nice if-"

Catra groans and puts the earbud back in.

"Fine, I'll check in later, okay?" And with that, Catra turns on her side, showing her back to Adora. "Jesus."

*

"Shouldn't we wait for Catra?" Bow asks.

Adora peeks at Glimmer and shrugs. She is sitting between Bow and Glimmer on one of the comfortable logs that are laid out in a triangle, with a bonfire blazing between them. Adora is staring into the fire, eyes following the crispy sparks jumping and getting carried away by the breeze.

"Maybe she won't even show up," Glimmer says, crinkling her nose. Adora told them everything that happened at dinner, but with so many familiar faces mingling around them, they did not have the time to get deeper into the matter.

"She will," Adora says firmly. "I just... don't know what her problem really is." She picks up a twig and throws it into the fire. It flares up bright and quick. "What else can I do now other than apologise? And I did! And I am trying, but she's the same stubborn brat that she-"

"Catra, you made it!" Bow exclaims.

Adora turns her head. Catra is still a safe enough distance away, so she probably did not hear anything. Adora turns back and throws another twig into the flames. She desperately wants to calm down, but something inside her is still flaming, hand in hand with the

childlike enthusiasm she feels whenever Catra is close; the two emotions tug on her brain and pull her into opposite directions.

Catra, now wearing her hair in a messy bun and dressed in an oversized band tee, steps over the empty log next to them with one leg. She flops down onto it sideways, spreading her legs wide and facing the others.

"Hey . What did I miss?"

"We didn't start without you," Bow says.

Catra clicks her tongue. "Great."

"So, now that we're all here," Glimmer says, all too sweetly, tapping on the tablet laying in her lap. "Battle plans. Catra, you get Scorpia's usual team, the Garnets. Do you want to change the name?"

"Nah," is all Catra says. She is very focused on burying her feet into the warm sand, wiggling her toenails painted deep purple.

"Good, because we don't have time to make new jerseys. Speaking of-" Glimmer turns around and picks up a red cap. She practically throws it at Catra. "There's your official coach cap! Welcome to the team or whatever."

Catra takes the cap but does not put it on. She rests her elbows on her sprawled knees and hangs the cap on a hooked finger, lazily spinning it.

"Yay, thanks," she says.

Adora shoots Catra a reproachful look from behind Glimmer. Catra sticks her tongue out in response. Glimmer takes a deep, deep breath and ignores their little scene, opening another document on the tablet. The lights illuminating her face change colors, painting her hair blue and her eyes green.

"So, the team lineups are pretty similar to last year's; we only have four newcomers registered, which mea-"

Catra straightens and peeks at the screen. She scoffs sharply.

"Your team is called 'Arrows'?" she drawls, contempt practically dripping off her tongue.

Bow registers nothing of it when he squeaks:

"Dope, isn't it? I was so proud of it when I made it up. Seahawk said it was the coolest name he's ever heard."

Catra tightens her bun with both hands, a crooked smile widening on her face.

"Defeating you guys will be a piece of cake."

Glimmer curls her lips into a pout, nostrils flaring. "Excuse me? Sorry? I was talking?"

Sensing the tension rising, Adora lowers her voice as she leans in and whispers:

"Glimmer, be cool. No drama between us, remember?"

"Aw, is this a drama-free environment? How nice. Do we braid each other's hair and talk about our feelings? Is there a daily compliment quota we gotta hit?"

Glimmer looks like she is ready to tear all her hair out, and go for Catra's scalp right after.

"Can you shut up for one minute?"

"I don't know. Sounds like a lot of work."

"Adora, do something!"

"Me? Why me?"

"Makes sense to me," Catra says. The edge of her voice is sharp like knives, cutting through Adora's mind as their eyes find each other's for the first time around the fire. The shift in the atmosphere is sudden and fatal like a freezing gust of wind. "You were always great at managing to control me, right?"

Adora starts to rise up, heart hammering from a whiplash of fury.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

Bow grabs her wrist and pulls her back down, and does not wait for Catra to answer.

"Okay everybody, let's just all calm down and listen to what Glimmer has to say. You can talk out your deep-rooted issues in your own free time, in the bungalow. If you want. Or just continue… whatever this was. Alright?" Bow looks at Adora. Adora bares her teeth but forces herself to nod. Bow turns around to Catra then, expression unfaltered. Catra returns the look languidly. "Okay!"

Bow gestures to Glimmer to continue, and after shooting Bow a thankful glance, she finally does. Adora's eyes are still drilling into Catra's, everything else around her blurry and dark.

Glimmer gives them the usual run through. She mentions details Adora and Bow already know, but Catra probably does not about the rules and schedule of the camp. Adora can barely sense the tension in the air anymore, like it just flared up and burned to a crisp right away, like the twigs she threw in the fire.

Catra takes her elastic out and hoops it on her wrist. She digs her fingers into her hair and notices Adora staring. The sparks in her mismatched eyes are straightforward now, their bright warmth almost inviting. Was Catra just.testing her before?

Adora's head is throbbing. She has never felt more confused and lost, and she barely knows what is happening around her on a daily basis. Technically, she knows that some things are unpredictable, and that you can only be prepared for anything in a general sense, which already drives her mad and anxious about the next thing - but Catra? Catra is a wild card. There's no possibility of preparing with her.

Adora tears her gaze away .

After a couple minutes of talking and switching between docs and spreadsheets on the tablet, Glimmer looks around the fire.

"Any questions?"

Bow and Adora shake their heads silently.

"Are we done?" Catra asks, painted nails scratching the "Coach" title on her cap.

"Oh, we are," Glimmer says, voice vibrating. She folds her tablet into its shimmery case and puts it on the log next to her.

Bow turns around in his seat and grabs a ginormous paper bag that is stuffed to the max. He plops it in front of him and starts unpacking boxes and bags.

"Time for smores!" he says with a glowing grin, throwing each of them their own ration of ingredients.

Catra snaps hers up hungrily, hugging the boxes and bags to her chest like treasure.

"Ugh, finally ."

"...Really?" Glimmer says with a snarky grin. "I didnt assume you had a sweet tooth."

Adora snorts loudly.

"You have no idea," she says, ignoring Catra's warning glare. "Catra was the chubby bunny champion at our school. She could defeat *anyone* , and when they gave up, Catra would look them dead in the eye and *swallow the whole thing* ."

"Ewwww , what? How?"

"That's so gross but so awesome!" Bow adds, voice cracking. "You have to teach me your tricks."

"The trick is to fear no god," Catra says and shrugs. She already tore her marshmallow bag open and popped one in her mouth.

Adora could see the genuine surprise on Catra's face when the others start cackling at her joke. She would swear the dark shade on her cheeks is not just a shadow cast by the dancing flames.

*

As the night falls, more people join them. The referees first, then the counselors, then the kitchen staff and the office employees; all the seats on the logs get occupied, people even sitting in the sand that is slowly cooling down. One of the central referees gets really into singing, so Bow takes out his lute for cue music to his shanties.

People keep mingling, taking and leaving seats as they go, and so Adora finds herself sitting down next to Catra.

Things start to get louder, so Catra grows even more quiet. Adora is chatting with the referee's girlfriend, the other central, when she notices that Catra had disappeared from her side.

Mermista sways the skewer dangerously close to Adora as she goes on:

"And I was like, okay, just because I catfished your brother for bullying me in middle school and and sent his ass on a nonexistent date to a different state we can still be friends--" She clips her words

as she glances at Adora. Mermista changes her tone: "And then I sawed him into pieces and buried his bones right under this bonfire."

"Mm, sounds good," Adora chirps.

Mermista growls and waves her hand in front of Adora's hazy eyes.

"Um, hello? Is being listened to while I talk too much to ask for?"

Adora blinks.

"What? Oh, no, I'm sorry . I was listening."

"Suure."

Adora is suddenly hyper-aware of her legs bouncing. She scans the crowd for Catra once again, head turning like a sprinkler. Her ponytail flaps behind her with every ragged move.

Mermista blows on her marshmallow and rests her chin on her free palm, black nails tapping her half-shadowed face.

"You're looking for that rocker chick, right? That Cat...girl."

"Catra."

"Yeah, she left like fifteen minutes ago. Guess she was getting bored with staring at you."

The blazing fire warms Adora's cheeks. Her voice is small.

"She what?"

"Of course you're listening now. Wanna hear the rest of my story or-" Mermista's eyes grow wide, her voice thick as she stares at something right behind Adora. "Who gave Seahawk a torch? Which one of you gave Seahawk a torch!?"

The joyous answer comes from the perpetrator himself.

"Correction, my dear - I found it myself!"

Mermista hops up and comes around Adora, leaving her alone with her thoughts and the sad sight of Mermista's marshmallow dropped in the sand. Adora cannot blame her; they all remember last summer when someone asked Seahawk if he could burn a couple newspapers the kitchen staff used to transport the plates. They nearly lost a bungalow.

Adora's fingers are fumbling with the hem of her shorts. Her head is buzzing with the crackling of the bonfire, the muffled noise of laughs and cheerful screams. It does not take her a long time to stagger to her feet as well, deciding to go and look for Catra.

Not entirely sure why. She has no reason to think it was a good idea. If anything, Catra's offhanded comment about Adora controlling her should register in Adora's mind as "back the fuck off." Part of Adora's brain is aware of it. Part of it. On the other hand, if she had done anything wrong, she should know about it, right? She should be told so, and be given the opportunity to make it right. That's how things are supposed to go.

The weather got a bit colder, Adora notices when she walks away from the heat and light of the fire. Adora assumes Catra went back to their bungalow so she does as well; stepping inside though, she finds it dark and empty, the bathroom too. Adora walks past the window and as she peeks out, she sees a tiny figure huddled up on the shore.

Adora smiles fondly. She takes her bedspread and steps outside again, walking carefully so she makes no sound. It is no use; she is pretty far away when Catra turns her head and stares at her over her shoulder.

"Can't a girl get any time alone?" Catra asks and turns back towards the sea. She hugs her knees closer, chin resting on her arm as she watches the waves flow to shore. She is sitting so close to the water that the next ripples could reach her toes.

Adora halts for a second. She licks her lips, crinkling the bedspread between her fingers.

"You want to be left alone?"

"I'm sitting alone in the dark, far away from everyone. Take a wild fucking guess."

"Wow, okay," Adora snaps back. Her laugh sounds hollow as she cocks her head. "Just when I thought you started to have fun. Why are you like this?"

"What do you care?"

"I don't know!" Adora rolls the bedspread into a ball and flings it at Catra with all her might. It hits her in the head. Catra fidgets and slams the spread down, turning in her seat with a kick of her feet.

"Hey!"

Adora inhales slowly, pinching the bridge of her nose. It is strangely difficult to calm herself down. When she hangs her head down awkwardly and continues, she can feel Catra's curious eyes on her, so she avoids them. Her voice is softer now.

"I just do. And I never- I never wanted you to feel like I wanted to control you."

Catra laughs dry.

"You're still hung up on that? Seriously, Adora?"

"What did you mean by that?"

Catra says nothing. When Adora forces herself to look at her, she doesn't know what to make out of Catra's expression.

The sea is swashing quietly. The moonlight is flickering on the black waves behind Catra, covering the silhouette of her wild hair with a

silver glow. The contrast darkens her features, sharpening them into daggers. It is just Adora and Catra's piercing eyes, burning with blue and amber flames, hotter than the bonfire Adora just walked away from.

"Did you bring your own bedspread?" Catra finally asks, dropping her knees down. "You know it's gonna be full of sand, right?"

Adora puckers her lips.

"I didn't want you to get cold."

Catra stands up at that, taking the bedspread with her by holding a corner in each hand. She steps in front of Adora and throws the bedspread on Adora's shoulders like a cape.

Adora can feel the blood rush up to her cheeks as Catra holds the corners between their chests, tugging on it so lightly that Adora is unsure why she is leaning in; it might be Catra's hands, or it might just be her alluring eyes pulling her closer. The backs of Catra's hands reach Adora; as she gasps quietly, the touch lingers on her chest a moment longer.

Adora can feel her heartbeat thrumming on her ribs, humming in her ears. She puffs her chest out, longing for Catra's skin on her.

Obviously, Catra is still beautiful; especially now, haloed by the moonlight, with her makeup-bare face and hair frizzy and poofy from the damp air, lips shiny from Catra sliding her tongue over them slowly, staring at Adora like she wanted to devour her whole, melt into her.

Obviously, Adora is still attracted to her; she was not going to deny that, at least from herself. She cannot blame herself for her breath hitching when Catra tugs on the spread with a light jolt of growing force, Adora tilting her head impulsively-

Catra lets go, raising her chin triumphant. Adora nearly falls over her, slamming her right foot ahead to support herself. She stands halfway between Catra's legs now, their foreheads just a breath away from touching. Catra's left hand lets the spread go, bringing her hand down between them; the ghosts of her fingertips brushing across Adora's stomach.

"You're so predictable," Catra whispers.

Adora wants to kill her.

"Am not!"

Catra starts giggling; that high little sound washes away all Adora's frustration, empties her mind into blissful nothing. She can feel her own features melt into something she might not want others to see, but it is fine since it is just Catra and the rippling darkness.

Catra ducks out in an elegant spin and comes 'round her. Adora turns as well, grabbing the bedspread so it stays on her shoulders.

"Where are you going?"

"I'm going to bed," Catra says, not looking back.

"I thought we could stay here for a bit," Adora says, taking a couple uncertain steps as well. She is aware how stupid she sounds after everything that just happened, but right now, leaping across the ocean sounds easier than not talking to Catra.

Catra keeps walking;she raises a hand and waves it nonchalantly .

"I'm not going to stargaze romantically with you, Adora. I'm not your girlfriend anymore. Go back to your friends and let me be, okay?"

Adora flops down where she stands and watches Catra's swaying figure melt into the distance.

Catra, messing with Adora with frivolous ease. Catra, always finding her way to crawl under Adora's skin like she has always belonged there. Catra, ever so playfully cruel about the games she plays, the rules only she knows. Catra, deciding at the very last moment to either kill her or take her.

And Catra, so uniqely beautiful with the duality of her eyes and voice and whole being - leaving Adora tiptoeing between the two sides on a rope high up in the sky, knowing she will have to fall, either for her or because of her.

Catra does not seem to have changed at all.

The thought disheartens Adora just as much as it excites her .

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

h which Catra warms up to Adora a bit. They also finally play soccer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

mday

I told you to give her some time," Bow says, shoveling scrambled eggs on his fork.

I did,"Adora says.

She only pushes her food around on the plate. The quiet clattering of silverware makes her head throb.

Adora decided to go back to their bungalow late enough to find Catra hopefully asleep. Then, she tossed and turned all night, and got up as soon as the sky brightened into a dusty shade of grey.

She changed into a tank top and leggings and sneaked out then, always using the time after waking up to exercise. She usually jogs a couple laps and goes through her usual dozen HIIT exercises by the soccer fields, shoes slipping on the fresh dewy grass, the cool air tightening her lungs and sticking to her warm skin. She misses gym equipment but enjoys the crispy scent of dawn, and the breeze that sends shivers up her spine whenever she stops moving. There's usually fog coating the fields, hiding the goalposts and the bungalows from her sight like she is surrounded by nothing. It feels

like floating in her own mind; like lucid dreaming where her brain does not map the whole world out.

Catra slept through Adora sneaking back in, showering and getting ready. Or pretended to, at least. Adora was peeking at her a couple of times while she was putting on grey shorts and a light yellow t-shirt with the usual coach title and the main sponsor of the camp, Dryll Enterprises' logo on the chest. GRASSKILL is written on the back, framed by Camp Etheria's winged emblem.

Lastly, Adora creaked the door open to the office bungalow. They have a shared fridge plugged in there so coaches and referees dont have to barge into the always busy kitchen. Adora has the top shelf; she keeps some pre-made protein shakes there, as well a couple bags of frozen smoothies in the freezer. And some extra berries. And maybe some caramel ice cream.

She grabbed a bottle of the banana-chocolate flavored shakes and kicked the door closed with the heel of her sneaker, then did the same to the bungalow door. The fog had mostly dissipated; the horizon was just starting to flare up in the East.

A handful of people were loitering around the dining area by the time Adora arrived, Bow and Glimmer included, so Adora catches them up immediately about the events of last night.

"I wouldnt call a couple hours time," Glimmer yawns, leaning back on her chair. "Just let her sulk, shes not your problem. You guys arent together anymore."

"I know that," Adora says, offended. She is getting really annoyed by everyone telling her that like she didnt know. "I just wanted to be nice, is it that bad?"

"Of course not," Glimmer shrugs. "But if she doesnt want to accept your kindness, thats on her. Especially since she doesnt seem to have anything pleasant about her."

I" thought I could get through to her." Adora sighs and rests her temple in her palm. "Make things okay between us again and help her find her place in the camp. Iwanted her to enjoy her time here as much as Ido, that's all..."Her voice trails of f into a mumble.

Bow and Glimmer share a look. Before they could say anything, Adora takes a huge chug of her shake that hurts to swallow, and slams the bottle down. The table shakes.

"Y ou know what? You're right. Im done with trying to be the bigger person. f she doesnt want to be friends again, that's fine. Im not going to try and change her mind."

"Finally ," Glimmer breathes out, relieved. She headbutts the tabletop and stays down. "It's way too early for all this talking."

"And if she needs to be appeased, Istill have marshmallows."

Glimmer points at Bow, appreciating his idea. Adora finally chuckles. She feels very hungry all of a sudden; she snatches a handful of toast from the bread box for the pile of eggs she has on her plate.

She has a plan. All she has to do now is to follow it for two weeks.

Easy.

ednesday

t is not easy .

Well. t is easy , for the most part.

Adora limits herself to shooting some volatile side glances at Catra when she doesnt notice, and watching her work with the kids - she

has the opportunity and the time, since they always got the two halves of the same field to hold their practice, while Bow and Glimmer shared the other one next to it.

Catra never seems to notice her and focuses on her job instead, while Adora is doing the same. When the two of them are alone in their bungalow, the quiet is bearable; familiar, even.

It reminds Adora of the times Catra came to Adora's house just to hang; they were doing their own separate things, still close to each other. Catra would lay by Adora's bed or spread out on the floor with her laptop. Sometimes she would get so comfortable that she would fall asleep, taking a nap in Adora's bed, leaving her scent with Adora for the night.

Adora was aware that Catra's family situation was pretty shitty, and Adora was her sanctuary. After a while, things started to shift into something more; Catra would let Adora huddle close to her to watch something together, and she would lay her head in Adora's lap. They would touch each other more freely, although it always happened within the safe walls of Adora's room, hiding them from the world. It started with little nuzzles while play-fighting and holding sweaty hands, fingertips caressing cheeks and necks and shoulders. Adora started to find it harder and harder to keep her hands off of Catra - and yet, Catra kissed her first.

It was really messy. At a sleepover, laying in the dark, fumbling blindly. Catra went for it, quick and intense, like she was afraid of missing her one chance, smashing their noses together and letting their teeth clash. Their lips barely touched but Catra drew back quickly, almost falling out of bed with panic flashing in her eyes. She only relaxed when Adora started giggling like an idiot and pulled Catra back by her nape for a second, much sweeter kiss.

"What?"

Adora winces. She is suddenly aware that she has a comb in one hand, her pajamas in the other, as she was leaving for the bathroom

God knows how long ago.

"W -what?" Adora asks back.

"Y oure staring." Catra crosses her arms over her chest. She is dressed down to a sports bra; Adora gathers all her strength to not let her gaze fixate on the dark trail of hair that starts at Catra's belly button and disappears under her shorts. "It's really creepy ."

"I just. Uh." Adora tries so hard to find an explanation that it hurts her brain. "Y ou grew your hair out again."

"I know . I was there."

"I mean it's. it' s nice?"

Catra snorts; she cannot help it turning into a chuckle. She lets her arms fall, one hand coming back up to her hip.

"Are you asking or saying?"

Adora finds herself grinning back.

"Whichever helps me get out of this in a better light."

"Smooth."

Adora hums proudly. She is still looking at Catra; Catra is staring back without blinking. Adora starts to feel like this is a challenge, and she is unsure what the good outcome would be. Does Catra want her to back down and submit, or should Adora give it her all and try to earn her respect?

Turns out she does not have to choose. Her eyes get watery, forcing her to blink first.

With that one little blink she almost misses the door closing behind Catra who leaves for her usual evening run.

f ri day

"W anna stay behind and practice some?" Adora asks, maneuvering around Catra in the tiny, cluttered shed where they keep eqipment.

Yes, she gave up.

They are finished with the last bit of coaching for the week, so they have free time to kill until the two qalifying matches on Saturday morning.

Catra straightens from putting back a tower of cones in the corner. She leans on the agility ladders hanging on the wall, raising her brows.

"With you?"

"And Glimmer and Bow. There's a soccer tennis court by the tail gate. But we could use the fields too, if we want. It's kind of our thing on Fridays."

"...A what?"

"Oh, a… um. The court with four divisions, with the net in the middle? You must have seen it. The rules are really like tennis. I mean the main ones, then we have our own rules, youll learn them fast. It's very fun. Angella - Glimmer's mom - thought it was the best way to improve juggling abilities."

"Aha," is all Catra says. Adora can see it in her eyes that she is actually considering joining.

Adora is waiting silently. The shed does not have a source of light; it is pretty dim and grey in there with the door half closed, beams of

sunlight only breaking through the cracks. Tiny specks of dust are floating between them in the air; they remind Adora of Catra's cute freckles.

"Is that all you guys do in your free time?" Catra asks. "That soccer tennis thing?"

"*No*," Adora says. "We also go out Saturday nights."

Catra gasps.

"After curfew? You're such rebels."

"What can I say? Your bad girl act rubbed off on me."

Catra opens her mouth like she was going to say something. Whatever it was, she decided to swallow it down and turn her back towards Adora. She leans back down, packing a bag full of mesh jerseys into a bigger bag.

Adora licks her lips.

"Sooo. You coming?"

Catra sighs.

"Sure, why not." She peeks back at Adora with a hungry twinkle in her eye. Adora must just hallucinate that Catra wiggled her butt a little bit. "You could use a devastating defeat, hotshot."

*

Adora *is* starting to suffer a devastating defeat, although Bow and her were winning for the first part. They decided to go for eleven scores, and Glimmer and Catra are already on their tenth.

Now it is Adora's turn to serve. She decides to spice it up: she starts it with a rainbow kick, showing off to overcompensate. It does not distract the enemy as much as she had hoped.

"Left!" Catra yells, gesturing to Glimmer .

Glimmer moves quickly , passing the ball to her with her knee. Catra kicks it in a low angle above the net, making it spring up at the end of Adora and Bow's side. Adora rushes behind and is barely able to reach and touch it with the tip of her foot before it flies out of the court. She aims it high for Bow to head. Glimmer's foot catches it easily on the other side, sending them a final strike. The ball hits the ground by the sideline and springs out of the field.

"We won!" Glimmer cries out and leaps to Catra. She hugs her tight, smearing a kiss on Catra's cheek. Catra makes a grimace; her victorious smirk takes away the edge of her displeasure..

"Not bad, Sparkles," she says, leaning her elbow on Glimmer's shoulder. She looks at Adora when she says: "Who knew we'd make a pretty good team."

"Nice win, you guys," Bow says, voice full of pride. He peeks at Adora next to him and pokes her with his elbow. "Adora, what do we say?"

Adora wrinkles her nose.

"Congratulations," she grumbles.

"What was that?" Catra asks, blinking innocently. "Sorry , I didn't hear that."

"Me neither ," Glimmer says. "Could you repeat it, Adora?"

Adora does, a little less grumpy this time. When Catra starts laughing a moment later, loud and lively, Adora can feel the tension slipping away from her muscles.

Adora steps away to take the ball and holds it between her chest and bicep, squeezing. She is not giving up to even the odds out just yet.

"Let's do penalty kicks," Adora says. "Loser pays for the drinks tomorrow, even if they win the qualifying match."

"Who will be the keeper when you're up?" Glimmer asks.

"I will," Catra says, already staring at Adora before she even spoke.

Adora hums and accepts, mimicking Catra's expression as she stands tall next to her.

"Paying for everyone's drinks is a little extreme," Bow remarks gingerly. "Most of us are like, really broke."

Catra shrugs and walks closer to Adora, poking the ball out of her grasp and catching it mid-air. She spins it on her fingertip like a basketball, easily dodging Adora's attempts to steal it back.

"Three rounds," Catra says.

"T wo," Glimmer says.

"Three."

"Three for us, one for Adora because that'll roughly have the same affect."

Adora stops trying to steal the ball back, scoffing:

"I can drink!"

"Sure you can."

Catra laughs and puts her palm on the ball to stop it spinning. "Deal."

"Did you two just decide over our heads?" Bow asks.

"Y ep."

"Looks like it."

"Winners' choice."

"Losers will have to prove their worth to have a say in these matters."

" *Yes* ."

Catra runs back to Glimmer and the two of them start springing towards the soccer fields, still bathing in their glory and poking back and forth. Adora and Bow just watch them for a moment, Bow being the first one to say out loud what they are both thinking:

"They're *horrible* ."

"And now they *like* each other."

"We are so screwed." Bow pokes under Adora's ribs with his elbow. "Also do we have the same type?"

"I can't decide which one of them is worse."

"I can."

"Oh, hush, your girlfriend is not better than mine-" Adora turns her words into incoherent mumbling. She winces and decides to bolt too, raising her voice as she gets further away from Bow. " *Ex* . My *ex* girlfriend. I meant my ex girlfriend. Don't say a word. Don't look at me. I need to get my gloves. See you there. Bye."

*

Finally, Adora is winning.

She went for her own kicks first, handing Catra her treasured goalkeeper gloves. They're almost too big on Catra's hands, which Adora wants to comment on but decides not to. She is fine with basking in her silent endearment alone.

They decide to go for five kicks each. When Adora puts the ball down and backs away at an angle, Catra immediately says:

"Aren't you right-footed"?

Adora dries her sweaty palms on her shorts.

"I switch it up sometimes," she says.

Catra does not seem convinced, but she thankfully lets it go. She is standing in the middle of the goal, hands up, waiting for Adora to strike.

Adora jogs to the ball and kicks. Catra tried to catch the high kick but did not jump high enough; the tips of her fingers barely touched the ball Adora sent into the upper left corner. The net rustles triumphantly as the ball bounces down.

Catra kicks the ball back to her without saying a word.

Adora scores again. She chose the same spot to aim for, knowing damn well that Catra will expect a twist from her.

Catra throws herself to the opposite direction, landing in the grass. She staggers to her feet, hair ruffled and eyes shooting lightning. She dusts off the gloves by clapping, shaking her head so tufts of hair don't stick to her skin.

Bow and Glimmer cheer Adora on, which clearly annoys Catra even more. Adora contemplates her next kick, trying to figure out how Catra's mind works. If she knows her well - and Adora thinks she does, in this case - Catra is trying to get one step ahead of her, and she probably already is. Adora would change her ways by now, using this card once.

So she should go against her own mentality.

Adora kicks the ball towards the same spot for the third time. Catra had been waiting without moving around until the inside of Adora's foot touched the ball, jumping to the right direction. She manages to

flick the ball away but it bounces inwards off of the goalpost, and lands behind the line.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" Catra cries out, throwing her head back.

"Do you need glasses, Catra?" Adora asks.

Catra growls. She kicks the ball back harder this time, Adora is barely able to catch it before it hits her in the guts. Adora just chuckles and gets ready again.

Adora finally misses one. Catra kicks the ball out in a split. Adora compensates for it in the last round; she aims her kick close to the goalpost and Catra is too short to reach it even as she slips.

"Four out of five," Adora pants victoriously and Bow whistles.

"I'm next," Catra grunts through gritted teeth. She practically tears the gloves off as she walks to Adora and slams them to Adora's shoulder. "Let's see what got you into Nationals."

"How- how do you know about that?" Adora asks.

"Scorpia told me, I guess."

As Catra walks by her, Adora turns, trying to look at her face.

"I thought you said you didn't know I was gon-"

"Enough chatting, more playing," Catra cuts in as she finally looks back at Adora. Her expression is unreadable. "What, are you scared?"

"You wish," Adora says, putting her gloves on. She knows she is under Catra's skin now, and she will not let that advantage slip away from her.

Except what she heard made her own head spin. As she takes up her post, her thoughts roam free in her mind, too fast to keep up with them, urgent questions forming around one focal point, one very important variable.

Catra *knew* .

The ball whooshes by her, hitting the net. Adora straightens and yells:

"Hey , I wasn't ready!"

"Not my problem," Catra says and reaches out her hands for the ball, wiggling her fingers.

Adora throws it back.

The second and the third time she is more focused and defends well, fueled by playful revenge. Her competitive spirit is always out the roof whenever she is playing with Catra, and Adora almost forgot how *right* it feels.

The fourth time, Catra obviously cheats. Adora is waiting for her to get a move on, but Catra stays put, standing right behind the ball. She seems to be waiting for Adora to get confused and truly look at her, then Catra grabs the bottom of her top and uses it to wipe her neck. She is keeping Adora's eyes locked with hers; Adora's vision becoming unfocused. She registers Catra squeezing her belly in as she ties her top and lets the breeze dry her brown skin.

Adora swallows.

Catra always had more delicate features than Adora - two beautifully curved lines of muscle around her belly button, sunkissed skin gleaming with sweat, a narrow waist and boney hips and there is that goddamn trail again-

The attack is more sneaky than powerful. Catra kicks the ball nonchalantly with the inside of her foot, landing the ball dangerously close to Adora.

And still, Adora's last minute reflex can't defend it. Catra scores the last one too. Adora's face is burning red.

"Do you need glasses, Adora?" Catra asks, hooking a finger into the collar of her top. "Or do you enjoy the view too much already?"

Adora grumbles.

Bow is next, ending up with two scores. Glimmer is up last; Adora gets her head back in the game and defends the first two kicks with ease, letting herself be cocky about it again. Bow cheers Glimmer on and whispers advice in her ear.

Catra walked further away from them, now standing closer to Adora than Glimmer and Bow. Adora ignores the sharpness of Catra's seeking eyes boring into her; it makes her feel seen, too exposed, observed, hunted.

t happens at Glimmer's third turn.

Glimmer speeds up and kicks hard. She aims the ball in the lower corner, making Adora slip and slide. As soon as Adora hits the ground awkwardly, she feels a throbbing pain that pulses through her nerves like lightning.

Adora bites her lip, unable to stop a raspy grunt and a whimper to escape her. She stays down for a second, gloved fingers clawing into the grass, eyes growing wide. Her ponytail falls into her face, hiding her from her friends - not like it matters, since Bow picks Glimmer up and twirls her around as soon as the ball lands in the net.

Adora tries to calm her breathing. Her lungs are whistling.

"So we're done, right?"

Adora snaps her head up. Catra glances away when Adora props herself on her elbows.

"What, why? I still have two rounds left," Glimmer complains, hopping off of Bow's arm.

"What does it matter?" Catra snaps back, a little too rude. She changes her tone as she goes on: "We won the first time, Adora clearly won this. Even if you score on your last two turns, your boyfriend loses. Let's just wrap this up now. It's getting late."

"I guess that's true," Glimmer says, patting Bow on the shoulder. "Sorry babe, you're paying."

Bow lolls his head back, palms hiding his face from the world.

Adora staggers to her feet, clinging to the goal post and pulling herself up and out. She tries to put some weight on her leg, hissing quietly. She lets herself flop back down.

Catra is still hanging around; she turns her head away, but Adora knows she is watching her from the corner of her eye. Catra waits until Glimmer and Bow take their leave and turn their backs to her and Adora. Then, without a word, she offers a hand for Adora to take.

Adora accepts, relying on Catra's strength to fully help her up her feet.

"Thank you," Adora says. She takes a couple uncertain steps and sucks her lips in. Then, she tries a weak grin: "I landed so weird."

"Sure," Catra says and lets Adora's hand go. She turns on her heels and walks ahead, footsteps rustling in the grass. "Enjoy your win."

*

Adora cannot fall asleep.

The ghost of the pulsing pain is haunting her. She knows she cannot let anything like that happen again as long as she is here at camp. She was reckless, and cocky, and she is going to mess everything up if she does not keep it low and controlled.

Adora stumbled to the bathroom for the fourth time that night. She kept the lights turned off inside, not trying to disturb Catra. She mavouvers out of the bathroom by holding onto the door and gets back to the bed by memory. Her toe barely misses the edge when she feels the bed out; she straightens then and flops down onto the mattress hard, face first.

There is a heavy crack followed by a hollow thud. t all happens so fast Adora has no time to even sqeak.

Catra, on the other hand, screams and springs out of bed.

"Who do we kill!?" Catra jabbers and holds her phone out like a knife; the screen flashes up bright, showing her Adora accepting her fate, laying on the mattress sliding off of the broken bed frame.

Catra almost drops her phone. She wheezes and starts laughing, trying her best to speak through the waves of uncontrollable laughter.

"Adora- oh shit- are you -are you okay"?

Adora growls louder as a "ye s," her voice still muffled and lost in the pillow. Catra's laugh sounds even higher now , almost inaudible.

"Oh shit," Catra breathes again, drying her eyes with her index finger. "Oh this is good. How heavy are your muscles"?

Adora finally rolls off of the mattress, climbing across the broken bed frame. She sqints in the yellow light Catra's phone shines upon her .

Adora should have expected this to happen. Scorpia broke the other bed the same way last year; the camp only had money to buy one new bed in place of the broken one, despite all of them knowing replacements were very much needed.

Adora sighs and looks down at the damage. The frame completely broken in three, the mattress stuck between the pieces.

"I should text Glimmer ."

"Y eah, it's like-" Catra turns the screen towards herself for a second, "almost three. Let her sleep, well deal with this in the morning."

"Right. Y ou're right."Adora leans down, grabbing the mattress.

"What are you doing?"

"What does it look like?" Adora mumbles. "I'm getting my mattress out so I can go back to sleep."

Catra keeps quiet for a while, watching Adora's struggle.

"Don't be an idiot," she says then, quiet and low. When Adora looks at her with her eyebrows furrowed, Catra shrugs. "It's not like we've never slept in the same bed."

And with that, Catra turns around and locks her phone with a click. Adora waits until her eyes are used to the dark; she lets the mattress go and straightens her back.

"W ait, really?"

Catra sets her phone on the nightstand. She kneels on her bed and slips under the blanket, leaning on her elbow, propped up on her side. She grabs the corner of her blanket that's closer to Adora and raises it along with her right brow.

After a moment of hesitation, Adora practically leaps to the bed. She takes the blanket, fingertips brushing Catra's knuckles. Catra turns

her back to her while Adora is trying to get comfortable.

"Thank you," Adora whispers.

"Eh."

Adora is laying on her back, fingers laced together and resting on her stomach. Catra snuffles quietly next to her. Adora can barely hear the rumbling of the AC or the waves outside over the drumming of her own heart.

Adora's whole body feels itchy. She is afraid of moving and scratching, not wanting to make the bed creak and disturb Catra with that, or with her fidgeting. She is also sweating under the blanket that feels too heavy now. No, wait - a cold breeze sends a shiver up her spine. Her teeth clink together.

Minutes must pass. It still feels like tiny needles digging into her skin, and she cannot think of anything except for that and the fact that Catra is sleeping so close to her that she can feel her body's warmth.

Catra suddenly growls.

"What now?" she asks, voice husky with sleep.

"I didn't- I didn't say anything."

"I can feel how tense you are. And you're making weird noises."

She is? Adora is thankful for the dark, hiding how her cheeks grow burning red. She swallows hard.

"Sorry ."

Catra sighs. The next thing Adora knows, Catra's upper body is hovering above her, narrowed eyes boring into hers. Catra puts a hand next to Adora's head on the pillow, leaning on it. Adora lets her head roll to the side, her forehead bumping into Catra's wrist.

Thoughts escape Adora as soon as they touch, her fingers unlacing and curling into the blanket. She peeks up, still afraid to move in any other way. Something tugs on her stomach like she had reached the highest point before the drop on a rollercoaster.

"Catra?"

Catra lazily lays her body on top of Adora's. She nuzzles into the crook of Adora's neck, parted lips sliding across Adora's collarbone. Catra throws a leg over Adora's hips under the blanket and bends her knee, squeezing her close. Her hand rubs over Adora's stomach, a bit rough, fingers gripping her waist and tapping higher on her side.

Catra stills, then; Adora shivers and squeezes her thighs together.

"Relax," Catra says softly. "Okay?"

Adora's throat dries. She breathes out in a shaky little sigh, muscles tensing and relaxing under Catra's weight. Adora lets her arms wander closer, but never reaches; one over Catra's back, the other over her thigh. She can almost feel Catra's hair and warmth under her careful fingertips.

"Okay?" Adora asks.

Catra chuckles. She turns her head up, tip of her nose and upper lip pressed to Adora's neck now.

"Sure." The word vibrates in Adora's throat, sending - no, *throwing* - her over the edge.

Adora slides her palms on Catra's bare skin; the tips of her fingers barely slip under Catra's oversized shirt she wears to bed. Breaking that contact is a rush of heat and a stabbing pain low in her stomach, twisting into a whirl. Catra sinks her whole weight on Adora with a content sigh, moaning softly at Adora smoothing little circles into her skin.

It is surreal. Unreal. Adora is convinced that she is only dreaming, and not actually cuddling Catra - *that* Catra, ex-girlfriend Catra, used-to-be-hers Catra laying in the same bed as her after not hearing about her for years. She is suddenly aware of how full her heart feels, despite not realizing before that Catra's absence cut a hole into it.

And Catra smells so nice. The lemongrass shower gel mixes with the smoky scent of the men's deodorant she uses and the sweetness of her skin, the mint of her breath.

Adora is desperate for more. She swallows dry, both her hands slide higher on Catra's outer thigh and up to her nape.

"Hey"...

There is no answer. Catra seems to be fast asleep once again, leaving Adora alone in the dark with her aching want and the guilt blooming immediately from it. She draws her hands back.

Catra makes a tiny noise of complaint in the back of her throat and nestles against Adora. She clings to her tight even in her sleep, snoring so softly it sounds like purring.

Adora closes her eyes and very gently turns a bit towards Catra, making sure she is not waking her up.

She throws an arm over Catra and focuses on Catra's snuffling, the rhythm of her chest rising and falling slowly under Adora's arm. She burrows her nose into Catra's hair; she breathes in her scent, keeping it in her lungs as long as she can before it burns and chokes her.

Adora's heart, feverishly beating before, slows down in sync with their breathing.

She falls asleep.

saturday

Adora awakes with a little jump. She immediately forgets what she was dreaming about, but her arm is slippery with cold sweat and her legs under Catra's thigh have become numb.

Adora does not seem to mind any of it. She peeks out from Catra's hair, blinking heavily; Catra is laying on her side, facing Adora, lips slightly parted. So that part was not a dream.

Watching someone else in their sleep obviously gets very creepy very fast, so Adora only gives herself a couple moments to appreciate the girl in her arms.

Catra has not changed much, from as much as Adora remembers her, that is. Of course, she put the photos of her into a shoebox and hid it under her bed, not dwelling on the past like that, as a good romcom heroine. The pictures online, she cannot always ignore. She found Catra on Instagram once, a couple years back, but Catra was barely using it. Adora's fingers were itching to dm her and say… well, she did not know what she should say. She had nothing. But she also did not want to just tap follow, like a couple new posts and wait for a miracle to happen. She decided to sleep on it, only to wake up to realize that Catra had either deleted it or changed her username just like she *knew* , and was still trying to run away from her.

Adora draws her arm back from Catra's back to stroke her arm with the back of her hand. Catra squirms but breathes out in a content moan. Adora holds her by the waist now, lightly tugging closer, her eyes flickering between the seas of freckles covering Catra's face, her chapped lips and makeup-smudged eyelids.

Catra squeezes her eyes a bit like she would want to dismiss a bad thought. The motion attracts Adora's glance, now focused on how Catra's eyelashes are still, like, ridiculously long. She used to run her thumb over them, pressing soft kisses on them; Catra always looked up so her eyelashes tickled Adora's lips, making her laugh and try to pin Catra down on the bed-

Catra fidgets again, then blinks sullenly. Her hazy eyes find Adora and focus on her, luring her in and locking her up. Before Adora could say anything, Catra cups her face and nuzzles close, kissing the corner of Adora's mouth.

Adora's whole body freezes. Catra's eyes are still foggy for a second, then they quickly clear up; the sleepy bliss rushes out of Catra's face just like her blood, followed by pure dread. She pushes herself away, too far away, and she crashes down from the bed with a shrill yelp. She takes the blanket with her too, pulling it off of Adora.

"Catra?"

Adora grabs the edge of the mattress, peeking down at Catra. Her lungs tighten up as she watches Catra squirm and wiggle furiously, trying to untangle herself from the blanket that wrapped her up like a burrito.

Adora bursts out laughing, her hair falling into her face. This feels like a delicious payback for Catra's entertainment last night. As soon as Adora snorts unattractively between chuckles, Catra stops thrashing and lets her shoulders drop, watching her strangely.

Adora combs fingers through her hair, smoothing locks behind her ear. She catches her breath again, smiling down at Catra. She reaches her hand out.

"Come on."

Catra clicks her tongue but takes it. Adora slides closer to the edge, dropping her feet to the floor and spreading her knees. She holds Catra's hand with one hand, and peeling her out of the blanket with the other. When she is done and Catra rises to her feet with Adora's help, Adora is not letting her hand go.

Catra squints at her. Adora replies by squeezing her hand and pulling her between her knees. She uses her hand to make Catra lean down so Adora can reach her cheek. She presses a little peck on Catra's freckles, lips lingering a second longer than necessary.

There.

Catra slaps Adora's hand away, turning on her heels to hide her face. Adora does not mind; Catra's slap was weak, almost playful, and she can still see how red her ears are burning. Adora leans back on her elbows, sprawling out on the bed, watching her.

"You're such an idiot."

"Yeah," Adora chuckles and tilts her head to the side. "Wanna shower?"

Catra turns back to her, drawing her shoulders up defensively.

"What? No. What are you-"

Adora's voice is dripping with smugness.

"Like, first."

Catra slaps her own temples, nails scratching her scalp. She pulls them across her face then, growling deeply. "I'm going to kill you."

"Right. Can I shower first?"

"Go shower!" Catra screams into her hands.

Adora chuckles again and gets out of Catra's bed half-heartedly, glancing back at the two close dells their bodies have left on the crumpled pillow and sheet.

She already misses Catra's warmth. She takes a hot shower, inhaling the heavy steam, letting the water drops swim with the sweat.

t is still not the same.

*

The qalifying matches are at ten in the morning. Both matches held at the same time, on the two adjacent fields, Adora can trust that she will not be distracted by Catra.

Team Grayskull is up against Bright Moon, while the Garnets go to battle against the Arrows.

Adora waves the kids around her. When she's surrounded by a circle of gleaming eyes and wide grins, she leans down and reaches her hand out. Once by one, the kids join her.

"What do we fight for?" She yells joyfully, and the kids scream in unison as they throw their hands up:

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

"Whoo!" Adora cheers again, then straightens and claps her hands. "Alright guys, two laps around the field. Take your time and watch your breathing. Slowly. *Slowly!* You need your energy for the game!"

She is getting some cones ready to continue the warm up once everyone is finished. She turns around to face Catra, who is guiding her team towards the farther field where the Arrows are already doing some jumping jacks.

Catra catches her eyes, nodding sharply.

"Good luck," Adora says.

"We don't need luck," Catra says. She holds her smile for Adora, stepping closer so she is the only one hearing her whisper: "Don't you dare lose. I want to kick your ass next week."

"Don't worry about that." Adora crosses her arms. "Worry about your own ass. And me, kicking it before you could."

Catra sighs.

"You always ruin it."

*

Just like Adora and Catra had planned, Team Grayskull and the Garnets won the qualifications, both of them winning by two. Adora's team scored three while Catra's only did two, which Adora cannot wait to rub in her face. They all shepherd the kids back to the dining bungalow for lunch, Catra's team leading the others.

Adora reaches out both arms and lets Flutterina hang on her as they walk, Adora occasionally spinning, earning her a joyful laugh. The others take their turns as well until Adora can barely walk under the weight of four children clinging to her like little giggling sloths.

By the time they have seats at the coaches' table, Catra had disappeared. Adora could say nothing to Glimmer's question about Catra's whereabouts; she did not notice when she disappeared into thin air. Which is what she does, apparently.

After lunch, the coaches let the kids be taken care of by counselors so Adora parts ways with them as well as her friends. She checks the parking lot first - Catra's motorcycle is not there.

Adora is walking around in their bungalow; while she was content and fine with being alone until Catra had arrived on Sunday, Adora was getting really used to and comfortable with her hanging around.

She liked having her to come back to after the early workouts, her sleeping face always being the first thing she sees. She liked welcoming Catra back after her jogs. She liked her presence, her scent lingering around when she gets out of the shower. The scent Adora is all too familiar with now, and craving deeply.

Adora is listening to the racket outside; the water splashing and the kids laughing and screaming. She usually joins her team on beach days.

Hours pass, and it is almost dinner time.

Adora wishes she could text Catra, but she does not know her number. Maybe her old one, back from high school. Should she try and text that? No, wait - Glimmer has it.

When Adora fishes her phone out of her back pocket and tries to flop down on her bed, she stops herself at the last moment, stuck in an awkward, aching squat. Right. The bed. Which she should also tell Glimmer.

Invading Catra's space when she is not here feels wrong, so Adora drops herself on the floor instead. She crosses her legs and unlocks her phone in her lap.

Best Friend Squad

Adora

Glimmer, can you send me Catra's number?

Glimmer

yea why

nvm i dont want to know

hold on 😊

shes still not back?

Adora

Thanks

No, Ihavent seen her since the game

Bow

its not unlike her to disappear ¯_(ツ)_/¯ im sure she is fine adora dw

Adora

Iknow

Ijust wanna ask her something

Bow

mmmhmmm

(youre so worried tho)

Before Adora could object, Catra's number pops up in Glimmer's next text. Adora can see Glimmer furiously typing something, and there are five more pings after, but Adora is already in another tab.

Catra

Hey, are you okay?

wrong number

This is Adora. Hi!:)

wrong number, adora

CATRA

im fine

busy

needed something or?

ust wanted to know if youre okay . Sue me.

will do. gotta finish up here fist.

Hilarious

Will you be bsck soon?

yeah ill be bsck.

Dont.

dont go bsck? thought you missed me.

t was ONE typo. One.

setting your name as hollabsck girl now.

Shut up

Will you be back by the time we leave?

adora chill

ill try but ill probably meet you there if i wont be too tired

dont wait up

Okay. Were going to the Seaworthy bar downtown.

k

See you there?

She gets no answer.

*

"We're calling a Lyft," Glimmer says, furiously poofing her hair up with a comb. She tilts her head in front of the mirror then, checking her highlighter. "Wanna come with us?"

Adora is laying on Bow's bed (technically, it's the same as Glimmer's - they pushed them together), legs straight and ankles crossed, checking her notifications every twenty seconds.

Bow busies himself with trying to find something to wear in the dresser while Glimmer monopolizes the bathroom. The air is heavy with at least six different products from perfume to hair spray to deodorant. Adora finds the mixture less appealing than what her room with Catra smells like.

"No, it's fine. I'll drive Darla."

"Are you sure? We don't have to split, I've got you covered."

"I'll maybe have one drink anyway," Adora says, head propped up with Bow's pillows. She clicks her phone locked for the fiftieth time.

"I thought you could drink," Glimmer comments slyly. She brushes some more highlighter on the tip of her nose.

Adora makes a miserable little sound at the back of her throat.

"I can. Badly ."

"Don't you dare say you'll leave early just because she's not coming."

"Who?"

"Don't try to play dumb," Glimmer warns her. She leans to the doorframe, pointing her brush accusingly at Adora.

"You know we can see how you look, right?" Bow adds, getting more and more desperate with his own appearance as he tries to find a shirt that goes with his denim shorts.

Adora scoffs as she sits up ungracefully.

"I have no idea what you are talking about. I always look like this."

"Adora, if I had a dollar for every time you wear mascara, I would have starved to death."

"And you're in a dress. A dress! Scandalous."

"And your hair, like, whoa. Which was a more devastating breakup, Catra or the hair poof?"

"Sweetheart," Bow says quietly as he peeks at Adora's face.

Glimmer moans regretfully.

"Sorry , Adora. I shouldn't have said that. It was a stupid joke."

Adora tries to swallow the lump in her throat.

"It's fine," she says. "Good one."

She feels Bow and Glimmer share a look rather than seeing it. Before they could say anything to make the situation worse, Adora speaks up again, grinding a lock of hair between her fingers.

"I won't bail on you just because she's not coming. I guess I'm just more tired than I thought I was gonna be. Not in the mood for staying out late."

"And that's okay," Bow says, pulling a white crop top over his head. It muffles his words. "We just wanna make sure you're having fun."

"I am," Adora says. Her smile is genuine. "Couldn't feel better with best friends looking like you two."

Glimmer's nose is pink on itself now, without the blush she smeared on. She sits down on Adora's left, while a now fully clothed Bow takes the spot on her right.

"And you look breathtaking," Bow says, his arm thrown over Adora's shoulder, patting her bare back. Glimmer pins in the half-embrace.

"You truly do. I'm sorry for making fun of it earlier. I really love this look on you. And I'm sure Catra will-" Adora freezes under Glimmer's arm so she quickly changes routes from whatever she was going to say: "Be fine. Where she is."

Bow mouths "good save" over Adora's head. Adora buries her face in her hands.

"Are you finally ready to go?" She mumbles. "You both said five minutes but we've been stuck here for an hour."

"It was barely twenty minutes!"

"And you can't put a timetable on looking good."

"Speaking of," Glimmer says with a devilish smile on her face, drawing her round shoulders up. "You should totally let me touch up your makeup."

Adora ducks out of the embrace and spins around to stand up, facing them.

"No," she says, her face growing as white as her maxi dress. "Not a chance."

"C'mon Adora," Bow says. "Y ou know she's a professional."

"I wont do anything you don't like," Glimmer promises. "Please? You trusted Bow with your laptop, how's this any dif ferent?"

"Right, how's the internship with Dryll?" Adora jumps on the topic change, but Bow does not play along.

Instead, he stands up and comes next to Adora again, with Glimmer following suit. They circle Adora like sharks tasting blood in the water.

"Give me ten minutes." Glimmer grabs Adora's arm softly. "I know what you want. Trust me."

Adora contemplates for a minute, chewing on her lower lip. Glimmer does do a wonderful job, not just on herself - and has her portfolio and thousands of hundreds of Instagram followers to speak for her. Adora had only let her touch her face once, when Glimmer did a test round for Scorpia and Perfuma's wedding. Adora did not hate that bridesmaid look; with the peach dress Perfuma got for her, the general impression was definitely Adora, just dif ferent.

Is that not exactly what Adora wants her to see tonight?

"Fine. You have seven minutes. *Seven* . Then we're leaving before the bar closes."

*

Adora stops the truck at the side of the bar and leaves the lights on. She tilts the rear-view mirror down so she can see herself and turns her head to both sides, observing herself with an analytical squint.

The flickering neon lights of the bar are flashing on her face and Darla's windshield. The summer rain is drizzling in specks, barely noticeable.

f she did not know what Glimmer had done, she probably would not notice herself. Glimmer kept her promise; she only softened the outlines of Adora's brows and eyelids that she had messed up, touched on the angle of Adora's high cheekbones and put a hint of rosy color on her lips.

She looks like herself... when she has a fever. But like, in a weird, good way. How the makeup makes her eyes glisten and her lips look full and warm from the gloss, and there's a dash of color on her skin.

Adora makes a couple faces, testing the grimace-proofness of the makeup. Then she gently slaps both her cheeks a couple times. No smudges or cakey-ness. Adora hums.

She takes her trusted fanny pack and gets out of the car as soon as her friends' Lyft turns into the wooden-railed parking lot.

*

Adora flops back into the booth and puts a bizarre cocktail in front of Glimmer that seems to be radiating in the dark. Bow follows Adora, hands full with his own rainbow drink and Adora's Spritz

The Seaworthy bar looks roomy but is actually pretty cramped. The inside looks like a galleon's; ratlines and sails hanging from the walls, masts stand high by the counter, the coatroom and the bathroom. The dance floor is at the lowest level, functioning as the main deck; the tables and booths all stand higher around it, connected together by wooden stairs.

Glimmer booked them a booth on the highest floor, the sterncastle deck at the back of the bar. They can see the whole place from here, which is probably Adora's favorite part.

"There aren't that many people here," Adora says, hooking a finger into the tight neck of her dress and tugging on it. "It's still so hot."

Glimmer points at Adora's drink with her chin.

"Refresh, dance, refresh."

Adora shakes her head. She can hear her own voice emptily as she raises it to talk over the music.

"One round for me, remember?"

"With water, Adora," Glimmer says and takes a sip of her drink. Her face brightens at the taste and she pushes the glass in front of Bow. "Babe, taste this."

"Ooh, I hoped you'd offer!" Bow says and in exchange, slides his own cocktail for Glimmer.

They take the straws and lean in in sync, sharing a soft glance over the drinks.

Adora stirs her drink pensively. She leans on her elbow, resting her chin in her palm. Third wheeling her best friends when they are actually together is honestly not as different than when they both had obvious crushes on each other. Still, she always had someone else with them, with whom she could hang out and talk to, when Glimmer and Bow got too lost in each other's presence.

Adora entertains herself by people-watching, her gaze scanning the crowd on the dance floor and by the counters. She thinks she sees Seahawk and Mermista dancing, but she is not sure; the main deck is full of swirling dry ice and blinding flashes of lights.

Her glance slides further, close to the main entrance that is decorated with a siren figurehead cut in two by the wall;one can only see its tail and the foamy waves from inside.

Adora is chasing the straw with her mouth, trying to catch it with the tip of her tongue. When she finally does, after struggling with it for moments too long, she takes a long sip. The front door opens at the same time and a familiar figure saunters in, hands in her pockets, looking around.

Adora immediately chokes on her Spritz, almost inhaling the straw with it too.

She is still coughing violently when the newcomer notices her and bares her teeth.

Adora is so screwed.

Chapter End Notes

Check out this too beautiful to be true illustration by @blueberry-ghost! I am so in love with this, thank you so so much. ♡

CHAPTER 2 BABEY WHAT DO WE THINK
Thank you so much for reading, subscribing, and leaving lovely comments. I truly appreciate each and every one of you, and I hope you enjoyed the second chapter! If you did, please let me know, I love hearing from y'all. ♡
These two were the ones already half-done, so from now on, please be patient with me with updates. I will try my best to keep up and post the next one soon!

If you enjoyed reading, please consider supporting the fic by sharing my post about it!

Thank you for the wonderful beta work, @notterrible
Find me on Tumblr as @e-ra

See you soon! Until then, feel free to hang out with me on Tumblr. x

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

h which things get messy , and a secret is revealed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is so screwed.

She turns in her seat so as to not spill Spritz on her dress, but it is not that easy to do while trying her best not to suffocate. She grabs a handful of napkins from the table and dries the top of her dress furiously.

Glimmer cocks her head.

"What the hell has gotten into-" Her glance finds the newcomer stepping to their table, and her voice falters. " -*you* ."

"Hey ," Catra says and leans on the table with both hands. Obviously she is not wearing a bra under her half-open button-up shirt. Adora nearly drops the napkin, holding onto it for dear life.

"Hi,"she croaks, voice still husky from coughing.

Adora peeks at her friends; Glimmer is, well, *staring* , so they have lost her. Bow is simply just oblivious and very cheerful to see Catra:

"Hey to you too!Im happy you made it."

" bet," Catra says, swinging her hips to the side. "Ready for my first round when you are."

"Right," Bow says, hopping up from his seat. "Do you know what you'd like"?

I'll go with you before you even try to order me anything like you're drinking."

Glimmer has to stand up and slide out to give Bow space. When he gets out, Glimmer flops back down next to Adora. She watches Bow and Catra leave for the bar and turns back to Adora just in time to see her fish the straw out and chug her whole cocktail down.

"Yep, that's wise," Glimmer says.

Adora forces the last drops down with her head thrown back and mouth twisted. She smack her lips and yells after Bow quickly:

"Can you get me another one please? I'll V enmo you."

Bow and Catra both turn their heads back, Bow saluting so Adora knows he had heard her. Catra's glance slides to the empty glass and back to Adora's face with the most shit-eating grin Adora has ever seen. Adora stares back without blinking until Catra turns again and descends the stairs, following Bow's lead.

"You okay there?" Glimmer asks carefully, reaching out for Adora's shoulder. Adora jerks herself away defensively before Glimmer's fingertips could reach her.

"Sure," she says firmly. "I just realized that, uh, straws. They're bad for the environment. I'm not condoning using them and um, largening my cartoon footprint."

"Your *carbs* mmh." Glimmer inhales slowly through her nose and mumbles to herself: "This is gonna be a long fucking night."

Adora can sense that she has not convinced Glimmer enough. Should she eat the straw to demonstrate her dedication? No, she really should not. Would it be bad though? It is just a paper straw. Paper is fibre. Humans need that.

Adora gets her phone out to send Bow the money and to have something else to do other than eating the straw to make a point. When she's done, Bow and Catra are already back; Bow's phone buzzes in his shorts with the Venmo notification.

Instead of making Glimmer stand up again, Bow takes her place at the left edge of the booth. On the other side, Catra knocks on Adora's shin with her leather dance shoes, scooting her further into the booth and sliding next to her. Adora obeys without thinking.

Catra puts Adora's drink in front of her. It looks a bit different than before, with a dash of bright yellow and the orange deeper at the bottom.

"Thanks," Adora says.

"What are you drinking?" Glimmer asks Catra, leaning forward in her seat to see better.

Catra twists the glass in her hand and stretches her free arm along the backside of the booth. She draws her leg up too, ankle resting on her knee.

"Rum and coke." She takes a sip. The ice cubes clink to the glass. "I don't like fancy shit."

"Clearly," Glimmer snorts, then jumps as Bow pokes her between the ribs.

Adora pulls her drink closer and sniffs it. It is definitely not Spritz. Suddenly, Adora remembers Catra's pranks all too well. She used to be on the suffering side more times that she can count.

"What did you put in it?" She asks accusingly, squinting into the long glass like she could see its particles if she tries hard enough.

"Seriously, Adora?" Catra sighs, holding her drink to her heart. "It's just a little gift from me to you. An offering of peace, if you will. You're

not gonna reject the gesture and offend me, right?"

Adora knows a challenge when Catra presents her one. She shoots her one last glare inches away from the straw and takes a careful sip.

Okay. Okay, it is delicious. And probably way too strong for her because she tastes no alcohol.

"What's this?" She asks.

"Sex on the Beach."

Adora nods, pouting.

"It's really good."

"Wouldn't know," Catra says, tilting her head. "I've never had it."

Adora hurries to offer politely: "Wanna try?"

"Whoa there, Adora. Maybe buy *me* a drink first."

Adora snorts loudly, her grin wide and bright. Her cheeks and neck warm up in the spur of the moment as she slaps Catra's shoulder and shoves her away a bit.

"What are you, five?"

"I know you want to laugh."

"I don't."

"You want to."

"It's not funny at all."

"I'm hilarious and you know it."

"You mean ridiculous?"

Glimmer clears her throat. Adora jerks her head towards the sound, Catra following her lead lazily. Glimmer and Bow stand by the table hand in hand, their empty glasses in front of them.

"We're going dancing for a bit," Bow says. "Can we leave Glimmer's bag with you guys?"

Adora feels just a tiny jolt of panic at the thought of being left alone with Catra while she is not entirely sober.

"Sure. Have fun!"

"Dance so I'd be proud of you."

"We're not trying to get arrested," Glimmer says.

Catra raises her glass and winks. Glimmer rolls her eyes with a grin, sliding her arm around Bow's and pulling him towards the dance floor.

The bass is thrumming in Adora's ears as she takes another sip. She licks her lips; they taste like peach and coconut. She wonders if Catra would like it.

Catra rests her arm behind her, hanging her hand down. She is just a breath away from Adora's skin; the silent promise is more than enough to make her shiver.

Adora sips again. The warmth of the cocktail in her throat and chest calms her more than she thought it would. Instead of waiting for Catra's next move, she leans back to her touch and turns to her-

... *And* she has nothing to say.

She has a lot of ideas about conversation starters, but none of them sound good enough. Adora feels like she wants to know too much; Catra would probably not answer her questions about where she had

been today, or what has happened to her since the last time they saw each other. Even if she would, Catra would be vague about it and defensive.

Catra's fingertips smooth the skin around Adora's vertebrae, her index sliding up her nape.

"You're tense again," Catra says nonchalantly.

"I'm glad you made it."

Catra pulls her hand back like she had touched fire and averts her gaze. In a flash of bright, white light from the strobes, Adora can see the tip of Catra's nose turning the color of her carmine shirt. It probably encourages Adora more than it should and so she lets herself look just a little bit; her glance drops to Catra's neck, following the lines of her collarbones and between her breasts, falling further to the belt of her skinny sailor pants.

Catra pushes her foot off her knee and crosses her legs as a warning, Adora believes. Looking back to her face, she thinks otherwise; Catra draws back her hand from behind Adora and presses her knuckles to her mouth, her perfectly arched brows knot.

Shit. She is too cute.

"Sorry," Adora says instinctively, but her voice gives her away.

Catra clicks her tongue, then runs the tip across her teeth. She finishes her drink and stands up, holding the glass with only the tips of her fingers.

"Where are you going?"

"I need to pee," Catra says, still not looking at Adora. "If you don't mind."

Adora holds her hands up. She unlocks her phone when she is alone and checks a handful of notifications; she taps on the first one from

hstagram. Glimmer tagged her in a photo the three of them took in her and Bow's bungalow. t is a basic mirror selfie with Glimmer and Bow making a peace sign and Adora grinning with her eyes closed.

Adora double taps on it, and sees the little icon of a new follower. She opens it, and her eyes widen.

Catra followed her. She actually has a new username, different from the one Adora found years back; the profile is still the same, though, and she had not posted enough pictures that Adora cannot scroll through the whole feed with two flicks of her thumb. There are only three new ones - the latest is a professional still from Scorpia and Perfuma's wedding, Catra wearing a tux, standing by Scorpia's side. "best woman of the best woman i know . congratulations, idiots. 👯"

Adora tastes bile at the back of her throat. She tries to wash it down with her cocktail and scrolls to the next post.

t shows two photos saved from Snapchat; they are of the same greyish kitten, the first one taken of it in a cage with a caption "this bitch wont stop screaming at me." Adora swipes right to the second picture; the kitten is sunbathing on the dashboard of a car now, the caption reading "update: shes mine now and i would kill for her."

Adora clicks her tongue affectionately and scrolls down to the third post. t is a simple close-up selfie of Catra; she is laying in bed, her face half-lit by the sun. t paints her hazel eye burning gold, and the shadow dims the blue of her other iris deep like the night sky. The perfect angle of her winged eyeliner is sharp as a knife, much like tonight. Her freckles pop out adorably, and the flirty smirk on her brown lips is a direct attack on Adora's heart. She is in the middle of growing her hair back out, shoulder-length curly tufts slicked back by a red bandana. She is wearing a choker and dozens of tiny piercings in both ears. The caption is just a dot.

Adora forgets herself and stares at her screen probably way too long, because she only notices the real Catra arriving back at the booth when she is dangerously close. Panicking, Adora's thumb taps

on the screen as the phone jerks in her hand before locking the device quickly. She is praying to all the gods that she did not like it accidentally and slaps the phone screen down onto the table.

Catra barely sits at the edge of the seat and does not turn back towards the table. She rests her chin on her shoulder and points to Adora's half-empty glass with her thumb.

"Drink up, princess. You took yourself to the ball but I still wanna dance with you."

Adora snorts too loudly. "*'Princess'*?

Catra grins and flicks Adora's dress. Adora grunts playfully:

"Okay, okay, I get it. I don't know why I'm wearing it either."

"Really?" Catra purrs. "I was sure you wanted to match again."

And with that, Adora gets it. Her white dress with the golden striped summer sandals and her loose hair; Catra's color choices and the untamed high ponytail; the realization is a ball of sparking fire in her abdomen, bursting into her veins like fireworks.

They both look so much like they did at their senior prom.

Catra laughs.

"You should see your face. You really didn't realize, did you?"

"I would have gotten it," Adora says firmly. Then adds, much weaker: "Eventually. And just so you know, I wasn't planning it."

Catra says nothing.

Adora's second cocktail slides up the straw and down her throat till the last drop, its flames dousing the ones she felt because of Catra. She squeezes her eyes together for a second.

The heels of Catra's shoes knock on the wooden floor. When Adora peeks up, Catra reaches out her hand.

"You coming?"

Adora takes it. Her skin feels much warmer than Catra's fingerless leather gloves.

Catra helps her up and squeezes her hand. Adora cannot help but smile; then, something comes to her mind and she draws her hand back.

"Wait, wait."

Adora dives behind the table and grabs Glimmer's tiny, clear handbag, throwing it on her shoulder. She also takes her fanny pack, shoving her phone inside and buckling it on her waist. As she turns back, she faces Catra staring at her, quite literally biting the tip of her tongue.

"I want to say so many things."

"But you won't," Adora warns her and without thinking, she laces their fingers and bumps Catra's shoulder with hers.

"Because I'm secretly so nice?"

"No, you're a mean brat. But you don't want to miss your chance at dancing with me."

"If I knew booze makes you even cockier, I would have cut you off sooner."

Adora just shakes her head, smiling ear to ear. She pulls Catra towards the dance floor, taking the lead. She is surprised Catra lets her guide her down to the lowest floor and turning towards her, she takes a couple steps backwards and pulls her into the pulsing crowd.

Adora puts her hand on Catra's nape, dropping it down to the small of her back. Catra grabs Adora's waist in return, tugging firmly. Their bodies fit together perfectly.

Catra runs her hand through Adora's hair and uses her palm to guide her head closer. Like this, Catra can speak into her ear as she raises her voice over the drumming noise:

"Is that your fanny pack bulging or are you just happy to see me?"

Adora laughs into Catra's hair. Her scent is maddening this close; for a second, biting into the spot right under Catra's ear crosses her mind.

" *Easy.* "

Catra keeps quiet and moves her hips, her hand guiding Adora to follow her. Adora reluctantly draws back and pays close attention to Catra's every move, mimicking them nearly perfectly. She enjoys dancing but when she is left unsupervised, she is usually clumsy and awkward; meanwhile, Catra could whip out full choreographies from her back pocket any time, to any song. Relying on her is the only way Adora can avoid any catastrophes.

Catra bends her knees a bit and turns her hands down, running them lower to Adora's thighs; as they come back up, her nails crumple Adora's dress, making it slip higher on her shins, showing more skin.

"That's familiar," Adora says before she could stop herself. She spins quickly to the beat to hide her face of regret.

Catra stops Adora as she's facing away, pressing her chest to Adora's bare back and takes a handful of the dress now; her other hand comes back up from her waist, rubbing across Adora's navel, fingers spread. Adora leans the back of her head on Catra's shoulder while Catra's hips invite Adora's to sway with them as she releases the skirt after a slow, tentative pull.

"I think I like this dress," she muses.

Before Adora can think of anything clever to strike back with, the song ends. Neither of them move in the seconds of heavy and sudden silence, Adora feeling the pressure of Catra's heaving chest on her skin. The next song starts with a familiar beat; it is a hit that used to be Adora's favorite song in the world but which Catra absolutely despises. It was played all over their senior prom and Catra made endless fun of Adora knowing (or believing she knew) the lyrics, singing every fits-too-well line to Catra.

Adora peeks over her shoulder, expecting Catra to grunt or roll her eyes. Instead, she finds her wearing a blank expression, the only emotion evident on her face the feigned confusion about Adora's stare.

Adora does not believe it one bit. She quirks a brow and turns on her heels. Catra finally shrugs and Adora starts jumping to the pop rock tunes, her hair and Glimmer's bag following her rhythm with a missing beat. She takes Catra's hands and twirls the both of them.

Adora feels the need to yell a comment way too loud: "You *just* went to pee, huh? I can't believe you remembered."

Catra sticks her tongue out, but cannot suppress her laugh as she watches Adora attempting to headbang to something that does not need to be headbanged to whatsoever.

Adora nods her head and sings along screaming. To her surprise, Catra joins in the chorus, only mouthing the words to Adora just like she used to back then, the two of them circling around each other and losing themselves to the song.

When the instrumental part hits, Adora releases Catra's hand and throws her arms up, her muscles flexing.

Catra's eyes flare up with something raw and familiar. She hooks an arm around Adora's chest, grabbing her arm.

As the song slows down, Catra is quick to put Adora's free hand on her shoulder, her own finding a comfortable place around Adora's waist again. Adora's singing fades; she springs herself at Catra and slots their bodies together in an all too eager impact. Adora manages to calm her tipsy heart and touches their foreheads together much softer. She closes her eyes and feels the tip of Catra's nose bumping into hers.

Her body is moving quicker than her mind can follow as Catra rocks them as one, Adora's dizziness making her stumble. Catra holds her safe and tight before her last strike; she spins and dips Adora, a steady hand on her back not letting her fall.

Adora draws her knee up instinctively, trapped between Catra's thighs. She knows opening her eyes is going to be the exact moment she loses to Catra, but she cannot help it; as their eyes meet, Catra makes the smallest, grinding ripple of her hips that almost feels accidental and leans in closer. It sends a sweet stab of greedy want between Adora's legs which disappears all too quickly when Catra brings her back up.

Adora is too giddy to stand straight. She clings to Catra as they spin off of the dance floor together, stumbling to the nearest vertical surface that happens to be one of the decor masts. Catra's back hits it first, Adora falling onto her. The song has sped up again, which neither of them seem to register.

Adora mumbles into the crook of Catra's neck, her palm squeezing Catra's shoulder:

"Shit, sorry . Sorry."

"You okay?"

"Yeah- you?"

"Yeah."

Catra's nails are digging into her scapulas when Adora grabs the mast and pushes herself away; but not too far away. She draws back so she can look into Catra's eyes, tasting her minty breath on her parted lips.

The song - their song - comes to an end. The silent break between two songs is ear piercing, Adora's ears ringing already. She breathes in deep, licking her dry lips before pleading:

"Can I-" She clips her words.

Catra raises her chin invitingly; her gaze, fixated on Adora's, slides down slowly as Adora's chest heaves again. Adora's hand crawls from Catra's shoulder to her neck, fingertips running along the sharp line of her jaw before settling there. "Can I ask you something?"

Catra tiptoes and whispers, just as breathless: "Yeah."

Adora swallows. The DJ is still babbling something into the speakers, giving Adora time to collect her courage and finally blurt out:

"Are you seeing anyone?"

Catra's glance springs up again as she stares at Adora blankly for some very long seconds. Then, she starts laughing; she drops her hands from Adora's back and rolls her shoulders away from the mast like she would just stretch them.

She mutters something to herself before her eyes find Adora's again, twinkling softly in the flashing lights of red and blue.

"No, Adora. I'm not seeing anyone."

Adora nods solemnly, lips pressed together. She lets go of the mast and clears her throat. She needs to regain all her strength to keep her legs from buckling under her.

"Me neither," she says, unprompted.

Catra tilts her head now and crosses her arms under her chest.

"You don't say."

There is a moment of silence before someone is yelling for Adora. They both turn towards the stairs and see Glimmer and Bow wave and rush towards them.

"There you are," Glimmer says huffily, holding out her hand for her bag.

"Sorry," Adora says, pushing the handbag off her shoulder and handing it to Glimmer. "I took it to keep it safe."

"I know, I know," Glimmer sighs. "I just panicked when you weren't at the booth."

"Really panicked," Bow adds.

Glimmer shoots Bow a dark glare for giving her away. She loops the strap on her arm and looks back and forth between Adora and Catra, narrowing her eyes suspiciously.

"So you two are dancing too?"

"Yeah," Catra says at the same time as Adora goes:

"No." They look at each other. Adora swallows dryly, shifting her weight from one leg to another. "Yeah, we were. Now we're not."

Bow hugs Glimmer from behind, resting his chin on the top of her head. Glimmer takes his hand and kisses his knuckle.

Bow asks:

"Wanna go back to the floor together? Catra, you have yet to see Adora trying to do the robot to every single song."

t works with everything!" Adora snaps defensively, fingers pressed to her temple. She exhales in a huff, panic rising in her chest. t makes her voice break a little bit. "Okay , anyway. You guys should go ahead. ll be at the bar . m parched."

Adora avoids looking at anyone as she rushes awkwardly round them, her fingers already on the ip of her fanny pack. She gets her credit card out in time as she arrives by the bar, slapping it down on the countertop.

"Give me a shot of something strong, please," Adora vaguely tells the barista, who nods and turns around with the card in hand.

Adora is gently kicking the bar with the toe of her sandal, chewing her skin by her nail. The barista knocks a golden glass of something in front of her. Adora holds the shot glass up and takes a deep breath. As soon as she is going to move it to her lips, someone from the right clinks their own glass to hers.

Adora stares at the stranger confused. They are insanely tall and lanky in their stilettos, wearing a black-green seqin dress and a sharp smile.

"Cheers," they say and take their shot, so Adora does the same.

Her throat is on fire. She hits her chest with her fist to suppress a cough, and tries to straighten as much as she can so she will not feel as small standing next to the stranger as she does now.

Her head feels light as a feather. She turns towards the figure, suddenly seeing double. They have been watching her with their elbow digging into their waist, waiting for attention so they can finally speak up:

"Hey , are you and kitten-face exclusive?" Adora frowns and stares up at them with confusion. They try again: "Monogamous, honey ."

"No, we're having fun," Adora objects, of fended.

"I mkay." They are drawling now, sharp nails digging into their palm. "Do you two date each other only, or are you in a relationship where you're allowed to flirt and be with other people?"

Adora's face is burning red, heat crawling up her ears.

"No, no, we're not- we're not in a relationship."

They glare at Adora in disbelief. "Does she know that?"

"Uh, yeah? She's single. So. You know."

They click their tongue and open their mouth to continue, when Adora feels a familiar touch on her shoulder.

"Hey, Adora?" She snaps her head back, facing Catra's unreadable expression. Catra lets go of her. "You okay?"

Adora pouts and gives one big overacted nod. "Totally."

"Hi," the stranger cuts in, showing off their unsettling grin. Catra does not even look at them as she says:

"Hey."

"I saw you on the dance floor." They say, leaning on the countertop. "Pretty impressive, but I can show you better."

"Can you."

"Wanna try a round?"

"You sure you're okay?" Catra asks again, her attention focused solely on Adora. Her tone is more strict now, with a touch of stubborn anger.

Adora looks at her and shoves Catra's shoulder playfully.

I'm peachy," she says and grins wide. "Don't worry about me. I just. I might get another one of this thing." She holds her empty glass up and shakes it.

If you say so." Catra turns towards the very patient stranger, and eyes them up and down. "Still down to dance?"

They narrow their eyes.

"Always, kitten."

"Fine." Catra steps away from Adora and turns on her heels, knowing that the stranger will follow her.

They do, saying goodbye to Adora with an elegant little wave. The crowd devours them, and Adora is left with the drumming in her ears.

She headbutts the counter then and growls loud enough that the barista raises her eyebrows at her. Adora rolls her head to the left and whines:

"Can I get another round of this, please? Thanks."

And rolls her head back down, nose pressed to the countertop oozing from alcohol. Catra was right. She is such a fucking idiot.

The lump in her throat is impossible to swallow, the taste of the shot crawling up her throat sourly. She thanks the barista for the next round again, and takes a little sip. It sticks in her mouth but she forces it down on the third try.

Her knee buckles under her so she climbs up into the empty bar chair next to her. She is moving completely out of sync with her body and a little voice in her head is screaming at her to stop.

She ignores it.

The shot goes down with the next gulp and it wants to come back immediately. Adora clenches her jaw and peeks behind her shoulder

to the dance floor. Thankfully, her hazy eyes cannot find Catra.

All she can feel is the burn in her chest, and still, she believes she should feel nothing. It is her own fault to mess up with Catra again, and if anyone does it better than her - which is ridiculously easy, apparently - she has no reason to feel this ping of jealousy. Not even jealousy, not quite - she is angry with herself, about her own incompetence.

It makes sense to her that others see how breathtakingly beautiful Catra is, and she deserves to be seen and appreciated. It just. Really, really, really sucks that she is not the one who can give that to her.

Adora hides her face in her palms, breathing out heavily.

Is this what she wore a fucking dress for?

*

She blacks out for the next hours. She remembers a couple bits and pieces. They had probably all happened.

sunday (technically)

"and left her unsupervised while I am grinding with someone I just met."

"Well Im fucking sorry, I didnt realize I came to babysit. Shes twenty-five, she should know her limits."

"Adora? Can you hear me?"

Adora snorts at Bow's worried question, waving her hand.

"Course I do. What's up?"

Someone, probably Bow, is holding her under her armpits while her legs shake like jelly.

"We're taking you home, okay? Do you feel sick?"

"No," Adora whines, and reaches out for the bottle of beer she remembers she left by her feet on the ground. Her hand grabs the air. "Who stole my drink?"

Glimmer's voice cuts into her high and frantic.

"You finished everything like half an hour ago!"

"Chill, Sparkles. The whole fucking town can hear you."

Glimmer is whisper-screaming something now, but all Adora can focus on are the warm little hands taking her ragdoll body from Bow. Her nose is filled with a familiar scent.

"Catra," she mumbles into something that feels like Catra's shirt. The outside is cold, unwelcomingly breezy, but Catra's chest is soft and warm. Adora closes her eyes and nuzzles into her neck.

"We're leaving, okay?" Catra asks gently, smoothing Adora's hair behind her ear. "You're totally shit faced."

"No," Adora says again, giggling faintly. "I wanna dance with you again."

There's a moment of silence. She feels Catra swallowing, then saying:

"How about I buy you a cheeseburger first?"

Adora perks up and needs to be held again as she tries to straighten. She could never get tired of Catra holding her.

"Really?"

"Yeah, really. Where's your keys? I'm driving."

Adora giggles again and bumps her hips into Catra's.

"In my fanny pack."

Glimmer jumps in again:

"You're not taking her back alone."

"I don't need your permission to do anything," Catra snaps back. Adora whimpers, upset about all the tension, so she calms her tone: "Look, you're right. I should have stayed with her. So I will now, okay? I'll get her home safe. You have my word."

After another long moment of silence, Catra says to Adora:

"Can I have your keys now?"

Adora fumbles furiously with the zip of her fanny pack, and manages to push her phone into Catra's hand. Then a pack of gum. Finally, Darla's keys.

"If anything happens to her-" She hears Glimmer's voice again.

"I know you're smarter than that," Catra says drily. Her voice is tired and sad, and it breaks Adora's heart. "So use your brain."

*

Rain pours on Darla's windshield, and every wipe comes with a loud creak. Adora feels like they are going at the speed of light, and she tries to maneuver the cheeseburger into her open mouth.

The bun is warm in her hands, sauce dripping down her arms. She takes a huge bite, moaning delightfully.

"You're the best thing that's ever happened to me," she babbles with her cheeks full.

Catra flips the turn signal on and grunts:

"Stop talking to your food."

Adora leans to her left, clearly offended:

"I'm not talking to that."

Catra peeks at her as she spins the wheel, nose scrunched. Her face is burning red.

"You have lettuce on your face,"she says.

*

Catra flicks the lights on in their bungalow. It is too bright and burning yellow, digging into Adora's skull. She squeezes her eyes shut, letting a broken noise of distress escape her throat.

They are both soaking wet; the walk from the parking lot to the bungalow in the pouring rain was not easy, especially since Adora was barely able to walk by herself and needed to be dragged along.

"You should clean yourself up," Catra tells her, and tries to peel Adora's arm off her shoulder. Adora clings to her even tighter.

"Adora."

"I'm fine," Adora grumbles, head lolling back. "I'm just gonna sleep now."

"You're full of burger sauce, dummy" Catra says, fighting back a laugh. "It's pretty ridiculous."

"Your face is ridiculous," Adora snaps back, then gasps with dread. She wants to cup Catra's face, shiny from the rain, but she is unaware of the vehemence of her moves and practically slaps her. "That's not true, your face is so pretty ."

Catra clicks her tongue and pushes Adora down to the bed. She keeps her steady by her shoulders, squeezing softly. "Don't make me wash you."

Adora quirks a brow and chuckles.

"Or what."

"I should have let Glimmer deal with you," Catra sighs. "I'll get you ready for bed but only if you do as I say. You will let me wash your face, then you'll change and go to bed. Deal?"

"Will you go to bed with me?"

"I literally can't sleep anywhere else, so."

"Okay ."

"Okay?"

"Okay ."

Catra nods sharply. She disappears behind the bathroom door, water running quietly from the tap. She comes back with a towel on her head for her own wet curls, and one dry and one soapy wet towel in her hands. She kneels in front of Adora and wraps her right hand in

the wet towel, rubbing Adora's face; the cloth scrubs a bit roughly, but Catra's touch is incredibly gentle as she smooths Adora's skin.

Adora closes her eyes, a faint smile on her face. Then, she jerks out of the blue.

"Where's your new friend?"

Catra draws the towel back.

"Who?"

"The one you danced with."

Catra exhales through her nose and takes Adora's hand now to run the towel across her arm.

"Dee? They found someone who'd pay for their drinks all night so they got rid of me pretty quickly."

"Oh," Adora says, way too relieved. She adds: "Sorry."

Catra laughs.

"For what? We were just dancing."

"They seemed cool."

"Yeah," Catra sighs nonchalantly, turning the towel to the clean side and taking Adora's other hand in hers.

Adora's vision gets hazy. Her throat tightens achingly and she swallows, trying to stop some stubborn tears pooling in the corners of her eyes.

Catra peeks up at her face when Adora starts to shake, the panic like lightning in her eyes.

"No, don't," she warns Adora, shaking her by the shoulder. "Not the sentimental drunk. Stop it."

"Why are you helping me?" Adora weeps, voice breaking. "I thought you hated me."

"I am starting to hate you now."

"I'm so sorry."

Catra moans miserably and puts the towel down next to her.

"Why the fuck are you sorry? Stop saying sorry for everything."

"I'm so- mm." Adora presses her lips together and gives Catra a thumbs up. Her tears are still flowing.

Catra takes the other towel now, drying Adora from the soap and the rain and her tears. By the time she reaches her head and rubs her hair rapidly with both hands, Adora is still sniffling a bit.

"Done," Catra says, pulling the towel down to Adora's shoulders. Adora's hair stands up and out like hay. "You look like a sexy scarecrow."

Adora finally giggles.

Catra staggers to her feet and grabs a tank top and basketball shorts from Adora's wardrobe. She pushes them into Adora's hand and fishes her own shirt from under her pillow.

"I'll go change in the bathroom. If you're done, just scream."

*

Adora jolts awake in the middle of the night. She gasps, her throat dry and her tongue sticking to the roof of her mouth. Pain strikes into her temples and through her leg. She whimpers.

She is laying on her side, facing her broken bed and the bathroom door. Her pulsing leg is dangling over the floor, cold sweat sticking to her skin.

Adora draws her leg back under the blanket and pushes herself up very, very slowly. The room is still rocking under her like a ship in a seastorm.

"You're not gonna barf, are you?" Catra asks raspily from under the blanket. She turns towards Adora much quicker than Adora is moving, and leans on her palms behind her back. Her hair falls into her face, big and fuzzy from the rain.

"No," Adora mumbles, shutting her eyes close. She presses her fingertips to her temple. "It's just. Ugh, my head."

"I left aspirin on the nightstand," Catra whispers. "And a bottle of water."

Adora combs her hair back from her face. She is fumbling with the cap of the water bottle and drinks a couple careful sips before reaching for the meds.

"Thank you."

"Take two."

Catra lays back down; this time, she faces Adora as she draws her legs up. Her knee pushes to Adora's thigh.

"Don't barf on the only bed we have left or I'm going to kill you."

*

Adora wakes once again, blinking slowly. It still looks grey outside for a moment, but as soon as she turns towards the window and the empty space next to her in bed, she sees that the blinds are still down. The rain keeps pouring outside, the drops quietly knocking on the window.

Her phone is buzzing on the nightstand. She grunts and waits until the ringing stops and takes the phone in her hand. Even before she unlocks it, she sees dozens of notifications from the group chat, and the missed call from Glimmer just now.

Adora squints and immediately changes the brightness on her screen. Then, she finally opens her messages.

✨ GlimMAH ✨ changed the group chat name to 💌 **Best Friend Squad** 💌 +**Catra**

AUG 9TH AT 2:36 AM

Catra

why am i here

✨ **GlimMAH** ✨

what do you think?

hows adora

are u home?

is she ok?

Catra

yea

✨ [illegible] ✨

[illegible]EA WHA T?

Catra

to everything. shes fine. just put her to bed.

✨ [illegible] ✨

show me!

send a pic

and make it recognisable!

Catra

im not taking pictures of her while shes asleep, are you insane?

✨ [illegible] ✨

then ill break the door down 😠

?

HELLO

catra

CATRA!

ARE U SERIOUSL YIGNORING ME RN?

ANSWER ME

M GONNA K[illegible]K UR FCKING DOOR N

istg

catra

catra

catra

catra

Catra

for fucks sake sparkles

The video chat ended.

17 secs, Aug 9 at 2:42 AM

AUG 9 AT 8:14 AM

✨ [illegible] ✨

u guys awake?

AUG 9 AT 9:08 AM

✨ [illegible] ✨

@Adowwa ⚔ are you ok?

AUG 9 AT 10:01

✨ [illegible] ✨

Adowwa ⚔ Catra hellooooooooooo

The conversation ends. Adora peeks at the clock at the top of the screen; it is past noon. She starts typing slowly, fighting to act like a normal functional person.

Adora ⚔

Good morning! I'm okay , guys. I'm so sorry for not texting back sooner,

I was knocked out. Catra was wonderful and took great care of me, trust me.

Catra

told you.

✨ **GIMME** ✨

fine!

i believe it

UGH 💝

we're glad you're ok, adora 😘

catra is out buying u some breakfast!

Catra

wow thanks, wasn't a surprise or anything.

😱😱😱 oh no im so sorry!

You set the nickname for Catra to Catra 😼. Change

Catra 😼

i hate you

awwww it looks just like her 😍

POW set the nickname for Catra 😼 to Catra 🐯 . Change

Catra 🐯

this is blatant homophobia

Adora laughs loudly, right when the bungalow door opens. Bright grey light pours in with the fresh smell of rain. Catra barges in and turns around to slam the door. She realizes her mistake in the last moment, grabbing the knob and closing the door as quietly as she can.

She turns on her heels again. Her wet bangs stick to her face.

"Hey ," she breathes, holding up a paper bag like a bloody sword. "Brought you breakfast. Which you didn't know about and now you're very surprised and happy."

"Hi," Adora says and pushes herself up to a sitting position. "You brought me breakfast? Catra, that makes me so surprised and happy!"

Catra grins and throws the bag into Adora's lap on her way to the wardrobe. Adora rustles with it curiously, the fresh smell of warm dough calming her rumbling stomach instead of upsetting it even more. She sniffs into the bag before reaching inside and she moans contentedly when she takes a croissant out. "Thank you."

"The éclair's mine," Catra says and peels off her wet clothes, her top first. "How you feeling?"

The first bite sticks in Adora's throat as Catra wiggles out of her ripped jeans like it is nothing. She leaves her clothes on the floor. When Adora stays quiet, Catra glances at her questioningly.

"Uh, fine," Adora says. "The meds really helped."

"Eh, I also forced a whole bottle of water in you before I let you go to bed."

"Aww, you care about me so much," Adora coos.

"I brought you that croissant and I can take it away from you anytime I want."

Adora grabs the pastry with both hands and holds it far away from Catra.

"Over my dead body."

Catra chuckles and pulls a dry tank top over her head. She shows no signs of planning to dress further, and comes round to bed to sit by the edge, grabbing the paper bag with her éclair in it.

The taste of the bite Adora is chewing on turns spongy in her mouth. She forces it down her throat before she starts weakly:

"About last night, I didn't do anything awkward, did I?"

Catra raises her brows, rustling with the bag.

"Define awkward."

"Like. I didn't say anything weird to you, right?"

Catra smirks and tilts her head towards Adora.

"Oh, you mean how you confessed your undying love for me?"

"What?!" Adora shrieks, nearly crushing the croissant in her fist. Catra bursts into laughing, slapping Adora's shoulder with the back of her hand.

"I'm messing with you. You were fine, don't worry."

"Oh."

Adora swallows. For a split second there, she almost felt relieved believing Catra.

Catra rests her chin on her own shoulder. Her cheek puffs up adorably, and she still has not touched her éclair.

"So, no headache?" She pressures gently. "Nausea?"

Adora shakes her head and wipes some crumbs off the corner of her mouth.

"I just feel weak as shit, honestly."

Catra finally takes a bite from her pastry and munches on it slowly. She notes, mostly to herself:

"You never know when to stop with anything, huh."

"You have no idea," Adora says emptily.

"Hey, I never said it was a bad thing."

Adora smiles, weak and grateful.

They finish their breakfast in silence.

*

Adora snoozes again after their late breakfast. She only laid back down to feel more comfortable, but she fell asleep almost immediately. Adora remembers Catra drawing her legs up onto the bed and towering her pillows so she could lean back and type away on her phone. Then Adora dozed off.

When she wakes again, the rain has yet to stop but Catra is still there, laying on the blanket Adora is hogging, legs straight and ankles crossed. The wind whistles outside, the storm looming through the windows. Catra had opened the blinds; the sky is dark blue and lightless.

"Hi," Adora croaks without moving from the pool of drool she managed to produce. Catra does not look up from the dimly lit screen.

"Welcome back."

Adora clears her sore throat.

"How long have I been out?"

"Couple hours. Sparkles is losing her mind again. She's convinced I poisoned you or something."

Adora chuckles and draws her shoulder up.

"Tell her it was just crushed up sleeping pills."

Catra rolls her head back, grunting desperately:

"I did, but she wasn't a fan of you snorting them off my tits."

"You did not tell her that. You wouldn't be here talking to me if you did."

"But I wanted to."

"You can, when that actually happens."

"Fuck, I'm actually out of sleeping pills. Should I Google pharmacies in my area real quick?"

Adora snorts. "Dumbass."

She rolls to her back, stretching her scapulas with a moan, then turns towards the bathroom. She was dehydrated enough that the amount of water Catra made her drink is just starting to make her need to pee.

Getting out of bed seems to be an impossible task but Adora is not going to give up. She pushes her upper body up first and uses her hand to guide her heavy legs down to the floor. She feels like it is lead flowing in her veins instead of blood.

She manages to sit up, and starts to stand. The pain is instant and unbearable; a short scream escapes her and she collapses with a heavy thud.

The blanket slips off of her, the cold air peppering her exposed skin with goosebumps. Her head is buzzing as Catra jumps up and drops on her knees next to her, grabbing her shoulder.

"Adora?! Adora, are you okay?"

"Yeah," Adora breathes, lungs whistling. She is hiding behind her hair. "I'm fine. I think I stumbled on something."

Catra lets her go with a violent push. Adora hits her back on the bed frame, its sharp edge pressing into her spine. Adora jerks and stares

at Catra with wide eyes.

"Cut the crap already!" Catra yells. "Do you really think I'm fucking stupid? Or blind?"

"No, I-"

"I know you," Catra goes on, desperate and furious. "I know you're hiding something, I know you're not okay. Do you really want me to buy your lame ass excuses about landing weird' and shit? Who do you think I am?"

Catra's chest is heaving. Her distress makes Adora's eyes burn, and she can feel an agonising knot forming in her stomach. It tightens from guilt and heartache, both so sour and heavy to carry.

Catra sighs then, closing her eyes for a moment. When she speaks, her voice is quiet again, though the edge is still there.

"Were you leaving for the bathroom?"

Adora mouths a "yeah," since she cannot find her voice just yet. Catra nods, pressing her lips to a straight line.

"Alright. Come on."

Catra takes Adora's wrist and slides her arm onto her shoulder. She keeps that arm still and stands up with bent knees, ready to help Adora lift her body up. Adora puts all her weight on one leg and pushes with gritted teeth. Catra immediately supports her, easing the pressure.

They walk the couple necessary steps together, then Adora grabs the doorframe with her free hand. Catra's hand slides to her hip.

"Can you go in alone?"

"Yeah."

Catra lets her go carefully and spins, her back pressed to the wall. She crosses her arms and turns her head away.

"Don't close the door. I'll be here when you're done."

Adora nods sharply and stumbles in. It takes her an unholy amount of time to finish from start to finish with drying her hands on the towel, but Catra shows no sign of impatience as Adora limps back out.

She does not have to ask for anything; Catra holds her again without Adora humiliating herself saying she needs help.

It is as shameful as comforting, to be taken care of like this. Adora has been keeping her every issue a secret for so long she has forgotten how it feels to share the weight of them. How it feels to be understood without degrading her worth, to be helped without disappointing everyone, without someone asking for anything in return. How it feels to be seen and vulnerable in a whirl of uncomfortable relief like it's her first breath after nearly drowning.

Catra pushes her down onto the bed. Her every move is careful, gentle, and reassuring despite the wrath of her words before. She still does not wait for Adora to ask before she turns Adora's upper body to the pushed up pillows and grabs her ankles, lifting both her legs onto the bed too.

Then, she sits by Adora's thighs and her cold, interrogating tone is back.

"So?"

Adora exhales slowly. She lifts her thumb to her mouth to chew on her skin. Catra takes her hand and pulls it back down, fingers curling around Adora's on the blanket.

"Adora."

t is a plea and an order . Two things Adora is unable to disobey.

"Fine,"Adora mutters, her voice exhausted and raspy .

She licks her dry lips, eyes cast down. She still cannot bring herself to look at Catra, who's piercing eyes she can feel on her face, stinging like needles. Catra squeezes her hand.

Adora knows exactly where to start.

"You wanna know why I wasn't at the wedding?

"I know you had that interview. I was with them when you called Perfuma."

Adora hums and shakes her head very slowly.

"I had surgery. I tore my hamstring." She takes a deep breath, and forces herself to glance up at Catra's unreadable face. She hears her own voice too loud and too distant to recognize. "I may not be able to play professionally anymore."

Catra's expression is still motionless, but her skin grows pale under her freckles.

The storm is raging outside mercilessly.

Chapter End Notes

(ノ_ _)ノ (ノ_ _)ノ (ノ_ _)ノ (ノ_ _)ノ
it's gonna be ok I promise

Also can I get an F in the comments for Catra's sanity? If you didn't think Adora was fucking delusional and dumb before, you should know the [the song] Adora was obsessed with.
Catra: *screaming* I'M STILL NOT OVER YOU I HATE YOU ALL WAYS

LOVED YOU YOU FUCKING DUMBASS KISS ME
Adora: aww u remembered my fav song :))

Thank you so, so much for support on this fic! ♡ Thank you for leaving lovely comments, thank you for subscribing (ICAN'T BELIEVE IT'S OVER 100 NOW), thank you all for reading and enjoying this mess I am presenting you. If you do enjoy , please consider leaving me a comment - I do love hearing from you all, and it keeps me going and inspired to an unholy amount. You guys are fucking awesome, and I am entirely grateful. ♡
Also yes the number of chapters have changed and it's going to be longer than anticipated but I'm always doing this--

If you enjoyed reading, please consider supporting the fic by sharing my post about it!

Thank you for the wonderful beta work, @[redacted]
Find me on Tumblr as @[redacted]

See you soon!Until then, feel free to hang out with me on Tumblr. x

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora learns some interesting things about herself - and others.

Chapter Notes

> tw: mentions of / implied child abuse, you know, this is Catra we're talking about

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"What are you saying?" Catra asks, careful and quiet; so quiet the storm outside is almost louder than her voice.

"I lied about having an interview." Adora swallows, feeling a wave of heat rushing over her body. "I signed the contract weeks before that. I just didn't tell anyone. Didn't want to steal the thunder from Perfuma and Scorpia, wanted to focus on them and the wedding, and I thought I'd have time after. So I kept quiet, went to practice in secret… and I started to push myself. I wanted to prove I belonged there. I wanted them to see that they didn't make a mistake with signing on with me. So I was working harder and harder and harder until…"

"You didn't know when to stop," Catra says. She does not mean to be hurtful or judgmental. "How much did you push yourself to tear your hamstrings? I don't think I've ever heard of a keeper with that kind of injury."

"I'm talented like that."

Catra scoffs fondly.

"I should have started to doubt your story about an interview that was-" Catra makes air quotes with one hand- " booked a month before' but you, of all people, were just going to wait right before the week of the wedding to call it off."

"I never meant to do that," Adora says, voice breaking. Her mouth twists.

Catra's thumb strokes over Adora's knuckles. "Hey , obviously. And no one was mad at you."

Even if that is a lie, hearing it from Catra unties the knot in Adora's stomach. Her muscles relax again, and she hangs her head with a sigh that comes from deep down.

Catra is waiting for her to continue for a couple of moments. When Adora keeps quiet and motionless, only her gaze flicking around the room unfocused, she pressures her:

"You had physical therapy, right?"

"For the first two months. But." Adora's voice grows higher and louder with every sentence. "I dont know. Something doesnt feel right. It doesnt react well to pressure, even… even when I dont strain myself more than usual, it's like… The pain still strikes and-" Adora inhales sharply. "I know it shouldnt. I cant let it happen during a game, but how can I even play if I couldnt go through a couple of penalty kicks with you guys? Or-or a night out dancing? Or carrying some fucking chairs, Catra, I-"

Catra soothes her with another squeeze of her hand. Adora's chest is heaving, and she is glancing at Catra apologetically before she leans in and presses her forehead to Catra's shoulder.

Catra freezes for a second. Then, she slides her free hand to Adora's nape, into her hair, pulling her in a little tighter. Adora nestles gratefully, her lips sticking to Catra's skin. Catra shivers under them.

"So you have your doctor to call?" Catra asks. "Do I take you to the ER?"

Adora shakes her head slightly.

"No- no. It'll be fine. It's fine. I'm okay. Sorry."

Catra's chest is rumbling under Adora's cheek as she growls.

"If you say that word one more time I'm *actually* going to kill you." Adora laughs, and Catra pins for a brief chuckle. Then, she turns solemn again. "Seriously, Adora, if it acts up this much and hurts this bad, you need to get it checked. Maybe the surgery didn't go without complications. Maybe they fucked up your therapy. If they strained it during recovery, it might be readjusted. I heard stories about both of them happening."

"I know," Adora whimpers. She draws her healthy leg up and hugs her knee with her free hand. "I just…I'm."

She squeezes all the air out of her lungs and chews on her lower lip so hard she tastes iron. Catra strokes Adora's hand again, then laces their fingers together.

The words roll off Adora's tongue easier now.

"If I truly can't play anymore," she starts slowly, her lips moving against Catra's neck still, "then this is all I have left. My friends, this camp, these kids… I'm not ready to give that up. If we go now, I might not be able to come back. If I need another surgery, if I can't coach them next week, I-" Adora's mumbling shrinks into something unintelligible.

Catra keeps quiet for a minute, breathing a little heavy under Adora's weight. Then, she says, raspy and simple:

"Okay."

Catra's hand slides from Adora's nape to her jaw and pushes her a little further away. Her other hand unlaces from Adora's fingers to rest on her shoulder. She tilts Adora's head to look her in the eye.

"But until then, you have to promise me something."

Adora presses her lips together, listening quietly.

"You won't strain yourself next week. No early workouts, no games, no unnecessary showing off, I don't care how difficult it is to give that up." Adora exhales through her nose; a weak chuckle. Catra holds Adora's head more firmly now, forcing her to not look away. So Adora does not. "Promise?"

Adora swallows, dry.

"I promise."

Catra nods.

"Good. You don't want to be on my bad side, trust me."

Adora snorts.

"You think I didn't already know that?"

Catra looks away. She drops her hands from Adora's face and leans on the edge of the bed with both hands.

"Well. What do I do now?" Catra asks, earning a questioning look. She suggests awkwardly, still avoiding eye contact: "Be pack?"

"I guess that wouldn't hurt. But Catra, you don't have to-"

Catra is standing already by the bed, slipping into her half-dry jeans and flip-flops in a rush. She steps to the door quickly and grabs the knob at the same time Adora clings to the sheet desperately and calls for her again:

"Catra."

Catra turns the knob and her head, staring at the wall as she is waiting for Adora to continue.

"If you meet Glimmer and Bow"…

"You have a really bad hangover," Catra finishes emptily and turns away again. "I won't tell them anything."

Adora's "thank you" is silenced by the thunder outside, and Catra slips through the door.

monday

Monday starts rough.

Adora awakens the same time she always does, her lower body still asleep. Her lips stick together so she tears them apart with force, grimacing miserably.

She turns around like a fish flopping on dry sand, only to face Catra glaring at her with narrow eyes. Adora freezes from head to toe.

"You're not going for a run, are you?"

"Um, no?" Adora says weakly.

"Okay," Catra says, still suspicious.

Despite feeling like utter garbage, Catra's raspy morning voice makes Adora smile.

"I swear I wasn't gonna," she says again, quirking a brow. "What, are you worried about me?"

Catra bares her teeth.

"I just don't trust you not to do something stupid. Again."

"Fair . But I'm pretty sure you're worried about me."

Catra growls and sinks lower under the blanket. Her voice is muffled now, her hair flowing everywhere on the pillow.

"You're lucky it's too early to kill you."

"Aww, someone's not a morning person."

"Aww, someone's not gonna be a person at all if she continues."

Adora laughs; it sounds too loud in the silence of dawn, but she cannot help it. Catra peeks back out, pulling the blanket down to her nose.

"Do you really have a death wish?"

Adora is feeling way too bold in the ungodly hours and pulls the blanket down even lower. She cups Catra's face, her thumb smoothing over Catra's lips as she whispers:

"I know a couple of pleasant ways you could kill me right now." Catra gasps, eyes wide before she casts them down. It sends a cold shiver up Adora's spine. She snatches her hand back. "I'm sorry. I wasn't thinking."

"Do you ever ," Catra mutters then, turning away .

Adora is staring at her back, shoulders raised defensively.

The moment that might have never been there is gone. Adora stays awake for the remaining couple hours before they are forced to get up, chewing on her lip and the words she is afraid to say.

She must have dozed off because Catra's alarm hits her like an electric shock.

Catra taps on her phone, grumpy as ever, and the awaited bliss of waking up together at the same time, in the same bed dissolves like a dream.

Adora watches Catra rise, still showing her back to her. There is something nostalgic about Catra combing her hair back with her fingers, neck stretched, sulky moans resonating in Adora's chest.

"Good morning," Adora tries, hoarse and careful.

Catra seems to ignore her at first. She pushes herself up and out of bed, wobbling a little. She must have had less sleep than she usually does, Adora thinks. It lights the flames of guilt deep inside her stomach like clockwork.

"Mornin'," Catra croaks then, turning towards her. Adora quickly sits up in bed.

"Are we okay?"

Catra rubs her eyes, inhaling deeply. "What… yeah? Ugh." She massages her whole face then, coming around the bed and grabbing her clothes from the drawer. "I'll go first."

From the bathroom, a completely different person emerges. Catra opens the door, a haze of steam and her intoxicating scent pouring out, and she leans on the doorframe. There is a strange, twinkling light in her eyes as she asks:

"By the way , what did Glimmer say about your broken bed?"

Shit.

Adora turns in bed, sitting on the edge now, and sticks the tip of her tongue to her teeth. "Umm. That's, you know, funny that you'd ask… So there was this little, uh." *Work, morning pain. Work.* "The

department store had a big purchase order right before Glimmer called them…for uh. An orphanage? No, kindergarten."

"Mm-hm."

"So, I should get my bed… later. This week. That's what Glimmer says, at least, who knows if there will be another unfortunate delay."

Catra pushes herself off the frame and walks to Adora now, arms crossed, hips tilted. She halts right before her, craning ahead a bit.

"You know, that *is* funny," she drawls, "since Glimmer freaked out so much about you sleeping in my bed when I FaceTimed her the other night."

Adora swallows.

"Did she?"

"She did."

"Strange."

"Very strange. Do you think it has something to do with these crazy bed emergencies that've been happening all around?"

Adora exhales in a huff. She breaks the playful eye contact, tasting bile at the back of her throat.

Catra senses the change in her, letting her arms fall. She takes a step back and says, very softly:

"I told her since mine is closer to the door, you crashed there." Adora's head snaps up. Catra is smiling at her, faint but sweet. She takes Adora's hands and pulls her out of bed. "Now come on, get ready, and let's go already. I'm not eating soggy bacon because of you."

Wednesday

"Come on guys, let's push it, we only have five minutes left!" Adora yells from the sides, pulling her cap lower on her head. "Wingers, don't leave your positions, stay on your half!"

An Arrow kid flops onto the ground, and Seahawk whistles. Adora uses the break before the free kick to walk closer to their goal, stepping in line with her keeper.

"Flutterina!" Adora calls. Flutterina jumps, holding her hand in front of her chest. She looks at Adora nervously. "Hands and knees, okay?" Flutterina stares down on herself, quickly shifting into position. "You've got this."

Seahawk whistles again, pointing towards the Grayskull goal.

"Onward!"

Flutterina leaps to the right, hands reaching for the ball. It won't be enough. Adora takes a step ahead.

"Slip!"

But she does not. Three minutes before the end, and the score has just changed to 3-1 with the Arrows winning.

Adora clicks her tongue. This is the least successful practice match Team Grayskull has ever played since Adora became their coach.

She cheers them on, regardless, until Seahawk blows the game off with a long, melodic whistle.

Adora catches Bow's glance at the other side of the field. She gives him a thumbs-up, Bow grinning proudly. His team had never defeated Adora's before.

Adora gathers her team around her, leaning on her knees so she's at eye-level with the kids.

"We may have lost today, but that will only make us work harder, and be smarter," she starts firmly. "We are still warriors, and we will keep training and working as such. I know you all did your best today, and for that, I am so proud of you. Next time, we will stand victorious, and take the Garnets down. So who's with me?"

All the kids cheer, except for one of them. Adora straightens and raises her fist in the air, shouting their slogan at the top of her lungs.

"Who are we fighting for?"

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

"Alright, mighty warriors," Adora says, and notices a counselor waiting to guide the team to the dining bungalow. Adora gives a friendly wave, the girl winking in return. "A feast awaits us. Go with Netossa, wash your hands, and for the love of everything, behave. One more food fight with the Garnets and we all will be in big trouble."

"But they starte-"

"I know, they always start it. But it's gonna be my head on Coach Glimmer's silver platter, so, you know."

The kids mumble in unison. Adora bites the inside of her cheek to not laugh and watches her team leave in pairs, looking for a pink mop of hair.

"Flutterina," she calls then, quiet but stern. Flutterina looks back, stepping out of line. "A word, please?"

Flutterina presses her lips together, peeking after her friends one last time. Once they are all out of earshot, she blurts out:

"I'm so sorry for messing up the game for everyone! I know I did bad, and I'm *so* sorry, we could have won if I didn-"

Adora puts a hand on her shoulder, squeezing gently.

"Hey, it's okay. I didn't want to talk to you to scold you. Come on, let's sit down."

They walk back to the sideline together, Adora's hand resting reassuringly on Flutterina's shoulder. Flutterina flops down on the bench, huddling into herself immediately. The Garnets are still in-game with Bright Moon, their ruckus echoing over and across the empty field Adora and Flutterina are sitting by.

Adora leans back on both hands, crossing her ankles.

"So," she starts, kind and careful. "I noticed that you were kind of out of it the whole game. If there's something on your mind, something that bothers you, you can always talk to me about it. You know that, right?"

Flutterina nods hastily, her gaze still fixated on the grass. She says nothing, so Adora goes on:

"We're all a team, and all have equally important posts to play. We are all responsible for winning or losing, and we have to work together to be better. Look, I know the pressure of being the goalkeeper, and how easy it is to feel like the whole game depends on you and you alone, but-"

Suddenly, Flutterina cries out:

"I hate being a goalkeeper!"

Adora blinks. Flutterina's eyes grow wide like she cannot believe what she had just said. She curls up even more, drawing her legs up onto the bench and fumbling with the strap of her keeper gloves.

Adora keeps silent, giving Flutterina the time to build up courage and collect her thoughts. On the other field, the Garnets score another goal.

"I hate being a goalkeeper," Flutterina says again, much quieter this time. She takes a deep breath, tearing off her gloves and shoving them aside. "I'm scared I'll get hit, I hate slipping and sliding, I can't make good decisions in split seconds and I hate the pressure, and I hate just standing around most of the time while everyone else gets to run and take action! I hate it all."

Adora's heart clenches. She leans forward, trying to get Flutterina to look at her.

"Why didn't you say something sooner?"

"I'm the only keeper we have."

"So?" Adora asks, exhaling with a sharp huff. "Flutterina, it doesn't matter that you're the most trained if it's for a position you hate so much."

"We will never win without me. I can do it. I can, I just..." Her shoulders raise defensively.

"Hey, hey. I care about you guys having fun more than winning. I can't let this ruin your time here. We'll figure something out together. You don't have to do anything you are not comfortable with, okay?"

Finally, Flutterina looks up at her. Her cheeks are flushed, her eyes shining.

"Really?"

"Of course," Adora says, grinning wide.

They hear another long whistle. Soon, Team Bright Moon passes them, heads hanging. So the Garnets have done it again; Catra's

team is still on the field, full of adrenaline, chatting, and laughing loudly.

Adora catches Catra's eyes. Catra squints prettily, then her glance slides to Flutterina sitting next to Adora, her posture still sad and broken.

Catra gives a couple of kids high fives on her way to the bench, halting before Adora.

"Hi, Coach Catra," Flutterina says.

"Hey, kid." Catra tilts her head, raising a brow at Adora. "Is everything okay?"

"Yeah," Adora says, peeking at Flutterina. "We've got this. Right, Flutterina?"

Flutterina's glance sparkles between Adora and Catra, but she nods. Catra does as well, quick and sharp. Her eyes soften again as they meet Adora's.

"Alright, Princess. See you at the coaches' table," she says, backing away without turning.

"Yeah," Adora breathes. "See you."

"Bye, kid. Keep your chin up."

"Bye, Coach Catra."

Catra turns on her heels now, swaying away. She looks back above her shoulder once more before disappearing behind the dining bungalow.

Adora comes back to Earth with a cold shake of realization that she has not finished talking to Flutterina yet. She turns back to her swiftly, clearing her throat.

"Can I ask you something else?"

"Y eah," Flutterina says.

"Most of the kids I have on my team don't have such a clear vision on what position they want to play at so early on, but you… I remember the first time we met, you already told me you wanted to be a keeper. What happened?"

Flutterina blushes deeply, turning towards Adora with her whole body, knees still drawn up on the bench. She laces her fingers together around her ankles and peeks up at Adora.

"I never really thought of what goalkeepers do. I knew I wanted to be a keeper because you are, too."

Adora's jaw pops open. She has no idea what to say, feeling her cheeks heating up as well.

"Oh."

"I just wanted to be cool like you."

Adora smoothes a loose curl of hair behind her ear, mumbling coyly:

"Oh, I'm not- I'm not that cool, actually ."

Flutterina sounds straight-up offended at that.

"Y es, you are! You're the best keeper, you have cool friends and the coolest job on earth and a cool girlfriend-"

"Whoa, wait, a girl- *what?"*

"Oh!" Flutterina slaps her hand to her mouth, whispering to herself: "Not yet?" She quickly looks around and waves towards a group of the Garnets kids. "Frosta!"

Frosta walks to them, squinting suspiciously. Without saying anything, Flutterina sighs with a miserable little whimper and gets a couple crumpled one-dollar bills out of her shorts. She pushes them into Frosta's hand.

"I told you," Frosta says simply, and leaves as fast as she had arrived.

Adora blinks. Whatever the fuck had just happened, there is no time to unpack all of that. Adora shakes her head slightly, trying to ignore her suspicions and getting the conversation back on track.

"Anyway," she says, "listen to me. You're definitely the best keeper on our team, but you cannot let that make you do anything you don't want to. There is only one important thing, and that's what *you* want. We all have things we're good at, but that doesn't mean we shouldn't do the things we love. Skill is one thing, talent is another, but spirit? That's what makes you who you are."

Flutterina's face is long, and she looks like she is seconds away from bawling.

Adora's blood runs cold. What did she do? Did she mess up? Did she say something wrong? Did she only say all the wrong things? Fuck, where is Bow when she needs him most?

She looks around desperately for help.

"Listen, we can just-"

"That was so beautiful," Flutterina whines, and before Adora could think of an answer, Flutterina's tiny arms are wrapped tight around her. "Thank you, Coach. I knew you were my hero for a reason."

Adora chuckles, patting Flutterina's head. Her chest feels warm, and if this hug goes on any longer, she will probably start tearing up, too.

"Well, there's only one question left," she says, and Flutterina lets her go to look at her questioningly. "Do you know what position you'd like to play from now on?"

"Actually, I... I think I'd make a pretty good defender… maybe center back?"

Adora staggers to her feet, resting her hands on her waist.

"I know just the guy to help you out. Come on, let's go."

Adora takes Flutterina to the coaches' table after they both got their trays of lunch in hand, and introduces her to Bow.

"Coach Bow is the best defender I know. Whatever questions you may have, he'll know the answer. And if you're lucky, he might show you some of his best moves and tricks. Right, Bow?"

Bow is downright glowing, quickly rising from his chair.

"Absolutely!" He says, voice breaking from excitement. He takes his tray with him. "I'm so honored you thought of me. Come on, I'll sit with you. We can talk it all through and once we're finished, we'll take it to the field, Best Defense Duo style! Okay?"

Flutterina is bouncing on her feet.

"Okay! Thank you, Coach Bow! Thank you, Coach Adora! You guys are the best!"

As the two of them leave, Adora plops down in Bow's empty seat.

"That was some nerve," Catra says in a joking tone, stabbing baby spinach on her fork. "Passing off work for the coach of the opposing team."

Adora takes her fork, snapping back:

"Don't tell me you've never wanted to do that."

"Busted. I wish I thought of it before. That Frosta kid was giving me *hell* last week."

"Hey ," Glimmer cuts in, pointing her knife at Catra. "Only I can talk about my little sister like that."

Catra's voice grows shrill.

" *She's your sister?"* She slides lower in the chair now, head thrown back. "Ugh, everything makes so much sense now ."

Adora and Glimmer are laughing while Catra is growling.

"So Flutterina doesn't want to be a goalkeeper anymore?" Glimmer asks then.

"Nope," Adora mumbles and swallows the bite in her mouth. "She says she just wanted to do it because she's the best at it from our team, but she doesn't have any fun doing it. She's been miserable for a while but she was scared that she'd let the team down if she goes for something she truly loves."

Catra narrows her eyes at Adora.

"And what did you tell her?"

"I mean, I told her that she should always go for what she wants, and she shouldn't let the thought of something she's good at control her and hold her back."

"Aha."

"Well, I'm glad she changed her mind," Glimmer says and stands up from the table with an empty tray. "I'm gonna go look for her and Bow. See you guys later!"

Once Glimmer is gone, Adora is back to finishing her lunch. Catra is already done as well, and Adora is just as happy as surprised that

she keeps her company regardless, finally feeling like Catra has completely warmed up to her.

Adora shoves a big pile of lettuce into her mouth when she peeks up and notices Catra staring at her with the same expression as before.

"Mhwha?" She asks, pulling the greens in like a rabbit.

"Do you ever hear yourself when you talk?" Catra asks, her tone edgeless and genuinely curious.

"What do you mean," Adora blurts out, confused and low .

"When are you gonna take your own advice?"

"About?"..

Catra licks her lips and leans onto the tabletop. She pushes her chair back, the legs screeching on the floor loud and sharp.

"You'll figure it out."

thursday

Adora is tapping away on her phone, her grunts growing more and more frustrated.

She is sitting by the end of Catra's bed - their bed, as she likes to call it in secret- elbow resting on her drawn-up knee, desperately trying to get into her banking app.

She messes up her last try, too. *Shit* .

She throws her head back, her skull knocking loudly on the bed frame.

" @- "

"What the hell are you doing?" Catra asks, voice breathless from trying to bite back a laugh. She is putting a flannel shirt on, open over her crop top, and grabs a tiny leather backpack she shoves her phone in.

"I locked myself out of this stupid app," Adora mutters. "I have to pay this bill today or they'll turn the power off in my apartment."

"That sucks," Catra says, throwing the backpack on her shoulders.

Adora checks the time, climbing off the bed and pulls the hem of her shorts down her thighs.

"I'm just gonna go to town and get it sorted out before the next practice." Adora eyes Catra up and down. "Are you leaving, too?"

"Yeah."

"We can go together. I'll take you," Adora hurries to offer. "If you want."

Catra's eyes flare up, a smirk tugging at the corner of her mouth.

"I have a better idea," she purrs.

"I've never done this before," Adora says.

Catra straddles the motorcycle between her legs, turning to Adora with a crooked smirk.

"What, are you scared?"

Adora snaps, offended:

"No."

"Then hop on, Princess. W e dont have all day ."

Adora fumbles with the strap of the extra helmet, tightening it under her chin. She hops onto the bike, too, trying to get comfortable behind Catra. She raises her red sneakers off the ground, and before she could catch her breath, the bike burrs up and jerks ahead.

Adora yelps, pressing her thighs to the sides. Horse riding reflexes.

Catra laughs and turns around, raising her jaw .

"Hang onto me, dummy." Adora stares at her, trying to figure out if Catra is serious or not. Catra beams at her, bright and inviting. "Come on."

Adora swallows drily. She crosses her arms around Catra's narrow waist, sliding ahead in her seat until they are practically cuddling. Adora lets herself be bold once again, resting her chin on Catra's bony shoulder. Their helmets knock together.

"Hold tight," Catra warns her and starts the engine again with a kick of her combat boots.

They leave the gate and turn onto the narrow street slowly, the bike popping under them. Once the road is clear ahead, Catra speeds up from 0 to 100 in a split second. They are *definitely* scorching the asphalt over the speed limit, the trees around them melting into one big green rail.

Adora screams excitedly like she is on a rollercoaster, and hugs Catra even tighter. She can feel Catra laughing from her shaking rather than hearing it, but then Catra taps something on the side of her helmet and Adora can hear her loud and clear.

"Y ou okay back there?"

"How did you do that?" Adora yells, followed by ear-piercing static and Catra jumping in her arms. Adora whispers, nestling to her tighter: "Sorry ."

"Helmet intercoms, so, *please* , stop yelling."

"Whoa, cool."

"So? You okay?"

Adora feels a wide grin creeping up on her face.

"Depends," she says, dragging out her words pityingly. "Can this thing go any faster? Im gonna grow old back here if we keep plodding along like this."

Catra laughs, short and sharp.

"Dont say shit like that if youre not serious."

"Ha, you want something serious?"

Adoras moral code is swept up and dragged down the road by the whistling wind they are breaking through. There is something about the rush of this whole situation, Catras pretty body pressed against hers, the chance to touch her, warm her, breathe her in; the vertiginous speed that seems to shake Adora out of this time and space just by one second.

One second, and suddenly everything makes sense.

Adora draws her left hand back from Catras side, sliding it up her bare stomach, careful and slow. She feels goosebumps blooming under her fingers.

"Faster , Catra," she whispers then, getting drunk on the way Catras sucks her stomach in and pushes her ass back to Adoras thigh impulsively. Adoras hand presses on and higher, stopping by the curve of Catras bra. " *Faster* ."

Catra breathes something unintelligible and speeds up furiously, leaning ahead on the bike.

Adora leans with her, moving as one, and she laughs again, high and just a little hysterical. Catra tilts the Rebel side to side now, writing curlicues with the wheels, so Adora digs her nails in Catra's skin for a better hold, her other hand rubs further down, finding Catra's thigh to hold onto.

"You're gonna make me crash my baby," Catra grunts then, fascination hiding in her tone.

"Aw, are we already on pet name terms?" Adora coos, her index finger stroking along the line between Catra's ribs. Catra shivers and slows down a bit;she is still totally overstepping the speed limit.

"What the fuck's gotten into you," Catra asks, breathlessly amused and fighting back a chuckle. There is something insanely hot about only hearing Catra's raspy voice from so close, like she is whispering straight into Adora's ears. "Are you low on oxygen or something?"

Adora settles her hand above Catra's navel. She feels giddy at the fact that her one palm can almost cover her front entirely, and it does not help that Catra's breath hitches in her ear.

"Do you want me to stop?" Adora asks.

"Unfortunately, no. This is too funny."

Adora pouts at that, throat drying up. She was going for sexy, not funny. Her fingers shudder on Catra's stomach and she draws her hand back from Catra's thigh to her side.

Catra keeps quiet for a moment, and then-

"Hey," she says softly. "Why don't you save that cocky attitude for a time when *my* hands aren't occupied either?"

Warmth blooms in Adora’s chest as she rests her chin back in the place it feels like it truly belongs;the valley of Catra’s neck.

"I like that,"she mumbles.

Catra’s muscles relax under Adora’s arm. She is reeling back the pace to something legal and pleasant. Adora turns her attention to the scenery now; behind the long row of trees, there lay emerald fields and then the ocean, shimmering in the sun. From the empty road they’re taking, muddy intersections break off between fields, leading to secret hideouts Adora knows a couple of all too well.

Adora closes her eyes.

Catra stops the Rebel in front of Adora’s bank, two towns away from camp. Adora staggers off the bike, her thighs a little stiff as she tries to straighten.

"Thanks for the ride, again," she says, taking the helmet off. Her hair sticks to her skull, damp and fuzzy. Catra reaches out instinctively, smoothing some baby hairs back from her forehead.

"No sweat."

Adora pushes the helmet into Catra’s hands a little too rough, feeling heat crawling up her neck.

"Do I, uh. I’ll text you when I’m done?"

Catra draws back and gets off, too, propping the bike with the helmets hanging from the hand clutch.

"Nah. I’ll wait."

"Don’t you have errands to run, too?"

Catra shrugs nonchalantly as she moves to cross her arms. She does not look at Adora as she says:

"Mine's not urgent. It's easier if I just take you there, too."

It makes Adora unreasonably happy .

Ten minutes later, Adora pushes the glass door that clearly says "pull." She is completely lost in the sight of Catra leaning against the bike seat, one leg propped up, arms still crossed. She turns towards the street with her jaw raised, deep in thought. The sun shines upon her from above her head, tinting the tips of her wild waves, glistening gold.

Adora fights her way out of the building, then halts. She wants to enjoy this moment a little longer, Catra looking like the most beautiful little thing Adora has ever seen, and she is waiting for *her* . It sends a shiver up her spine.

The sight reminds Adora of the posters she used to hang up in her room as a teen - rock singers in tight leather and torn denim; tough but petite girls, sweet and dangerous; girls Adora has always had a thing for. Now she starts to understand why.

Catra turns her head, noticing Adora. She smiles faintly, stretching with a roll of her shoulders.

"Everything cool?" Catra asks from several feet away, watching Adora approach. Her glance slides down on her before snapping back to her face, Adora feeling it lingering on her thighs a bit longer than anywhere else. Interesting.

"Yeah, all done," Adora says.

Out of pure scientific curiosity, she reaches up for her ponytail, tightening it. She can feel her muscles tense in her arms, and with

them, Catra too;Adora sees her swallow big, long lashes fluttering.

Adora dares a questioning look with a cock of her head.

Catra stares back, blank;her nails are digging into her elbow .

"All done?" Catra asks in an obvious tone.

"You tell me," Adora says.

"Just get on the fucking bike."

Adora laughs brightly and grabs her helmet. She snaps it on her head and slides her palm on Catra's waist before either of them gets on the Rebel.

Catra does not seem to mind.

They park again in the lot of a pretty apartment complex; it looks bright and clean, white walls with maroon bricks, surrounded by coastal greens of every shape and size. They are still close enough to the coast that the air is cool with the sea breeze, fresh and salty. Adora falls in love immediately with the feeling of it all, huddling up to Catra tight as she looks around.

Catra stops the engine and reaches out her foot. Adora tilts with the bike and Catra, rather stumbling then stepping on the pavement.

"Where are we?" Adora asks as Catra gently peels her arms off her waist so she can stand.

Catra rakes her fingers through her hair, poofing it up where the helmet flattened its curls.

"My place."

Adora rises to her feet, too, pulling her leg over the bike. She glances around once again, trying to imagine Catra living at a place like this. In her imagination, she was more like a penthouse-type in a busy, smoky city.

"Wait, really?"

"Uh, yeah." Catra looks just a touch embarrassed, her hand sliding to her nape. "I've been living here for a while now."

Catra starts walking without waiting for Adora, who hurries to keep up with her climbing the stairs. Her legs are still not in the best shape for walking just yet.

Catra leads Adora to the third floor, keys jangling in her hand.

"I asked my neighbor to feed my cat but I still check on her sometimes," Catra says and turns the key twice. "She's never stayed without me for longer than a night since I've had her."

"Aww right, you have a cat," Adora says. She leans to the wall by Catra's apartment, waiting for invitation. She is not sure if Catra wants her in her living space or not; she might just ask Adora to wait outside until she goes in for a couple of minutes.

Catra has her hand on the doorknob now.

"Just a heads up, she probably won't let you touch her. Nothing personal, she just fucking hates everybody."

"Oh."

Catra opens the door and ushers Adora in. As they are standing in a narrow corridor with two doors on the left, one on the right, and one ahead, Adora sees a big floof of gray fur trotting towards them elegantly, screaming at the top of her lungs.

"Yeah, yeah, yeah," Catra says and squats down. She reaches out, knuckles first. "I kno- Hey!"

Adora giggles. The cat is slaloming around her ankles, tiny pink nose sniffing her, tail straight up like a flagpole. Adora leans down, holding her fingers close to the cat's fur but not touching.

"Hi," she coos. The cat sniffs, then bumps her head to the back of Adora's hand. Adora glances at Catra, who is staring at them like she was slapped in the face. "You're right, she's a dick."

Catra opens her mouth, but no words come out. She shakes her head and grabs her knees to push herself up, hissing to the cat on her way up, barely audible:

" *Traitor* ."

Adora laughs again. She tries her luck with picking the cat up; she puts her paws on Adora's shoulder immediately, head bumping her jaw now .

"Is that her name?

"If the shoe fits." Catra watches Adora cuddle the cat that fucking hates everybody, and says, weakly: "It's Melog."

"Cute."

"Yeah," Catra breathes, and steps closer. She pets Melog's head burrowed under Adora's chin. Melog starts purring like a sewing machine on steroids.

Catra's fingers caress Adora's jawline in the process; if it is an accident or not, Adora does not know, but it feels... too nice. She bites her lip hard, chewing on it.

Catra smooths her thumb on Adora's lip and pulls it back down, away from her teeth.

"You'll bleed again," she says, simple and quiet. Her eyes find Adora's and she scoffs, stepping back. "What?

"Nothing," Adora mumbles. She is scratching Melog behind her ears like her life depends on it. "So, uh. Is this where you disappear sometimes? Just hanging out at home with Melog so she's not alone?"

"Basically ." Catra bares her teeth. "Stop looking at me like that."

"Catra," Adora sings. "Are we just... hanging out? At your place?"

"As far as I can see you're hanging out with my cat."

"Don't be jealous."

"Oh please," Catra chuckles. "She'll forget you as soon as you step out of the door."

"Not jealous of me," Adora cuddles Melog closer, nestling into her soft fur. "Of Melog."

Adora hit a nerve. Catra's cheeks darken a couple shades and she snaps her head away, turning on the heels of her boots.

"Alright, I don't know what you're high on today, but either share it or cut it." Catra grabs onto a door frame, peeking back above her shoulder. "Are you gonna stand in the hall the whole time?"

Adora, still holding Melog, jogs after Catra and they step into a bright, open living space together; it functions as the living room, the dining room, and the kitchen all in one.

Adora tries to not stare too much, but it is hard. She has never been in Catra's, well, anything, apart from their shared bungalow. Back when Catra was still living with her mother, she did not let anyone visit her and Adora had always suspected that it was not Catra's ideal hangout place either.

It is strange and intimate to see how Catra imagines living, what things she surrounds herself with, and it is definitely a surprise, because it is very… well, cozy. It is neat - crowded, but clean. There

is a whole wall of shelves hitting the ceiling, packed with books and records and souvenirs; framed posters are hanging from the wall on the other side, peacefully coexisting with huge impressionist paintings and concert tickets and post-it notes just slammed on in seemingly no order - and still, everything looks like is it right where it is supposed to be. There is also no TV or any electronics, just plants - so many plants, hanging from the ceiling and covering most of the wood floor. Catra does not have much furniture, and what she does have, is a completely different piece than the others. All four chairs around the table are from wildly different sets, just like the pillows and throws on her huge low-seated sofa.

"Your place is so nice," Adora manages to say, still trying to take it all in.

"Don't sound so surprised," Catra jabs from behind the kitchen island.

"I mean, I just - I haven't. I've never seen where you live." Melog starts fidgeting in Adora's arms, so she lets her hop off. She lands on the sofa, curling into herself on a fluffy pillow. "It's cool."

"Thanks," Catra says, and she sounds genuinely grateful. She disappears down behind the island. Adora hears clattering and she comes round the corner to check what Catra is doing. She is fumbling with some glasses. "Want something to drink?"

"I'm fine, thanks," Adora says at the exact moment her stomach starts rumbling furiously. "...Sorry."

Catra just titters and glances at the antique clock on the wall as she straightens her back.

"I guess I owe you lunch now that we won't make it back to camp in time."

"There's really no need," Adora hurries to say, but Catra does not accept no for an answer.

"My fridge is full anyway. I've been away for long enough that you would do me a favor if you helped me eat it all before things go bad."

"You sure?"

"Yeah."

"Okay."

Adora turns with Catra towards the fridge and peeks into it as Catra opens the door. Once again, Adora has something to be surprised by, and it is not (just) Catra's perfect ass pushed closer to her as Catra leans ahead.

Adora thought Catra meant leftovers from takeouts, but the fridge is packed to the max with ingredients in their weird, packaged, unpeeled, uncooked phase.

Her voice grows high.

"Wait, you're gonna cook?"

"I hoped you'd at least help me."

"You can cook?!"

Catra does not look back as she starts unpacking the fridge, throwing bags and jars behind her back for Adora to catch. Adora does, then slides them all onto the island top carefully.

Catra straightens and turns then, raising her chin at Adora. She sounds playfully arrogant:

"I'm a survivor."

Adora knits her eyebrows, sucking her lips in. Catra sighs and cocks her jaw then, forcing herself to explain further:

"I've spent most of my childhood locked up at home alone with no money, so I had to improvise. Make something edible out of anything I found in the fridge or on the shelves."

Adora feels like she was punched in the guts with every word Catra said. She always had suspicions, but hearing it straight from the girl she spent her whole teenage years loving and protecting is… devastating.

"Catra, I'm so sorry."

Seeing Adora's face, Catra adds quickly: "At this point, I just enjoy doing it. Like growing herbs in the kitchen window and shit. It's fine, Adora. I'm over it."

Adora forces her expression to fade into something more relaxed, and just a tiny bit smug. She leans on her elbow, tilted head resting in her palm as she raises her brows at Catra.

"So you're a book-reading, painting-owning, herb-growing biker girl with a cat who also cooks for herself daily?"

"Everything you just said sounded defensive."

Adora grins wide and bumps Catra with her hips.

"I really like it," she says quietly, kind eyes drilling into Catra's. "I like lots of things about you."

Catra looks away, the tip of her nose dusty red.

"What are you in the mood for?"

"I'll eat anything. I'm just allergic to-"

"Shellfish. I know. I have some chicken."

Adora pushes herself back up from the countertop, lips parting. Catra turns away to get some pans and cutting boards from the

cabinet, like it is not a big deal that she remembers an allergy that maybe came up once, seven years ago.

"Who's Julien?" Adora mumbles to herself with a knife in her hand.

She is standing by the counter, right next to Catra who busies herself with lighting the stove under a wok.

"What?" Catra glances at the open cookbook that she laid in front of Adora. Because apparently, she also learns recipes from books. Catra snorts without edge. "Adora, that's *julienne*."

"Ah, okay."

Adora still does not move.

"Just cut the carrots and celery into thin little strips."

Right. That, she understands.

As Adora gets to work, cutting precise little matches from the vegetables, quick and determined like she was born for slicing things, she still has the time to process the whole situation. Or try to, at least.

She is in her cute ex's cute kitchen - the ex who she still has feelings for, definitely stronger feelings than she should have after all these years, but anyway- So they are in the kitchen, all alone, cooking a meal together from scratch. There is also quiet music playing from Catra's phone, and a cat that is supposed to hate everyone, but loves them both, is circling them like a fluffy shark, screaming for chicken.

This is too much of a domestic sapphic daydream to be true.

And Catra is laughing. Like, genuinely laughing at Adora's weak jokes and is fond of her cutting technique, and when they make

some kind of spicy sauce, Catra holds the wooden spoon up for Adora to taste it, looking practically ravenous as Adora blows on it before sipping a couple drops. Then, Adora is staring because Catra tastes from the same spoon right after Adora, her tongue pressed to it flat and she has the nerve to share the look as she gives it a long lick.

Adora feels dizzy, and not just from hunger. Catra's voice is low and raspy in her ears.

"You like it?"

"Yeah."

"Not too hot?"

"Just a bit. I can manage."

Catra smirks like she knows, and tiptoes for plates. It calls for revenge.

Adora steps right behind her, reaching up, too.

"Let me."

Catra freezes under her, gently pressed between the counter and Adora's front. She pushes back slightly, playing it off as an exhale and a drop of her hands from reaching inside the cabinet; Adora goes against that force, her chest pressed to Catra's shoulder and her nose in her hair.

She takes two plates with one hand, turning the other palm out as she brings it down by Catra's hair. Her knuckles caress Catra's shoulder, the length of her arm pressed into her side defensively, and reaches her waist to fully grab onto.

"Is that enough?" Adora whispers into Catra's hair, feeling the shiver she was waiting for.

"No."

Adora digs her fingers deeper.

"What do you need?"

"Two bowls for the dips," Catra blurts out.

Now is Adora's time to chuckle. She releases Catra's waist and obeys, getting two small glass bowls, as well. She steps back, then; it takes a couple of seconds for Catra to turn, as well, her expression unreadable.

Adora asks innocently:

"Table or sofa?"

"Sofa?"

Their phones ping at the same time. Catra sighs and grabs hers from the kitchen island since it is closer to them, and switches apps. Adora steps by her side at the same time Melog decides to jump onto the island as well.

"It's Sparkles," Catra says wearily. "Obviously."

Adora takes a fluffy mouse plush from a bowl on the island and sways it in front of Melog's face.

A paw comes clawing into it immediately.

Best Friend Squad + **Catra**

AUG 13 AT 12:31 PM

✨ [illegible] ✨

we couldnt help but notice that neither of u are here

r u coming to lunch?

?

[illegible]owwa ⚔️

[illegible]atra 🐯

[illegible] [illegible] changed the group chat name to 💝 **Best Friend Sqad** 💝

✨ [illegible] ✨

u better not be doing what i think ur doing

are u even together?

like atthe same place?

Catra puts her phone down and slides it between the two of them.

W anna deal with her?

Adora scoffs understandingly. She keeps one hand free to fight with Melog over the plushie, tapping slowly with the other.

Catra

This is Adora. Sorry, we're in Salineas.

✨ [illegible] ✨

HA

NICE TRY Catra!

i saw darla in the parking lot 😒

Catra

Catra took me on her motorcycle.

✨ [illegible] ✨

.wait is this rlly adora? what the fck are u doin in salineas?

Catra takes the keyboard before Adora could start typing.

adora's busy playing with my pu

"Catra no," Adora squeals hysterically. She tries to grab the phone but Catra snatches it away, the tip of her tongue pressed between her teeth. She looks bloodthirsty. "Catra!"

"Ugh, *fine.*"

Catra

adora’s busy playing with my kitty

✨ [illegible] ✨

what the FUCK

Catra

"You're gonna kill her," Adora whimpers, choking on giggles. She abandons Melog to try and catch Catra. "Catra, you're gonna kill Glimmer, give me your phone."

✨ [illegible] ✨

CATRA U BETTER NOT MEAN

MMA THROW HANDS

Catra

are you against eating out, sparkles?

✨ [illegible] ✨ is typing...

Catra 😼🌈

what i meant is

we're just having lunch

🫦

Glimmer is calling them. Adora is staring at the phone in Catra's hand, then she looks her in the eye. There is a glow in there that she knows all too well and which means nothing good.

"Catra," Adora warns her, trying to sound firm. She sounds as tough as a squeaky toy.

She hurls herself at Catra as soon as she picks the phone up, accidentally putting it on speaker.

"Hi Glimmer," Adora wheezes before Catra could even blink, voice growing shrill.

Glimmer gasps dreadfully. Her volume matches Adora's as she shrieks:

"Why are you out of breath?"

Catra opens her mouth. Adora twirls behind Catra and slaps her palm over her lips, twisting Catra's phone out of her grip and holding it closer to her ear. It does not stop Catra to moan loudly, *lewdly* against Adora's skin and squirm in her hold, reaching behind to tickle herself out of the situation. Adora keeps her waist as far away from

Catra's determined fingers as she possibly can while trying to keep her sanity.

Glimmer is not the only one who is heavily affected by Catra's noises, although differently.

"Hello? Adora?!"

Adora hears Bow's muffled whispers from the distance:

"Sweetheart, maybe you should hang up."

"No, no, no, dont-," Adora says. "Catra, stop squirming- We're not doing anything! I'm at Catra's place having lunch with her and there's a normal, actual, physical cat that she meant-" Catra presses her tongue to Adora's palm. Adora yelps and lets her go. "Did you just *lick me?* "

"Catra drop your location."

"Oh my god, both of you, stop," Adora says, then holds the phone away to switch to video chat. Glimmer and Bow do not turn their camera on. Adora reaches out her hand and zooms on Catra's cocky grimace. Also her very clothed body.

"See? Nothing is happening." Her voice grows smug. "Also, do you really think we'd have the time to text you back if we-"

"Okay, okay!"

Glimmer sounds even more furious at the fact that they are *not* having sex, if that is even possible. Adora could not be more confused.

Bow checks in, joyful as ever:

"Can you show me the cat?"

"Uh, sure," Adora says and tilts the screen so Melog is in focus.

"A wwww,look at that lab!Glimmer ,look at the lab!"

I" don't want to look at the lab ."

Adora and Catra share a glance. They both look ruffled and ridiculous, their chests heaving from scuffling. Adora reaches out off camera, stroking Catra's warm cheek with the back of her hand.

"Y ou got so hot,"Adora mouths with a grin.

"Y ou grew up pretty decent, too," Catra whispers back. Adora slaps Catra's shoulder and snorts, turning the camera back on her face.

"Now that everything's settled," Adora says, "we're just gonna go. Well be back in time for practice, okay?"

"Fine!"

"Kiss the cat for me!"

Catra smirks and purrs off camera:

"Adora, you heard the man-"

Adora waves before Glimmer could explode again and hangs up very quickly . The phone starts chiming immediately.

Adora slams her forehead down on the island then, arms reached out as she lets Catra's phone drop out of her hand.

"Oh my God." Her shoulders are still shaking with the aftermath of laughs. "Glimmer's never gonna forgive me. I'm a dead woman."

Catra pats Adora's back as she steps to the stove to portion out their lunch.

"She's gonna kill me first. My last wish will be to spare you."

Adora snorts unattractively.

"How noble of you."

"What can I say? I'm a fucking saint."

They spend the next ten minutes eating quietly, a healthy amount of space between them on the couch that Melog takes as hers. The sudden rush of warmth melted into something sweet and kind; the only thing burning is the spicy sauce in Adora's mouth.

Despite neither of them carrying on the conversation further, Adora does not feel awkward at all. Everything is all too comfortable and natural, giving her a spark of unreasonable hope that maybe, just maybe, if she goes on a little further next time, this could be her every day. It does not seem like a distant dream anymore - after all, she is already living it for a while.

"Do you like living here?" Adora asks suddenly, wiping some sauce off the corner of her mouth.

Catra winces, awakening from deep thought.

"Yeah, I guess. It's cheap. And I like the area."

"I like it, too," Adora says. "It's one of the best parts of coming here to Etheria. The sea and the beach, and these cute little coastal towns." Adora sighs a little. "I wish I lived closer."

"Could you?" Catra asks simply. She puts her empty plate down on the coffee table, drawing her legs up onto the sofa.

Adora clicks her tongue.

"I mean I could, it's just… the commute to the stadium is better where I live now. If I make it with this-" Adora shakes her injured knee- "I might have to move again, even further away. You know. I'd travel around a lot more too, so."

Catra is looking at her without saying anything to that. Adora takes another bite of her chicken, munching on it slowly. t tastes like sandpaper in her mouth.

t starts to make less and less sense to feel so miserable whenever she is talking about her future. Something about being here, with Catra, and being truly listened to turns a switch in her mind. t clicks. t clicks, and things have never felt more clear .

She swallows the bite.

"Catra," she starts slowly , but with growing force. "I don't want that."

Catra's voice sounds all-knowing as she asks:

"What don't you want?"

"I—" Adora gasps a little. Flutterina's words are echoing in her mind, and she raises her voice over them. "I don't want a career like that. I don't care about playing professionally, I just… I guess I just went with it because it happened, because a door opened and I didn't even think before going in because it made sense but it makes no sense!" Adora knocks her plate down next to Catra's, turning towards her. She confesses like it's a sin: "I love coaching. I love this camp, and I love to be here. I… I want to be here. I want to do this. I want… *this* ."

Her words mean too many things now, and it is getting harder to slow her thoughts before blurting them out. She releases the air in her lungs again, in breathy little chuckles, her fingers crawl up her temples.

Catra scoots a little closer now, her warm hand coming up to Adora's shoulder. Adora's breathing slows down.

"Then take it," Catra whispers.

Adora blinks at her. She drops her hands.

"You knew," she says, just as quiet. "How did you know?"

Catra's voice is breathless from suppressed laughter.

"Adora, you told me not to take you to the ER to save your career because there was a chance you couldn't finish coaching your kids. It wasn't hard."

"You could have just told me," Adora says, offended.

Catra shrugs and draws back.

"Where's the fun in that? Besides, you wouldn't have listened. You're stubborn enough to only care about what you think is true."

That makes sense. Adora flops to the backrest, staring at the ceiling. She feels… overwhelmed like she is being dragged down just as much as she feels like floating away. Her mind is empty but her head is heavy enough that it lolls back on the cushion.

She couldn't really do that, could she? Throwing it all away, stepping back from her contract, settling for a nice coaching job … moving down here, maybe.closer to her friends, the people she loves.

Closer to Catra.

She does not know how many minutes she has zoned out like that when she feels the cushions lift with Catra's weight gone. Her head bounces back. At some point, Melog crawled into Adora's lap and now she complains with a quiet *mrrnyp*.

"We need to leave soon," Catra says. "I'll pack some stuff I wanna take back. Get ready too, okay?"

"Yeah," Adora says, gently placing Melog back onto a pillow. "Sorry, I—"

"Don't."

Catra slips out the door. Adora staggers to her feet, getting her fanny pack and pacing around the room mindlessly.

She finds herself in front of Catra's heavily decorated wall, her fingertips sliding across the dozens of notes and pictures. Her eyes are scanning through them without finding anything interesting, when-

Adora's breath hitches. She pinches the loose corner of the paper between her fingers; it is a torn out page from a square grid notebook. The right side turned hard and bumpy; Adora remembers spilling Dr Pepper on it.

Hi babe ♡

Since you're in detention (AGAIN) and can't hang out with your super hot girlfriend (me) this afternoon, I have a proposal

I 'm not saying what it is yet, because it's a surprise. Which I know you hate, but trust me - it's gonna be amazing. And fun. And romantic. Sooo romantic. So make sure you have nothing to do this Friday night because I want you all for myself ;)

Ps. Please don't get into even more trouble I really miss you and I 'm contemplating doing something stupid so I can be with you in there

Ps.2 I love you

"Ready?" Catra calls from the hallway .

Adora tears the page off the wall and crumples it a little in her first.

"Yeah," she mutters, cheeks and ears burning hot. She folds and shoves the paper in her pocket as she stands high to reply, loud and clear: "I'm ready!"

Chapter End Notes

HELLO BEAUTIFUL PEOPLE AND I'M SORRY FOR THE WAIT
But here we are, you and me, gay (probably) and proud and personally, I think this is my favorite chapter yet. Also you might notice that I changed the chapter number to 7 because fuck that's where I am at, just 7. Every chapter I write gets longer and the end drifts further away. I'd say six now but I don't trust myself and so neither should you.

I had so much fun writing Catra as the kid who always gave you a hard fucking time because they kept making inappropriate sounds whenever your parents called and she is yet to grow out of that.
Also
Adora: Aaa nothing matches in Catra's apartment she's so cool and creative :)
Catra: Is it TECHNICALLY stealing if they left it on the street
Also
Frosta totally cheats in her bet with Flutterina because she gets all the inside info from Glimmer. Poor girl doesn't have a chance.

Anyway, fuck, thank you so much for your support on this fic! ♡ Thank you all for the lovely comments, for subscribing, for enjoying it - please do consider leaving me a comment because it really keeps me going, and don't be shy to hang out with me on Tumblr. I go by @e-ra there, and I have a whole fic tag (#ela writes) for sneak peaks and illustrations and any additional shit you might enjoy while I'm still working on the next chapter.

If you enjoyed reading, please consider supporting the fic by sharing my post about it!

Ilove you all, see you soon (ISWEAR) and hang out with me on Tumblr it's a fun time. ♡

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

In which Adora takes control.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora slips out of her shorts and folds them on top of the drawer. The corner of the paper she took hangs out of her pocket, inviting and inspiring.

Adora peeks towards the closed bathroom door. Water is sloshing behind it as Catra washes her face and gets ready for bed, so Adora pinches the paper between her fingertips and pulls it out, unfolds and reads again. And again.

She cannot say she remembers writing this exact message, just the Dr Pepper incident; she used to leave little love notes for Catra almost daily, sliding them in her locker, her backpack, her pockets, her books. Why Catra chose to keep this one, she does not know. If she even has a reason for it, although Catra has reasons for everything she ever does. There must be something about this one in particular that Adora must figure out, pay closer attention to.

This was not the first time she said *I love you*. Adora confessed her love earlier, in person. She remembers that word by word, and could still recite it by heart. She is pretty sure she called Catra "baby" before, too. Is it her determination to get into trouble for her that Catra found important? Or is it about their date?

Shit, which date was that? They did not have many actual dates Adora arranged, that were not just them hanging out. Making out somewhere, mostly.

They went to the amusement park once… Adora had insane period cramps and threw up after two rides. Probably not that.

They went to watch movies a lot, but that was neither heavily planned nor really romantic as past Adora promises. And definitely not treated as dates.

What else? Concerts. Some dinner dates, if you can call getting fast food after school a dinner date. Stargazing.

Stargazing! That was it.

Adora remembers that. It *was* fun and romantic. It was pre-Darla days so Adora packed a big backpack full of blankets and snacks and drinks, took Catra's hand and they walked down to the lake close to where Adora lived. The sun was just setting when they arrived and they watched it dip below the forest on the other side, and they talked and laughed and the stars came up twinkling like fairy lights and…

Adora *feels* Catra's lips on her own as she recalls that night. Catra always leaned in softly, like she would apologise over and over about their first where she just slammed their mouths together hastily. She savored every second, kissing Adora gently like she is made of glass and air. It made Adora feel small and cherished, cared for. Her lips tingle as she touches them with the tips of her fingers, chasing the ghost of Catra's silky skin.

Catra turns off the tap in the bathroom.

Adora turns and hides the paper in the upper drawer, between her shirts. She drags her pajama shorts up her thighs and takes off her bra from under a grey tank top.

Catra comes out of the bathroom. She shoots Adora a kind glance as she steps next to her and packs her day clothes in the lowest drawer that they use instead of a laundry basket.

Adora tries to swallow the dry lump forming in her throat.

"Hey ," she starts awkwardly .

Catra straightens, her smile almost shy.

"Hey ."

t is a crime, really, for Catra to wear her sports bra and skintight leggings right now instead of the oversized shirt she uses to sleep in. Adora's glance becomes unfocused, snapping up to Catra's face after a couple seconds of delay on her curvy waist and soft stomach.

"Are you free tomorrow night?"

Catra's lips part a little bit. She raises an eyebrow quickly , hiding the fractures of surprise.

"I dont know. I have an annoying blonde roommate who wants to hang out with me all the time."

"She sounds great," Adora grins. "W anna invite her too?"

"Who's the third wheel?"

"Probably you, Im getting fond of the annoying blonde."

"Oh, do you need some alone time? I can leave," Catra says with a point of her thumb and starts to back away. Her mismatched irises flicker playfully.

"Dont you dare," Adora says and reaches out for her wrist.

"Hey!"

Catra shrieks as Adora grabs her by the waist and lifts her up like she weighs nothing. Adora climbs onto the bed with a now laughing Catra in her arms, their cheeks pressed together, and flops her down

on the mattress like a sack of potatoes while Adora keeps holding onto her.

Catra lets out the cutest little squeak; Adora has to bite the inside of her cheek to not coo at her.

"Do you want to break this bed too?" Catra asks, still breathless from laughing.

Adora pulls back reluctantly, sitting on her heels. She shrugs sheepishly as she leans on her thighs.

"Scorpia already broke it last summer. This is a new one."

Catra draws her legs up and crosses her ankles. Her eyes are still twinkling mischievously as she rests her cheek in her palm, her elbow digging into her knee. She is waiting for something, and it takes Adora a couple seconds to realize that the *thing* is her.

Adora swallows, thick and dry. She is tapping her fingers on her thigh. Her voice is way more confident than how she is feeling.

"So. Can I take you somewhere? Tomorrow night."

Catra squints curiously.

"Where?"

"That's a surprise," Adora says, and gains courage to take things a step further. Her own written words are imprinted on her heart now. "Just trust me. It's gonna be fun."

The corner of Catra's lips twitches. She keeps quiet for a while, her eyes keeping Adora's captive.

"Okay."

Adora perks up, eyes wide.

"Okay?"

"Yeah… okay," Catra says again, then gets off the bed to take her charger from the drawer and put her phone on.

Adora nestles under the covers, half-sitting, fond eyes following Catra step to the switch and flip it down. She hopes the darkness covers for her, but Catra is still just standing there, turning towards her slowly.

"What are you staring at?"

Adora reaches her arm out.

"C'mere," she says softly.

Catra stays put for a heartbeat. Then, she walks to the bed, and a soft warm palm slides into Adora's.

Adora squeezes her hand and draws her in, holding her hand up like they are dancing and spins her away again so she faces the window instead of Adora. Then, Adora soothes her arm down to Catra's waist and pulls her in. Catra's body becomes rigid as she is cradled to lay down, tucked in gently; her back is pressed right to Adora's chest, and her legs curl up instinctively. Adora draws her knees up too, Catra's ass in the valley of her lap as she wreathes her arm around her waist.

"Is it comfortable?" Adora whispers.

Catra melts a bit, her muscles relaxing with a deep exhale. She takes Adora's hand that lays in front of her and laces their fingers together. She guides them both to her heart, her head rolling down until her lips are almost touching Adora's knuckles.

"Yeah."

Adora's chest is burning warm, her smile too. She presses her cheek to Catra's nape.

"Goodnight, Catra."

"Night."

Adora wakes with a start, darkness surrounding her. She does not know how long she had slept, and for a solid minute she is unsure what woke her up, mind still hazy with sleep.

Then, she notices and her heart sinks to her stomach.

Catra is trembling in her arms, like she has a high fever; they are still laying in the same pose in which they fell asleep, Adora feeling Catra's shakes deep in her bones.

Adora winces and pushes herself up on her elbow.

"Are you okay?" she breathes, and feels Catra shift.

Without saying a word, Catra twirls - their eyes meet for a split second, Catra's irises dull and dim- and slams her body to Adora's. She nestles under Adora's jaw, her arms trapped between their bodies. She is still shivering, her raspy gasps fluttering on Adora's skin.

Adora's voice grows high and childlike with worry.

"Catra, what's wrong?"

Catra burrows tighter, like she would want to crawl inside Adora's chest, to hide away, her fingers hooking into Adora's tank top to claw and drag. Her voice is weak as she whispers to Adora's throat.

"Just..hold me."

And so Adora does. She hurries to lay back down and slides an arm under Catra's chest, palm on her nape; her other hand comes up Catra's back, stroking her gently, pouring as much love and care into

her fingertips as she possibly can. She nestles into Catra's hair, breathing in deep.

"I'm here," Adora chokes, her nose filled with Catra's scent. "I'm here. It's okay. You're okay."

"Don't let go."

"I won't. I won't."

Adora keeps stroking and caressing, tender fingertips drawing tiny shapes on Catra's skin from her back to her shoulders, slick with cold sweat. Slowly but steadily, Catra's shakes fade away. There are silent breaks between a couple twitches now, to which Adora always reacts by squeezing Catra's body even tighter. Her biceps start to ache and her heart is drumming against her ribs, but she keeps holding Catra as close as is physically possible, petting Catra's soft waves, too.

After a while, Catra's breathing slows down to a smooth rhythm and she starts snoring quietly. Adora takes her chance to release the tension in her muscles without drawing back even an inch. She squirms into a more comfortable position, facing the ceiling, and carefully pulls Catra partially on top of her.

Catra moans weakly. Adora soothes Catra's hair back from her face, her thumb stroking over her eyebrow. Without thinking, Adora cranes her neck and presses her lips to Catra's forehead.

She falls asleep, too.

friday

"Why do you need all of these, again?" Glimmer asks, standing in the middle of her and Bow's bungalow while Adora rushes around

her in circles like a blonde tornado.

"For Darla!" Adora says and snatches another pillow from the top shelf of their closet. She halts then, stumbling a bit as her eyes are scanning through the piles of knickknacks inside. "Do you have fairy lights?"

"Adora, we're at a soccer camp," Glimmer says.

"Right."

"Of course I have fairy lights."

Glimmer steps by Adora's side and tiptoes, sinking elbow deep into the disorganized mess. She pulls out two sets of warm white lights; one is the classic string, the other is a wall of lights in the shape of tiny stars. Both working with batteries, thank God.

"Can I take both?"

"Uh, sure. Adora, seriously, what's going on?" Glimmer scoffs without edge. "You can't just march in here and start stealing our stuff without at least explaining why."

Adora sucks her lips in and stops again. She turns on her heels very slowly, both hands full of stuff, towering so high that Adora has to tilt her head to the side so she can look at Glimmer.

Adora confesses the exact second Bow opens the door:

"I asked Catra out on a date."

"*You what?!*" Bow and Glimmer shout in unison, although in completely different tones; while Glimmer's shrieking sounds shocked and just a touch judgemental, Bow's scream is full of joy and anticipation.

"I didn't technically say *date*," Adora adds, bumping her forehead into the fluffy blanket in front of her. She mumbles into the fur: "But I think

that's what it is. I hope that's what it is."

Glimmer and Bow share a quick look, then they walk to the opposing sides of Adora to take a couple of things from her hands so they can all see better.

"Well, what *did* you say?" Glimmer asks, holding a sequined pillow to her chest and reaching for another.

"I asked her if she's free tonight and if I can take her somewhere."

"Good enough?" Glimmer asks Bow with a little shrug.

"Good enough. I mean she's obviously into you, I'm sure what you meant is how she took it."

Adora gawks, blushing a little.

"You think she's into me?"

Glimmer whines like she is in physical pain and turns around to plop down onto the bed.

"Adora, I love you with all my heart, but seriously?"

"What."

Glimmer gestures towards Bow: "Babe, a little help?"

Bow pats Glimmer's shoulder and takes over: "It's kinda impossible to miss. Ever since she's arrived she was all over you."

"No, she wasn't." Adora objects, offended. "That's just… we have history. She told me to leave her alone, remember?"

"One time!" Glimmer throws her hands up. "Then she managed to flirt with you so unashamedly that everyone is talking about you two. The kids even took a bet on when you're gonna get together." Glimmer clears her throat, tapping her nose. "So I heard."

Adora's voice turns deep and rough.

"*No*."

Bow puckers his lips.

"Okay, so don't check Twitter."

"I don't have a Twitter," Adora says gravelly. "What's on Twitter?"

Glimmer grins brightly, forming a hashtag with her fingers.

"*Coachcatradora*, baby!"

Adora whimpers loudly at that. She must look just as miserable as she feels, because Glimmer hurries to add:

"It's just a bunch of kids being kids. Don't worry about it, it's innocent fun between the teams."

Adora drops everything and buries her face into her hands.

"Do you think she saw?"

"Probably not," Bow says, voice breaking.

"Why does it matter?" Glimmer chimes in, still trying to sound encouraging. "Not like it's trending or anything, what happens on the *Camp Etheria* Twitter stays on the *Camp Etheria* Twitter."

Adora peeks through her fingers, glaring at Glimmer.

"Did you *share* them there?"

"Uuh-" Glimmer's nose turns pink. "Anyway, do you really think it's wise to date Catra aga-"

The bungalow door opens again. Adora yelps just a bit as she turns and sees Catra standing there in her usual evening workout attire,

with a tiny box in her hand.

"Can you ever knock?" Glimmer gets at her immediately .

Catra raises an eyebrow and knocks on the open door theatrically.

"Hey ," she says then, and nods to Bow. He makes a bowl from his hands and catches the box Catra throws at him. Adora recognizes that it is for Bow's earbuds. "Thanks. They're really better for running."

"I told you. You can borrow them any time you want."

Catra's glance scans through the room, settling down on the stuff Adora has hoarded and which are now in piles on the ground.

"What are you doing?"

"We're- we-, uh-" Adora stammers.

"Decluttering!" Bow cuts in, and Adora points at him.

"Yes. Exactly. That."

"You do have a lot of junk, Sparkles."

"Hey!"

Catra takes a couple steps closer, making a path with pushing a couple blankets away with her foot.

"Are you over your fluffy blanket phase?"

"We're just starting with the easy ones," Bow saves the day again, while all Adora can do is try her best to not stare at Catra's all too exposed, glistening skin. Sweat sticks to her stomach and arms like beads of pearls, her pinned up hair wet and even curlier than usual.

Adora stares at Glimmer and Bow, begging with her eyes. Thankfully, Glimmer knows exactly what can drive Catra away.

"W anna help, Catra"?

"Oh, no." And with that, Catra halts. She crosses her arms and catches Adora's uncertain look with hers as she smirks. "Y ou didn't say what time Ishould be ready , Princess."

So Catra still acts like nothing unusual has happened last night. After Adora finally decided to not only take anything Catra is offering her, but ask for more, Catra's breakdown was… frightening. Adora took it as a warning, almost, a bright, blinking STOP sign that raises a clear border between can and should, but Catra's words-

"Don't let go .

t resonates differently with Adora. t makes her feel guilty, of all things, like for some reason, it is all her fault, but not because she let herself be bold - but for waiting for so long to do so.

Catra is still looking at her, eyebrows raised. There is something in her eyes Adora cannot figure out.

"Uh,"Adora manages to say . Her throat is so dry. "Eight"?

"Any clues for style"? Catra asks, folding her arms a little tighter. "I want to look.appropriate."

Glimmer makes a sound that is the opposite of that. Adora is suddenly hyper aware of her and Bow being present.

Adora shoots them a disapproving glare and Bow pinches his fingers together, pulling them across Glimmer's lips to seal them.

"Casual,"Adora says. "Like, comfortable. W arm"?

Catra snickers.

"Are you just gonna wrap me in Sparkles' fluffy blankets and call it a date?"

"*No*," Adora says, a bit too obvious. Two seconds pass. Then, she feels blood rushing out of her face and steps closer to Catra. She asks, very quietly: "What did you say?"

When Catra realizes as well, the flickers in her narrow eyes are almost shy. She glances away before settling for eye contact that tingles Adora's skin.

Catra's voice is husky but challenging.

"Am I wrong?"

"No," Adora breathes, unable to stop herself from grinning. "It's a date."

"Dork," Catra mumbles, and turns on her heels. "Alright. I'm gonna take a shower and get ready. Good luck with...whatever this is."

And with that, Catra leaves and lets the door open.

Glimmer sighs and lays down on her back, arms stretched out.

"I guess I should get used to this now, huh?"

Adora is still grinning, biting her lip to somehow contain herself. It is no use; she is so all over the place she could run a marathon with her fucked up hamstrings and would not even notice.

She says nothing, just humming to herself and starts packing a bag with the date accessories.

Adora stays at Glimmer and Bow's to get ready too. She sent Glimmer over for her clothes, avoiding looking at Catra like a bride on their wedding day. She is aware of how bizarre that is, but she is

way too far gone to care. Her stomach is in an agonizing knot, pushing bile up her throat. She is more nervous than before any game or exam she has ever taken, and yet, she is buzzing with energy that she tries to help with bouncing her legs.

Glimmer comes back with Adora's date attire and a brand new attitude that Adora had expected from her, really. Leaving her alone with Catra for even three minutes can do that to her.

"Here," Glimmer grunts through gritted teeth and pushes the bag of clothes into Adora's hand. "You're *very* welcome."

"I appreciate your sacrifice," Adora says and peels off her coach clothes.

She changes into a simple white shirt with a gold collar and rims, and booty shorts that show her thighs that Catra seems to be very fond of.

"Knee socks, yes or no?" She asks Bow.

Bow eyes Adora up and down from the bed. Glimmer rests her head in his lap, laying sideways on the bedspread and playing on her phone.

"They're cute. And on brand for you. Which shoes are you wearing?"

"Uh-"

"I brought your red Converse and the white tennis shoes," Glimmer says without looking up from the screen. Adora takes one of each out of the bag and holds them up. "I'll go with the tennis shoes. I'm partial to the golden wings."

"Bow?"

"Agreed."

"Catra did too. Just saying."

Adora *shoves* the Converse into the corner like it burned her hand.

Glimmer raises her head at the heavy thud that the impact caused, and glances up at Adora's guilt-tainted face.

"Are you gonna wear makeup?"

"No." Adora laces her shoes and rolls her ankle to check if they are comfortable. "I feel better without it." And Catra likes her better, too. "I thought maybe I'd let my hair down?"

"*Yes*," Bow and Glimmer hiss in unison.

"Okay , wow," Adora mumbles and takes her elastic out, rolling it on her wrist. She smooths some locks behind her ears and pins her friends on the bed.

Adora lifts Glimmer's legs and slides under them so Glimmer can rest her shins on Adora's thighs. Adora leans on Bow's shoulder then, and takes her phone in her hand. She still has fifteen minutes to spare before she should leave; enough time to go through everything before the real deal.

Glimmer peeks up at Adora's screen curiously. She nearly drops her own phone in her face.

"Did you make a *presentation* for your date?"

Adora blushes and turns the screen away from her, raising it above her head.

"No! And it's private." She pouts and glares some, then sighs deeply. She draws her hands back, letting Bow and Glimmer take one quick look. "Okay , maybe. I just. Want to be prepared, so I made a couple notes, it's not a big deal."

"Oh, Adora," Bow says, eyes scanning through the bullet points. "This is a battle plan. How many pages do you have?"

"I dunno," Adora mumbles. She does know. Eight. She takes a deep breath, putting her phone in her lap, screen down. She draws her shoulders up. "Look, you don't get it. I need to use this one chance to show Catra what I can do, or she might not give me another one. It has to be perfect."

Glimmer puts her phone away too. Without the squeaky, jingling sounds of her game, the sudden silence is too hollow and solemn.

"Adora," she starts softly, "are you really sure you want to be with Catra again?"

Adora does not hesitate, looking at Glimmer like she lost her mind to even ask her this.

"Yeah."

Glimmer glances at Bow. He nods encouragingly, so she sits up, nestling between Adora and Bow. She reaches for Adora's hand and squeezes it.

"We're just worried about you. You seem to be really… serious about this, really fast."

"You told me she was into me too."

"And she is, totally, it's just." Glimmer clicks her tongue. "We don't know what happened between you two, and it's none of our business-"

"But we care about you, and wanna make sure you won't end up getting hurt."

"I have to try," Adora says again, firm but kind. "You don't know Catra like I do."

Glimmer tilts her head.

"Maybe you don't know Catra the way you think you do."

Adora feels prickly now. She draws her hand back, the flare in her eyes glowing brighter as she hardens her glance.

"Just say what you mean, Glimmer! If you know something-"

"I don't." Glimmer's voice sounds more desperate now. "Listen, all we're trying to say is that you're obviously very serious about this, and we really, truly hope Catra is too, but she… well, she's Catra. She might just want to get some fun out of this."

"Then she will," Adora says, her intention of ending the conversation is evident in her tone. "I told you, you don't get it. Thank you for trying to protect me but this is about us. I know her. Just trust me on this, okay?"

Glimmer swallows. Adora can see that she has much to say left, but thankfully, she just nods.

"Okay," Bow says. "We trust you."

"And we'll always be here for you. Whatever happens."

Adora's frustration is fading away. She smiles, reaching out and hugs them both, squeezing tight.

"Thanks, guys. Don't worry about me. I know what I'm doing."

"Yeah, right," Glimmer snorts. "Now go, get the girl. It's time."

Adora gasps dramatically and stares at the clock. It is almost eight.

She jumps out of bed, zipping up the two suitcases full of stuff. She throws the strap of one over her head and holds the other in her fist.

"Alright," she breathes, leaping for the door. "Wish me luck!"

"Good luck!"

"Go, Adora!"

Adora points a finger gun at them and pulls the trigger with a *pew*, pretending to blow off the fume. She catches Glimmer's eye roll as she twirls out the door, which reminds her of something.

Adora pops up again, hanging her head inside almost horizontally .

"Oh, and Glimmer? I broke my bed, you should get a new one. I'll cover your expenses. I'm sorry , love you! Don't wait up!"

Adora is already jogging down the wooden stair when she hears Glimmer howling:

"When did you break the fucking bed?"

"Last week!"

Glimmer screams bloody murder. She would make a great ambulance siren.

Adora loads the suitcases on the backseats and slams Darla's door. As she is sneaking back to the office bungalow for the last two Perfect Date Accessories, she fishes her phone out of her pocket again.

Catra

Are you ready to date?)

i changed my mind after you asked it like that

Aww Catra :(((

fine, i am.

😊😊😊 Meet me at Darla?

ok

Adora locks her phone and pushes it back into her back pocket. She unlocks the office bungalow door and turns the lights on, since it's already dusky and dim outside.

Adora finds the bottle of rosé champagne cooling down in the refrigerator, with a little note attached.

Have fun,honey!Nettie and I are rooting for you!

- S

Adora smiles and takes the bottle by the neck. She turns to the desk now, and slips a single red rose out of the vase. There is no note attached to that, but Adora asked Mermista in text if she could have one of the roses that Seahawk sent her for their anniversary (*take him too,h' 'tP AYU* ").

With the flower and the bottle in each hand, Adora feels ready, and just a little fuzz inside like the bubbly champagne. Between planning the perfect date and rearranging her whole team a day before the big game, she had no time to go to town and buy things herself. Thankfully, her staff team got her back; now the whole thing feels like a group project.

Her friends have tried to get her dates before, so their support is no surprise but still warms Adora's heart. She always assumed that they felt compelled to get her a girlfriend because ever since she started working here, she is the only single one. (Well, Socrpia started as single but quickly fell for the cute counselor so that lasted a month.)

Not like Adora had minded being alone, but no one knew what she knew - that she already found who she wanted to be with, and lost her once.

Now she will get her back, whatever it takes.

Adora arrives to Darla before Catra, so she has time to hide the rose and the champagne too. Just as she comes round the car to open the passenger door, Catra appears behind her.

"Hey , Adora."

Adora twirls around, a loopy grin on her face already; it quickly freezes into something akin to awe when she sees Catra.

"Hi," she manages to say, swallowing against the dry stimuli to cough. Her whole body is warming up. "You look.whoa."

Catra just smiles. She seems to be aware of the effect she has on Adora, and doubles it by leaning casually on Darla, so the lace bustier top slides even higher on her ribs.

"Casual enough?" Catra purrs.

Adora licks her lips. She does not know about that, but it is definitely a look.

Before she could say anything witty, Catra peeks inside Darla, raising an eyebrow at the fully packed bags.

"Ooh, are we hiding a body?"

Adora steps by her side and opens the door for Catra.

"You'd love that, wouldn't you?"

"Wouldn't be the worst first date I've ever had." Catra climbs in, squinting at Adora. "Not the best either, but you know my immaculate date planning skills."

Adora leans her elbow on the door frame, quirking a brow at Catra.

"Just you wait. I'll show you immaculate."

Catra turns in the seat, her knees almost reaching Adora's chest. She crosses her arms and leans ahead.

"Do you really think you planned a better date than mine? Do I have to remind you the time you threw u-"

Adora blurts out, raising both hands:

"Questions and constructive criticism at the end of the date, please."

Catra chuckles and turns on the seat again, facing the windshield.

"Fine. But I'll keep score."

Adora smiles fondly.

"I know you will."

The ride to Adora's secret hideout is mostly silent, but serene. She only has to drive a couple minutes before she turns on a rocky serpentine, and Darla starts jumping on the bumps, wild nature surrounding them in the falling darkness.

Catra was staring out of the window up until this point. Now she turns to Adora with a crooked grin.

"Okay, we're totally hiding a body."

Adora lets go of the wheel to shove Catra's shoulder and shush her firmly.

They both chuckle.

"You can open your eyes now," Adora says, and watches Catra's expression piercingly, carefully, hyperfocused on every tiny flinch and twitch.

Catra's eyelashes flutter, her jaw pops open a little. The sigh that escapes her is a little shaky; quiet and wonderstruck. She takes a couple steps closer to the unhinged tailgate, reaching out to stroke the corner of the closest blanket.

"I totally swept you off your feet," Adora says and crosses her arms, completely uncool and unable to control herself. "You *looove* it."

"It's... not bad," Catra says.

"There's another thing," Adora says and reaches inside through the rolled down window, pulling the rose out.

Catra rolls her eyes, but she cannot mask the smile that curls her lips.

"Ugh, no."

"Uhh, yes." Adora takes Catra's hand and guides her fingers around the rose. She draws Catra closer, tilting the rose to boop her nose. Catra giggles.

"Stop."

"I know you're a secret romantic."

"Lies and slander," Catra objects and pretends to try and bite the head of the rose off.

Adora gasps dramatically. "You animal!"

She fights the rose away, which only brings Catra closer with a tug. Adora's chest warms up where it meets Catra's body, and tilts her head so their lips don't crash.

Catra licks her lips slowly, hunger flashing in her eyes. It sets fire to Adora's insides, a knot twisting in her abdomen with greedy need. It would be too early, though; and she is not going that easy on Catra or herself.

So Adora just grins, flashing her teeth.

"I'll give you something to bite into later," she says, now stroking Catra's cheek with the rose. "If you behave."

Catra's gaze falls on Adora's lips before she averts it to the truck bed floor, then back to Adora's eyes. She raises her brows.

"Shoes off?"

"Yeah."

Catra takes the rose, burying her nose into the petals. She steps back without turning or letting Adora's eyes wander anywhere else but her. When she bumps into it, she hops on the truck bed floor, feet dangling down. Silver moonlight flickers in her determined eyes, and Adora understands immediately. She follows and gets on her good knee, reaching for Catra's boots. She unlaces and slides them off Catra's ankles like she is made of glass. Her palm lingers on Catra's calf, fingertips smoothing across the pattern of her fishnet stockings.

Catra leans on her hands and pulls herself backwards on the truck bed floor, deeper into the cozy nest of blankets and pillows.

She lays down with a contented sigh, then peeks up again.

"You coming?"

Adora takes off her shoes too, and climbs next to Catra.

Half a bottle of champagne later (that they sip straight from the bottle since Adora forgot to bring glasses) they are laying on the blankets facing away from each other, laughing so high and hard that they make no sound apart from a couple squeaks and raspy inhales.

Adora is drooling onto a pillow, her stomach spasming painfully when another wave of laughter hits her. Catra is fighting for air beside her, legs in the air as she turns on her back.

Adora takes a chance at peeking at Catra the same time Catra does too. As soon as their eyes meet, Catra chokes on a giggle and they lose their shit again.

Once they are calming down, slow and steady, Catra whimpers miserably.

Adora croaks:

"Do you think he could ever look at sour candy the same way again?"

Catra wipes her tears with the back of her hand.

"Probably not. Poor fucker looked traumatized for life. To be fair, I definitely almost killed him."

"I wonder what's up with him. I didn't expect him to survive puberty."

"He's just adopted a kid with Rogelio and Lonnie," Catra mentions offhandedly like they would be chatting about the weather.

Adora twirls towards Catra, jaw open and eyes wide.

"What?! How do you know?!"

"They have that stupid joined Facebook account since they've gone poly."

"I don't believe it."

"I swear on Glimmer's grave I'm not shitting you. Here."

Catra takes her phone out from her pocket and tilts the screen so Adora can see it too. She opens the app and shows Adora a family picture taken at the beach - all toothy grins, eyes squinting in the sun and flushed shoulders... and the ugliest baby strapped on Rogelio's chest Adora has ever seen.

"Oh my God," Adora whimpers, trying to not say anything rude.

"I know . He looks like a potato."

"Every baby looks like a potato."

"I'm talking about Kyle."

"Oh."

"But you're also right. Man, that's an ugly baby ."

Adora snorts sharply.

"Catra!"

"What? You're thinking the same thing. You're not better than me."

"Sometimes I hate that you always know what I'm thinking."

Adora scoots a little closer. She is not touching Catra anywhere, curling her body the same angle Catra is laying on her back, resting her head above Catra's shoulder. She can feel the warmth of Catra's body soothing her. If she turned her head just a tiny bit, their cheeks would press together. The thought of that is another rush of heat that swirls lower and lower in her stomach.

Catra's thumb is hovering above the screen, when she says, quietly:

"I don't know what you're thinking right now."

Adora curls her hand into a fist and pulls it under her jaw. She is still staring at the posted picture, her mind wandering.

"They look so happy."

Catra swallows audibly.

"Yeah. They do."

"Do you ever think," Adora starts weakly. "Do you ever think that maybe you've fallen behind in life? Like… look at our class. Everyone is married or having kids, or-"

"We're gay, Adora."

"So are they," Adora objects, gesturing towards the screen. "Name one heterosexual from that picture. The baby doesn't count, we don't know. I get the repressed thing, trust me, I do, but look at them. I didn't even know what I wanted to do with my life before I met you again."

Catra breathes out in a surprised huff, so Adora goes on, softer this time:

"I barely had the courage to ask you out again."

"But you did. So, y'know." Catra shrugs, the tip of her nose flushed deep. "Who cares when and how."

"I lost so many years to things I didn't even want. It just... makes me so mad."

"Okay, I'm not telling you that doesn't suck. And"… Catra's voice fades, "I know what you mean."

I'm sorry."

"No," Catra scoffs; it sounds like a miserable, lifeless laugh. She slides the back of her hand to her forehead. "I'm sorry."

Adora tilts her head up a bit; the tip of her nose brushes Catra's cheek.

Catra puts her phone down, taking a deep breath. Her hand searches for Adora's to hold and squeeze. Adora nestles close enough for their bodies to touch, lacing their fingers together.

They fell quiet for a while; Adora's phone is playing quietly beside them, a playlist that she put together this morning. She did not really have the time to think through which songs she should add to it, but some conscious choices were made.

Countless stars are twinkling above them, peppering the deep blue sky like powdered sugar. Adora hanged Glimmer's fairy lights around them on the sides and flowing from the rear panel; their warm light illuminates Catra's skin and hair, transforming her into a beautiful, glowing mirage. Adora can barely believe she is able to touch her and she does not shatter into golden dust under her palm.

Beyond the crisscross cliffs, the sea is swashing and rumbling. Waves crash into stone, moonlight dancing on them like strobe lights.

"Shooting star," Adora whispers as she catches a glimpse of a falling gleam.

Catra hums, and Adora closes her eyes.

A moment later, her phone switches to the song she was most excited about.

She pushes herself up, grinning down at Catra who makes a disgusted grimace at the familiar drumming beat.

"Are you serious?"

"Come on, we have to," Adora pokes her between her ribs, and slides off the truck bed floor in a second. "It's our song!"

Catra growls loudly and sits up straight. "It's a sorry excuse for a prom slow dance."

"It's our song," Adora repeats firmly, brushing aside Catra's complaints and reaching out.

Catra is glaring. She reaches for the champagne next to her and takes a couple gulps. She props the bottle back to the corner then, and accepts Adora's hand.

The grass is rustling under their soles. Adora pulls Catra in, not caring about keeping distance between them any longer.

This time, she leads. She slides her arm around Catra's waist, her other hand holding Catra's in line with their shoulder. Catra follows willingly, her palm coming up to the side of Adora's neck, her thumb stroking above her artery, feeling blood thrumming under their skin.

Adora can feel a grin creeping on her face once again, completely off-brand for the slow, romantic song that they are slow dancing once again, seven years later, but she cannot help it. Catra scoffs kindly and replies with a smile on her own; her eyes are dark, so many lights reflecting in them dazzlingly; the stars, the moon, the fairy lights, the mirror of the fire burning in Adora's own eyes.

Catra looks away. Adora draws her in tighter, their bodies flushed as she rests her cheek to Catra's temple. Catra's muscles relax under her with a shaky sigh, sending a shiver up Adora's spine.

They are swaying gently to the music, barely moving.

"So," Adora says. "How am I doing so far?"

Catra makes a small noise at the back of her throat.

"Is that really all you can think about right now? Your date grade?"

"Not *all*, but-"

Catra giggles.

"Nerd."

"Jerk," Adora replies just as fondly. She brushes her lips across Catra's knuckles as she raises their arms and spins Catra. "I told you I wanted to dance with you again, didn't I? Last weekend."

She catches a glimpse of Catra's surprise on her features as she twirls back.

"I didn't think you'd remember."

Adora pulls her back in by her waist, quick and heated, still so tender. She presses their cheeks together again, the heel of her palm stroking up Catra's side carefully.

"I remember a couple things," she whispers into Catra's ear. "How you held me. How you took care of me."

"Yeah well, you were shitfaced."

"How I told you you are the best thing that's ever happened to me."

Catra freezes. Adora chuckles, her arm sliding tighter around Catra's waist. They keep quiet for a while; Catra's breathing becomes a little loud and rugged, her chest fluttering against Adora's.

Adora looks up at the sky, mumbling to the stars:

"I really meant that, you know." Catra nuzzles into Adora's neck, hiding. "I really." Adora bites her tongue, breathing in deep.

I really loved you, back then.

The song is slowly coming to an end, but neither of them lets go. Catra unlaces their fingers to stroke Adora's inner wrist, leaving for the length of her arm and coming up resting on her shoulder. Adora fondles the small of Catra's back under the lace of her top, gentle and patient. Catra's fingers are twitching on Adora's skin.

"Do you remember" Adora begins, wincing at the sound of her own voice, "when we kissed last time?"

Catra makes a sound Adora cannot decode if it means yes or no. It sounds wet, like a sniff.

"The end of that stargazing date. Just a peck to say goodnight." Adora digs her nails into Catra's skin absentmindedly; Catra presses closer with a shaky gasp. Adora keeps quiet for a moment. "If I knew that was gonna be the last time, I would have kissed you differently."

Catra's voice is hoarse and nasally in her ear.

"Like how?"

Adora's gaze flickers between stars as she furrows her brows, her tongue darting across her lips.

"I guess I should've... I should've left no room for doubt and questions, I should have kissed you so you know exactly how I felt about you. I should've just. Gone for it and give it my all, heh," Adora ends with a meek chuckle and a fist raised behind Catra's back.

Catra shifts under her, drawing back so their eyes could meet. She drops her hands to Adora's hips, fingers clinging tight.

Catra's pupils are so dilated, both her irises look dark and endless like abysses, the whites of her eyes are shining like glass. Her lashes stick together wetly from her mascara, a little smudge under her waterline. She raises her jaw.

"Show me."

Adora's heart jumps to her throat. The air is stuck in her lungs as she heaves ahead swiftly like she is afraid of the moment slipping away, but stops herself in the last second. She exhales in a breathy chuckle, eyebrows raised questioningly. Her hands cup Catra's face, fingers trembling. Every inch of her body is screaming to close the distance, but all she can do is hold Catra's face and beg with her eyes for affirmation.

Are you serious?

Catra's expression is unreadable, almost arrogant. She dips her head to the side then, smiling encouragingly with her eyes only; her gaze finds Adora's lips before she lets her eyes shut, lips parting the tiniest bit in the middle.

Adora can barely hear from her own heart drumming in her ears. The pulsing in her throat is suffocating as she draws Catra in, their lips grazing lightly.

As soon as they touch, the lump in Adora's throat drops down into her chest, fluttering warmly behind her ribs. Adora breathes in the scent of Catra's skin that she could not forget since the first time they slept in the same bed together; her fingers glide into Catra's wild waves, pulling her in by her nape.

Catra whimpers; her lips are a bit rough but so warm and sweet, tasting like champagne, and Adora is kissing them like she forgot how to do anything else.

Technically, Adora has kissed Catra before. Countless times, even. Every day for their two-months relationship, but none of them compares to this - this breathless, fragile, bewitching moment where she can finally release her swallowed back desire. All the yearning, all the longing, all the wishful thinking and planning and failing and the forgotten tries of reaching out for so many years, none of them matter. None of them mean a single thing when Adora is holding Catra - *that* Catra, ex-girlfriend Catra, could-be-hers-again Catra - and getting drunk on her lips.

Adora draws back for air, panting and shaking like she is a teenager again. She keeps her eyes shut and her lips close; their upper lips still stick together as Adora's thumbs stroke Catra's cheeks.

Her throat dries up.

"That wasnt it," Adora whispers, eyebrows furrowing. "I can do better. Can Itry again?"

She can feel Catra's smirk as her mouth forms words.

"T ake your time."

And so Adora does. She switches sides and captures Catra's lips again, going in more heated this time. Catra makes the cutest little noise with her nose which makes Adora lose her mind; she licks Catra's lips, showing what she is craving and her heart is soaring at how Catra opens up right away, meeting Adora's tongue with her own like she could not hold back anymore either.

Their kisses turn messy and hot quickly , their bodies pressed closer until every inch of them is melting into one and they still keep pulling and drawing and clawing. They are both so driven and so far gone that there is no rhythm, no sync in their moves, their mouths crashing and burning and always a heartbeat ahead of each other. Adora does not mind; it is the greatest thing, really, having Catra so needy and so raptured by her that she cannot even think about anything else just to take and take.

Adora catches Catra's lower lip between her teeth, twisting as she tilts her head to the other side again. Catra moans into her mouth, returning the gesture with gripping Adora's hair and lolling her head back to sink her teeth into her pulse point. Adora cries out raspily, her hands dropping from Catra's face to her chest. Catra bites her once more, licking her way up to Adora's jawline where Adora dips her head to kiss Catra again, hands roaming across her body feverishly.

She cranes forward, grabbing Catra's thighs and scooping her up. Her injured knee buckles under her a bit, just a tiny strain, nothing that Adora wants to care about; not when Catra wraps her legs around her waist and her nails are digging into her shoulders, and Adora swallows that sweet, ridiculously hot " *fuck* " she growls under her breath.

Adora chuckles into Catra's mouth, tightening her grip on her thighs.

"I really like the fishnets," she says, breathless, and takes a couple steps towards Darla.

Catra squirms in Adora's arms, grinding her hips closer. She kisses her hungrily and growls again, deeper this time; Adora can feel it purring in her own chest.

"I can't believe I can fucking feel your abs like this."

Adora plops her down onto the sea of blankets without warning. Catra yelps, her legs dangling down. Without hesitation, Adora steps between her knees and leans ahead, propping herself on her elbows.

Catra's mouth is open, her arms writhing around Adora's neck again. She raises a brow and a knee, feeling Adora between her legs.

Adora jerks away, eyes wide and Catra drops her leg.

"Fuck, sorry," Catra sighs, fingers raking through her hair. Her face scrunches up. "Sorry."

"No-"

"I'm sorry. I thought-"

"No, no," Adora hurries to say, grabbing Catra's wrists and pulling her arms back around her. "I want to. I'm just." Adora licks her lips, laughing soundlessly. She hangs her head down.

Catra sits up, pulling herself up by holding onto Adora's nape. She cups Adora's jaw and tilts her head, guiding her gaze to meet hers.

Catra looks beautiful, and kind.

"We don't have to, Adora," she says. "It's really okay." Seeing Adora's expression has not changed, she jokes: "I won't bring your date grade down, I promise. Sex is for extra credit."

Adora finally laughs, although it sounds unusual. She raises her head just to kiss Catra again, slow and deep.

"I want to," she says again between little kisses. "I really do. But I… you should know that I might not. Be that great."

Catra scoffs, stroking Adora's jaw with the tip of her finger.

"Yeah right, like this is the *only* thing you're not good at? Cut the crap."

"I don't know," Adora says, a little distraught as she snatches Catra's hand. She finally blurts out: "I've never done this before."

Catra's features shatter. She is staring at Adora like she wanted to expose her lying, looking for signs behind the mask.

Adora is crewing on her lip.

"If it's a dealbreaker, I get it."

"What? No. Not at all." Catra shakes her head a bit. "I'm just… a little surprised. I didn't expect that, like. I assume it's not because you had no volunteers, girls must be waiting in line for you or some shit."

Adora's eyes drill into Catra's; her voice is barely a whisper.

"Yeah, well… none of them were the girl I've been waiting for."

Catra's chest is heaving.

"What?"

"I think you know exactly what I mean," Adora mumbles, eyes half-mast as she leans in again.

She kisses Catra with all her might, cradling her to lay back down on the blankets. She swallows Catra's gasps as her hand slides down on her front, reaching her abdomen.

Adora presses her forehead to Catra's, the tips of their noses grazing.

"Do you want me?"

"Yes," Catra hisses, back arching up to Adora's touch. She squints up at her, smoothing a stray lock of hair behind Adora's ear. She leaves her palm cupping her cheek. "Hey . Are you sure?"

Adora chuckles excitedly.

"*Yes*."

So Catra's knee comes back up as Adora's fingers unbutton her ripped shorts...

saturday

Adora awakens slowly, basking in utter bliss as sunlight warms her skin. She is nestling under several blankets, arm thrown over Catra's naked body;a body she knows better than her own, after last night.

Adora blinks sleep from her eyes, moaning as she holds Catra closer. Her free hand reaches for her phone, pressing on the side.

Blood rushes out of her face.

"Shit," she whines loudly and sits up. Catra drops down behind her, waking up with a raspy grow. "Sorry , shit- Catra!"

Adora turns and shakes Catra's shoulder violently. She keeps her voice down to compensate, whisper-screaming.

"Catra, wake up. Catra."

Catra squints up. Her makeup is completely ruined, her mane a mess, her lips curl into a killer grimace. She has no right to look so beautiful and so hot while bloodthirsty.

"I'm sorry," Adora says. "We need to leave. Now. We're so late. The- the game!"

Catra growls again, but complells. She crawls off the bed floor in slow motion, not caring about catching her clothes Adora is throwing at her.

Adora takes the bags and starts shoving the pillows and blankets into them before she realizes she can just throw shit on the backseats. When she's done with all, empty bottle and half-dry rose too, she pulls on her clothes quickly .

The corner of *that* paper is sticking out from her shorts, inviting. It fills Adora with warmth that she quickly presses down.

Not yet.

Catra only put on her shorts and top, underwear and stockings laying in her lap. She pulls her legs up onto the seat and turns towards the window, curling up.

Adora is pretty sure she fell back asleep. She takes her phone from her pocket, checking the time again as Darla climbs down to the narrow road leading to Camp. Adora almost pulls out the paper too, peeking at Catra.

Adora smiles.

Not yet.

They arrive ten minutes before the game should start, Adora stopping the engine and jumping out of the truck. Catra follows, staggering to her feet.

Adora meets her empty gaze through the windows, saying:

"I'll take a shower at Glimmer's. Meet you at the field!"

She turns on her heels and runs.

After a quick shower, Adora changes into her coach shirt, pulling the cap into her face. Glimmer has already left while Bow stays behind to wait for Adora and lock the bungalow after they leave.

He asks nothing, although there is no reason to. Adora is aware of the state of her that knocked feverishly on the door, desperately needing to shower and clean up after not coming back to Camp all night.

Adora keeps her grass strained knee socks on and slips into her shoes again, straightening without lacing them up.

"I'm done," she says, victorious and just on time.

Bow takes the paper from the ground, holding it up for Adora to take.

"You dropped this."

Adora takes it, pressing it to her lips like a cherished relic.

"Thanks."

Her thumb caresses the bumpy edge, then she shoves it back into her pocket.

Not yet.

Catra is losing.

Everything would make more sense if she was not that serious about it, vibrating with barely suppressed anger pulsing from every inch of her body as she circles the sidelines like a hawk.

Team Grayskull scores a second goal, which makes Catra snap her cap off, messing up her casual ponytail.

"That was of fside!" She howls, gesturing wildly . "Are you blind!?"

Mermista growls, hunching ahead.

"Uhh, did you see Spinerella wave her little flag? Yeah, I don't think so. It was a clean score, okay?"

"*Bullshit* ," Catra snaps again.

"Hey , calm down," Spinerella shushes Catra from the sideline. "You're coaching kids, remember?"

Mermista tilts her hips and crosses her arms. "And it wasn't offside, I saw it too."

Adora watches Catra slam her cap to the ground. Something is not right, but she cannot wrap her finger around it.

The game ends with Team Garnets suffering a devastating defeat for the first time in two weeks, Adora's newly arranged team winning by 4-0.

Catra storms off before Adora could reach her, surrounded and knocked off her feet by screaming children.

After the celebrational lunch, Adora feels sick to her stomach.

She has eaten more than she should have, given what she is planning to do next; a stomach full of pizza and ice cream is not a good combo with the jittery nerves, but she skipped breakfast to cuddling with Catra. And she would do it again.

Adora leaves the dining bungalow, bouncing on her feet. With every step she takes, she gets closer and closer to the big finish of her date plans. The last page of the presentation, the perfect closure for a perfect night.

Adora could not mind less that she had no chance to finish the date the way she had planned. What happened in the end was much, much better than what she could have ever dreamt of. Adora can still feel the ghost of Catra's fingers and mouth on her; the thought peppers her arms with goosebumps, the flames in her insides never fading.

She never imagined that Catra could be even more beautiful than how she has already seen her, but last night disproved her. Nothing can compare to Catra moaning under her, clinging to her with teeth and nails, gasping her name like prayers and curses. She never imagined that Catra's touch could feel better than what she is used to already, either. It was nothing like what Adora can do on her own.

Adora's cheeks are burning, and so are her eyes, shining. She is close to their bungalow and needs to collect herself. She tightens her ponytail and presses the back of her hands to her cheeks, trying to cool them down. She knows how she must look; not that different than how she did right after round three.

Adora clears her throat and shoves her hand into her pocket. Her fingers close up on the paper, rustling and she opens the door with her free hand.

She nearly bumps into Catra, trying to leave as she arrives.

"Hey ," Adora says with a grin, raising a shoulder. "Are you going to check on Melog?"

"No,"Catra grunts and tries to shove Adora away . "I'm leaving."

Adora flexes her muscles, staying put. She notices Catra's trekker backpack on her shoulders, empty shelves, and open drawers behind her.

"W ait, wait, what-- why?"Adora stammers, voice growing high.

"I'm not fucking stupid, Adora," Catra snaps, trying to get through Adora more forcefully. "Get out of my way ."

"What are you talking about?" Adora asks, panic creeping in. She grabs Catra's wrists and pushes her further inside the room, stumbling after her. "What's wrong?"

"Like you don't know!" Catra growls into her face. Her expression is distorted, distant. "Like you didn't just toy with me to win."

The suspicion is so ridiculous that Adora wants to laugh, and she would, if she was not so confused and terrified. Her lips curl into a grin on their own anyway, fueling Catra's anger .

She eases her grip on Catra's wrists.

"That's not true, Catra. Who would even do such a thing?"

Catra shoves her hands away, baring her teeth in a wild grin. She drops the backpack on the ground with a loud *thump* .

"Me!" Catra takes a couple steps back, giggling dangerously. It tolls inside Adora's chest, cold and empty. "Oh, Adora. Why do you think I accepted the offer for this job?"

Adora's throat is too tight to speak. She does not even try, and Catra goes on, her every hiss and wild gesture is a slap in Adora's face.

"I knew you were gonna be here. I knew you were gonna be easy to *manipulate* - Catra tilts her hips charmingly -, and I could finally give back the pain you caused. Iknew you were going to try and fix things between us, because that's who you are, aren't you? Good, kind, smart Adora." Catra's voice cracks. "Who breaks your heart like nobody's business."

Hearing that, a heat of anger pulses through Adora's veins. Now she has no problem with speaking, although her voice grows shrill.

"I broke your heart? What are you talking about?"

"You left me, Adora!"

Adora leaps to Catra, grabbing her shoulders. She shakes her a little too rough, but she cannot control herself well enough.

"*You* ghosted *me!* " Adora's chest is heaving. Her nails are digging into Catra's skin, arms trembling. Catra glares at her with empty, empty eyes. "You just stopped talking to me out of nowhere, and I-"

"What does it matter? You were gonna break up with me anyway! I didn't need to wait around for it to happen."

"I never wanted to break up with you!" Adora yells desperately, yanking Catra closer again. Something breaks in Catra's harsh eyes, and a tiny dot of shine is back.

"Then you're even more stupid than I thought," Catra croaks, slapping Adora's hands away once again. "Did you really think our

relationship could have survived with you moving so far away? That you had it in you to stay with me?"

Adora inhales deeply, pinching the bridge of her nose. She feels tired, all of a sudden, her voice weak.

"I thought so. Maybe. We didn't even try."

"You didn't try shit, Adora," Catra sneers. "I stopped texting you back and you gave no fucks about reaching out. That was it, that was your big love. I didn't even have to block you. You didn't fucking care about me. You never did."

The last flickering flames of Adora's anger are twirling in her throat. She holds them close, warming up to them, letting them coax her mouth and heart. Her voice is dripping and trembling with quiet rage, every inch of her body shaking, her skin itching tight.

Her eyes drill into Catra's.

"No," she says simply. Catra takes a step back, eyes widening. Whatever she sees on Adora's face or hears in her voice, it seems to terrify her. "I never wanted to leave you. I never wanted to hurt you. I never lied to you. You broke my heart too, but I wanted to respect your decision and your boundaries. I did try to call you and ask you what's wrong and you never answered. I've been waiting for you to come around, hoping that I'd get a chance to earn your love back. And you?" Adora raises her jaw, closing the gap between them again. Catra flinches, but stays put. "You won. You fulfilled your desire for your revenge. You can lie to yourself all you want, if it makes you feel better. You can tell yourself that I broke your heart. You can tell yourself that I left you, that I enjoyed hurting you. You can tell yourself that I've only been nice to you again to stab you in the back. But Catra?" Adora's vision is blurring. She blinks back the tears and keeps her chin raised. "Every choice you've made, you've made yourself. I guess we both have to live with that."

Catra keeps quiet.

Adora takes another deep breath, reaching inside her pocket. She pulls the paper out, her thumb stroking it one last time before she gives it to Catra.

"This is yours. Do what you want with it."

Catra takes the paper cautiously, peering down at it with a frown. She raises it between their faces then, growling:

"Did you steal this from my apartment? I seriously cant believe y-" Catra clips her words as she notices the back, a note freshly written.

Catra folds it out slowly, fingers trembling. Her eyes scan through the new message qickly , and she gasps qietly . She looks at Adora again, her features shift into the gentle, kind Catra Adora knows.

At least she thought she knew.

"Adora"…

Adora shakes her head, crossing her arms. She backs to the wall, crumbling into it as she feels strength flowing out of her body. She hopes Catra does not see how difficult it is to keep straight, to stand, to stay awake. To carry a body that is hollow and too heavy at the same time.

"Please, dont." Adora hangs her head, looking up. "I cant do this right now, Catra."

Catra breaks. Her eyes fill with heavy tears, qickly gushing out and rolling down her flushed cheeks.

"W ow," she breathes, voice low and scornful. "Y ou never mean a single thing you say, do you?"

Adora closes her eyes to lock out the image of Catra crying before she loses control and wraps her into her arms. She wants nothing more than to kiss up those tears and melt into the warmth radiating from Catra's body, but she cant. She shouldnt.

She probably never will.

Catra's boots are stomping on the wooden floor as she gets her stuff and leaves just like she planned. She pushes on Adora's shoulder on the way out, spitting:

"Have a nice life."

The door slams. Adora can hear Catra's voice once again, screaming:

"Get out of my way! Why the fuck are you guys everywhere?"

Adora digs her nails into her arms until her skin turns flushed pink and her knuckles whiten. The door opens again, carefully this time, followed by a pair of quiet steps.

"Adora?"

"Are you in here?"

Adora presses to the wall tighter, shoulders raised.

"Yeah," she calls but does not turn her head towards her friends. Seeing them would make her lose control immediately. She squeezes her eyes shut. "Can you… Sorry, could I be alone for a moment? Hm. I just. Everything is fine, I'll... I'll meet you guys later, okay?"

There is a beat of silence. Then, Glimmer says softly:

"Okay."

"You know where to find us. We're here for you," Bow adds.

"Whatever you need."

Adora swallows thickly.

I'm fine. Really ."

The hinges creak again, and the door closes. Adora stays alone in a half-empty bungalow, with a broken bed and a broken heart and Catra's cruelly lingering scent.

Adora slides down the wall, pulling her knees up and hugging them. She feels warmth building inside her, the boiling lava of pain and grief, flushing her skin. She feels skinned. Raw.

Her vision is blurry again; the room shifts into colorful shapes without edge, furniture dripping into each other. Adora blinks, the first tears fall.

Catra left the paper lying on the ground, Adora's words in the dust where they belong.

Adora's lungs rattle and she chokes on a sob.

Catra -

Will you be mine again?

Chapter End Notes

.....Ayyyy look, they finally kissed!(☞ﾟヮﾟ)☞ That's good, right?
Right?
So nice. So nice.

(Psst if you'd like to read an additional - and very emotional - smut about the end of the date, raise your hands in the comments and you can also subscribe to me so you won't miss it. ;))

Hello beautiful people, and welcome to the worst part. :D I've been sadistically excited for this to finally happen, partly because I wanted to be over it and mostly because I am cruel Like That. :)

I called this chapter Catra Stop Being Self-Destructive For Five Fucking Seconds in my mind, and it still turned out worse than I thought it would. 😬
Anyway-- here it is, Catra's plan and the breakup story , at least fractures of it. Of course they both remember it differently, and it's been so long ago, so the truth is somewhere in the middle. You'll understand it better in the last chapter . Adora being Oblivious was to be expected, and Catra is honorary Princess of Projection. ☝
But really what's a Catra arc without some good abandonment issues and revenge plot? Adora's POV kept hints and foreshadowing to the bare minimum which is probably more fun to me than it should have been. 😊

Also, here's the slow dance song, the new slap of cringe nostalgia (jk...unless), and the reason for Catra's second breakdown of... god knows how many, actually.

Thank you so, SO much for your support on this fic! ♡ Thank you all for the lovely comments, for subscribing (we're over 200 now, baby!), for enjoying it - please do consider leaving me a comment because they make my fucking day, and don't be shy to hang out with me on Tumblr. I go by @e-ra there, and I have a whole fic tag (#ela writes) and inside that a She's A Keeper tag (#coachcatradora) for sneak peaks and illustrations and any additional shit you might enjoy while I'm still working on the next chapter. I also made a Twitter since last chapter (Loul I blame you I'm so lost help me) so go... Check that out too? Someone tell me how that shit works.

If you enjoyed reading, please consider supporting the fic by sharing my post about it!

Ilove you all, see you soon and hang out with me on T umblr or Twitter it's a fun time and Ilove talking to you. ♡

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

august 7

Adora fidgets on the uncomfortable plastic chair. It's creaking under her every move; it makes Adora's hairs stick up on her arms and her skin itch. Her nose is filled with the stingy smell of antiseptics, the air cold and crispy with it.

"Miss Hope?"

Adora rises awkwardly, peeling her skin off the plastic. She follows the owner of the voice into a small room, her heels knocking unevenly. She is asked to sit again, this time, on something wooden at least. She adjusts the strap of her backpack on her shoulder, then decides to take it off and bring the bag into her lap.

A monitor is pushed towards her direction, an image flashing up black and white. It looks like a picture of sand, reversed.

"Good news is, your ultrasound shows that your injury hasn't fully ripped the muscle off the bone, unlike the last time you were here."

Adora stares at the image emptily.

"And the bad news?"

"The strains you have been experiencing, just like this mild tear right now, is caused by your hamstrings not extending your knee as expected. You'll need another surgery."

Adora doesnt ask what went wrong. She couldnt care less, just wants to laugh. Is that bad news to this woman?

"Okay ."

Adora calls Glimmer from the car. She accepts after one ring. Bow is there too, their cheeks pressed together to fit in the frame from up close, both of them wearing frantic expressions.

"Adora, finally!" She screams, making Adora wince. "Where the hell were you!?"

"W e were so worried about you," Bow adds.

"Bow cried."

"I did not cry ."

"Y ou sounded like you cried."

Bow tilts his head at that, agreeing. They both turn their attention towards Adora now, eyes widening.

"Oh, Adora"...

"I m sorry," Adora weeps, lower lip quivering. She tries to blink back the tears pooling at the corners of her eyes. "I m so sorry ."

Adoras shoulders start to shake. She looks away from the screen, barely missing the shared look between Glimmer and Bow.

After a couple of seconds, Bow asks quietly:

"Adora, whats going on?"

"I ," Adora starts, gasping for air. She takes a deep breath, lungs rattling. "I ve been lying to you, I m so sorry ."

"Lying about what?" Glimmer asks. "Adora, what the hell happened on Saturday?"

Adora shakes her head. She's not ready for that conversation. Not now, maybe not ever.

She blurts out, voice weak:

"I've been lying to you about my career. I'm not playing soccer anymore."

"What do you mean?"

"You didn't get a call-up?"

"I did get a call-up," Adora says. "But I... I tore my hamstrings. I needed surgery and that made me miss the wedding and now I need another one because something went wrong and I decided to step back from the contract and it's fine, really it's fine because I didn't even want to really play in the Nationals I just went with it because it seemed like a great idea but I didn't realize I was actually hating it until Catra-" Adora chokes on the name, her palm flying to her mouth. She feels burning tears dripping down on her cheeks, pooling on her fingers. She dries them, rubbing her face roughly. She is thankful for the silence at the other side of the line, giving her courage to continue: "I'm sorry for lying to you. I really am. I was just so scared to tell you."

"But why?" Glimmer asks, confused. "Adora, you can tell us anything, you know that."

Adora takes a deep breath, falling back to the seat.

"You were so proud of me," she says. "Everyone was so excited and I didn't want to fail you. Or didn't want you to know that I failed... I didn't want to disappoint you, I didn't want you to know that I'm not"...

Adora's voice fades away. She is not sure what she was going to say anyway. Perfect? She knows she's not. Who they thought she was? Who even is Adora? An imposter, a liar. Someone who doesn't know when to stop, just how to fake and fall into every trap life rolls in her way, who only hurts the people she loves even when she is trying to do the right thing.

She hears Bow's voice from far, far away.

"Adora, listen to me. We are proud of you for who you are, for what you're doing, for what you believe in. Not because you got into Nationals, but because you're a great goalkeeper. Not just because of your job, but because you're kind, and brave, and because everything you do you do it with all your heart. Because you care, and because you're a good person."

"And we love you," Glimmer says. "We love you for who you are, you don't have to hide anything. Especially a surgery, like come on, we want to be with you when you go!"

"Exactly. You don't have to do anything alone. We're right there with you. If you let us."

Adora's throat bobs as she swallows thickly. She dares to look at the screen again, finding shiny eyes and encouraging smiles.

"Thank you, guys," she whispers. "I... I think I Really need you, now. If that's okay."

"It's more than okay," Glimmer says. "Do you want us to come over?"

It would be a three hour drive, then the same amount back. And Adora can drive home, it's fine. So, she says so:

"No, no. It's fine. I'm fine."

"When is your surgery?" Bow asks.

"Next Monday. I have to spend the night on Sunday, too."

"W ell be there," Glimmer says. "I can drive you to the hospital."

"And I ll make you the dopest chicken soup you've ever had. George's recipe."

Adora chuckles. She truly never had a better meal than when she visited Bow's family. She sniffs, rubbing her face again with the back of her hand.

"Okay?" Glimmer asks softly .

"Okay ," Adora says. "Thank you."

"Call us anytime you need. f you want to talk, if you need a distraction. f you need anything, really . We're here."

"Just don't ghost us again, you hear me?" Glimmer changes to a playfully threatening tone. "Y ou have no idea how scary it is to have a friend disappear on you like that, especially after the break-in."

Adora scoffs. f only Glimmer knew .

But also, she is right. She can't do to her friends what someone else has done to her, knowing how heartbreaking it is.

Adora has already done it to Glimmer and Bow twice. Before Camp, and now after.shit, she really is no better , is she?

"I won't do that again," Adora croaks. "I promise." Glimmer's last words just start to reach Adora's brain. "W ait, what.what break-in?"

"Y ou haven't heard?" Bow asks, and Adora shakes her head. "Someone broke into Etheria Saturday night. Thankfully, everyone had already left by then."

"That's horrible. Glimmer , I'm so sorry ."

Glimmer shrugs.

"They didn't take anything. We only noticed because the bungalow door was left open, the keyhole scratched up. I already talked to Entrapta about installing a better security system all over Camp for next year."

"I'm really glad no one was hurt."

"That's why you freaked us out so much!"

Adora scoffs, raising a fist and flexing her bicep.

"I could've taken them down."

"Yeah, right," Glimmer says with a smirk. "Anyway, expect the cops to contact you if they haven't tried already."

Adora puts her hand down.

"Me? Why me?"

"Because it was your bungalow."

august 2

Adora zips her bag, packed with necessities for staying a couple days at the hospital. She straightens then, feeling the strain in her leg immediately. It didn't get worse over time, but the constant pain starts to get on her nerves.

She has no one to blame but herself. After Saturday, after everything, she packed her bags and decided to leave. She didn't feel strong enough to face her friends and the kids had already left with the Camp bus, so she had no reason to stay.

She also felt like she had no reason to hold back anymore. The overwhelming ache in her heart was impossible to ease, to swallow down, just like the boiling anger. She was angry. She still is angry, and so frustrated and confused, and she choked on them like lumps in her throat, feeling like she could throw them up any minute, so she did the only thing she knew could work.

She drove back home and hit the gym. She went hard until every inch of muscle in her body felt sore, her legs trembling under her as she stood.

On Sunday, she went again. She didn't drive there but jogged, then worked out for two hours before deciding to run back home.

She barely made it. She tried to ice her bruised knee, took pills, put on the elastic bandage she used before. It was no use, the swelling barely fading away and the pain keeping her awake at night.

The doorbell rings a calm, melodic tune. Adora limps to the doorbell on the wall, pushing the button. Static starts crackling as she tries to joke:

"I'm not buying anything."

"Do you have time to talk about our Lord and savior, homemade chicken soup?"

"Maybe."Adora presses another button on the device. "It's open."

Adora turns the key in the lock, opening the heavy door. Glimmer and Bow turn onto the corridor, both of them picking up their pace when they see Adora waving.

Adora is wrapped in a bone-cracking group hug, Bow and Glimmer careful to not put pressure on her legs. She already feels like tearing up so she cuts it short, drawing back but her hands never leave her friend's backs.

I'm really glad to see you," she says. "Thank you."

"*Always*," Glimmer says. "Do you need help packing?"

"No, I have everything."

Bow strokes Adora's shoulder and steps into her apartment.

"I'll put the soup in your fridge and we're ready to go."

"Okay."

Glimmer squeezes Adora's hand as she watches Bow stirring in the apartment, packing some things away, and quickly rubbing Adora's sticky countertop with a wet cloth. Bow gets Adora's backpack on his way back, throwing it on his shoulder.

"I can carry it," Adora says, reaching out.

"No need."

Adora lets herself be helped down the stairs, feeling like collapsing with every step she takes, clinging to Glimmer's hand like her life depends on it.

She practically falls into the backseat of the Beetle, blacking out of the conversation they have on their way to the hospital.

august 2

Adora wakes up. Cold bright light hurts her eyes, making her squeeze them shut right after opening them.

She feels drunk, and high, and exhausted, in that order. She wonders if she even has legs anymore, since everything is numb

under her waist, so she starts fighting with the blanket, pulling it off enough to see.

Two legs. That is what she is supposed to have, right? She is not sure anymore. Did she have more before?

Adora whines, turning her head towards the door of the ward. She catches a glimpse of something gray slipping out of the door.

Her heart skips a beat.

"Catra?"

She blinks and misses the phantom of the figure through the window. She is so confused and lost. But the hair she saw was neither long nor untamed, not framing the face with wild waves.

Why would it even be her?

Adora closes her eyes, falling back into a feverish slumber.

She dreams of her. Of course she does. Her mind just has to hurt her even more, showing vivid images and sounds that she wants to forget.

She dreams of Friday night and days before, and old times. Every version of her, all the fragments she still loves.

She dreams of sweet promises and gentle hands, soft mouths and whispered confessions.

She dreams of her, and even when she is kissed slowly and embraced tight in her fantasies, she feels like crying.

Adora awakens again. This time, warm orange light pours onto her white bedspread, making it easier for her eyes to adjust.

She feels someone squeeze her hand. *Catra*, her mind plays with her again, only to realize that the hand that holds hers is wider, and softer than Catra's.

"Adora," Glimmer says quietly, leaning in. "How are you feeling?"

Adora blinks. Her eyes are burning, her throat dry.

"Fine," she croaks, licking her chapped lips. "How long?"

"A couple hours. It's past six." Bow pipes in, his voice coming from the other side. Adora forces her head to turn and draws her hand out of Glimmer's grip to push herself up.

Glimmer and Bow help her immediately, bringing her pillow with her so her back feels more comfortable. Adora drags her legs like lifeless logs, grunting:

"I'm fine, I can-"

"Adora," Glimmer scolds and pushes a cup of water into her hand. It feels different coming from her than from Catra. Frustrating. Belittling.

Adora is so tired of everything.

"Everything went well," Bow says. "I talked to the doctor. You shouldn't get strains and pain from mild exertions anymore, but-"

Adora knows.

"Yeah." She sips and combs her hair back from her face with her free hand. "I told you, it's fine. I don't mind stepping back from playing soccer."

Glimmer asks cheerfully:

"What are you gonna do?"

"I..."

Talking about anything and everything just leads to one person. Catra is hiding in the shadows of her every plan and every thought, and Saturday starts to make less and less sense.

Adora starts to doubt Catra. Starts to doubt their fight, at least - Catra can be cruel, and she could play a part, but why go the extra mile to fix Adora's life? She didn't need to do that in order to earn Adora's trust, or heart, she already had it all and Adora knows she's an open book to her. Catra must have known she had her wrapped around her finger way before Catra took care of her, and listened to her, and lead her to realize her worth and what she wants-

And the moments they were alone? The moments where Catra got nothing out of it just spoiled Adora rotten with her kindness, the moments where Catra didn't even know if Adora is awake, or aware of things, and people saw… people knew what was going on, too. Catra didn't have to fool Bow, or Glimmer, or Mermista, Scorpia, or their teams. She didn't have to take Adora home wasted and make sure she wouldn't be hungover, or cook her lunch, or ride her bike in the pouring rain just to get her breakfast. She didn't plan to wake up to them cuddling and kiss her mindlessly. She didn't have to check in on her, to kiss her back with so much to give, to touch her so full of affection, to sleep with her just to break Adora's heart.

Anything could have been enough at that point. And Catra knew that. Does she really hate her so much?

Adora's head hurts. She realizes she's been staring blankly at the wall, and blinks. The cup has disappeared from her hand.

"I'm sorry," she mutters. "I think I'm still very dazed and tired."

"We should let you rest," Bow says, and pats Adora's shoulder. "We'll be back tomorrow morning to take you home."

"Okay . Thank you."

"Just text me if you need us to bring you something to eat that's not hospital food," Glimmer adds and hooks the strap of her bag on her shoulder as she stands. "Although you seem to be pretty spoiled already."

Adora follows Glimmer eyes to the nightstand next to the bed. It's sinking under the weight of bars of chocolate and flowers and other sweet "get well soon" presents.

Adora feels like she is going to tear up. After she came clean to Bow and Glimmer, she finally had the courage to tell all her friends and once again, apologize profusely to Scorpia and Perfuma. Still, the display of kindness and care overwhelms her.

"Sleep well, okay?" Glimmer says and kisses Adora's cheek. She holds Bow's hand then, and they wave and leave.

"Bye."

Adora feels relieved as soon as the door closes behind them. She reaches for a box of her favorite bonbons, her gaze locking up on a strange box sitting next to it.

It is deep red and velvety , looking like a jewelry box.

Adora furrows her brows and grabs it first. It's heavier than she expected it to be. Her fingers shake a bit as she opens the lid.

She exhales, short and breathless.

There is a beautiful, golden coach whistle laying inside, Adora's name engraved in it. She takes it out, and from behind the black cushion, a red silk thread slips out that Adora can hang around her neck.

Adora keeps it in her palm, feeling its weight. She twirls the box around in her other hand; there is no note attached, no personal

clues.

Adora figures it must be from Mermista; she usually leaves no trace to her gifts, loves gold more than anyone Adora knows, and they don't know each other that well apart from their summer jobs.

Adora holds the whistle to her heart. As soon as she gets out of here, she'll start applying to coaching jobs.

She can't fool around anymore, can't let anything hold her back anymore. She has to start over.

Now.

september 1

The microwave is beeping urgently, just when Adora's phone rings.

Adora opens the microwave and accepts the call with her other hand, putting it on speaker.

"Hello-" She hisses, taking the hot bowl out. "Hello?" She asks again, blowing on her fingers with quick little huffs.

"Adora Hope?" A woman's voice calls, low and bored from the line.

"Uh, yeah. That's me."

"I'm calling from Fright Zone SC. I might have an offer for you."

Adora nearly slips on nothing on her kitchen floor, heat rushing out of her face. The Fright Zone is one of the most prestigious soccer clubs on the south coast, working with players from every age range, with a nearly perfect rate to send their players into upswept careers.

"I oh. Wow. That's- that's amazing, truly, a wonderful possibility, but I- I am not playing soccer anymore due to an inju-."

"I *know*," the woman cuts in, drawling and clearly irritated. "We have a coaching position for you. If you're interested."

"Oh. OH." Adora completely abandons her lunch to grab her phone and press it to her ear to hear the caller more clearly. "Yes, that. That would be amazing! I'm *very* interested."

"Come to the main office on Friday, ten AM sharp. Look for Octavia."

"Yes, great! Thank you. Thank you so much-"

The woman ends the call, pretty rude, but Adora is bouncing on her feet with the phone still pressed to her cheek. Warmth crawls back under her skin until she is flushed from excitement.

She can't believe someone finally called back. She'd applied to so many positions at so many clubs she completely forgot she had Fright Zone in the bag. But she must have sent something in if they called her. She was probably still pretty dopey after the surgery.

She takes the bowl of pasta and flops down onto the couch. The TV on, but Adora quickly loses interest in whatever series she left it on, barely watching it to begin with.

She blows on the first bite and munches contentedly.

The Fright Zone.

She *cannot* mess this up.

september 4

"I can see that you've had quite the career as a goalkeeper. Your achievements truly speak for themselves, although your coaching experience is short and limited."

Adora licks her lips, tasting peach. She basically ate the whole layer of chapstick she applied in Darla before paddling into the office, feeling unsteady wearing short heels. She's tapping her foot on the plush carpet now, fighting the urge to tear the skin off her lip. Her navy pantsuit is pretty uncomfortable as well - so tight on her thighs and ass like it could rip at any moment. It has been years since she wore it, and apparently, she grew quite a lot in the muscle department down there.

The woman she came to see, Octavia, is sitting on the other side of the heavy desk, with Adora's CV in hand, resting her chin on the back of her hand. She looks bored, mostly, and Adora is unsure if she can convince her to give her a chance.

"I know I don't have much experience," Adora agrees, keeping her voice polite but firm. "But I can assure you I am a hard worker. And a quick learner. Coaching those kids at Camp Etheria for three years in a row made me learn and grow a lot, and it was the first job I had that I fell in love with. I know that my experience there can't compare to a full-time job at one of the best soccer clubs in the area, but I can do it."

Octavia hums. She keeps scanning Adora's CV for a while before she looks up, deep eyes drilling into Adora's.

"What makes you think you can keep up? We treat our players very seriously. Even if I assign you to the youngest group, we expect you to do as well as the coaches we have for our U21 team."

Adora straightens.

"I have what it takes. I want to do this more than anything, and I can promise you right now that you won't be disappointed in me. I've played soccer since I was seven years old, and even though I was

on the other side of the story, I know what a good coach is like. I know everything about the drills, I know what motivates players. f you give me a chance, youll see."

Octavia leans back on the chair, eyes never leaving Adoras. They see eye to eye for long seconds before - much to Adoras surprise - Octavia bares her teeth in a grin.

"Alright, Hope. I like that." She rises from her chair, so Adora does too. Octavia leans on the tabletop with one huge hand, reaching for Adoras with the other. Adora takes it, joining in the firm handshake with just a touch more strength than Octavia. "Y ou had the reference I needed before you came in anyway, but I wanted you to sell it. I wouldnt have given you a chance if you didnt live up to the expectations."

Reference? She didnt attach any. t has to be from Camp Etheria, she assumes. Adora makes a mental note to thank Glimmer immensely.

"Thank you so much," is all she says, trying to keep a straight face and failing.

"Y ou start next month. Im looking forward to working with you."

septembr0

Adora is in better shape than ever. Her hamstrings havent acted up since the surgery and the recovery process seemed to work better for her than before.

She got an email from Octavia, her contract attached. Her salary is much higher than she expected it to be, so she could immediately start looking for apartments. t truly feels like fate that all she sees

whenever she unlocks her phone and opens the browser, are ads for apartments around the Fright Zone that she can not only afford but loves everything about. She really talked too much about moving, it seems.

She found a new place in two weeks that is perfect for her every need.

Adora rips the tape off with her teeth and smooths it on the top of the paper box. She straightens then, looking around in her empty apartment.

That was the last box she had packed to the brim and sealed. She dries the beads of sweat off her forehead, exhaling with a huff.

She plops down onto a paper box then, stretching her legs and unlocking her phone. Her message app flashes up immediately, throwing her where she spent most her time, and where it always hurts to be.

Catra's contact.

Adora's thumb hovers over the keyboard.

She tried to reach out so many times. She found herself wanting to ask if Catra was okay. Wanting to tell her the good news, wanting to just check in like "hey, I'm moving to Salineas too," "guess what I got a coaching job." "We're going to be so close." "We should meet up."

Talk to me,please. Please.

Adora rolls her head back.

There is no use though, is there? Catra would just ghost her again, if she didn't block her number already.

Catra was mad at her. She was so mad, burning so hot, pushing her away with every bit of strength she had in her arms and in her voice.

And she hurt Adora. Adora should not forget that.

But maybe she hurt Catra, too. She looked hurt… and so small, despite trying her best to play cruel and cold. When she saw Adora's note, everything shattered on her face.

You never mean a single thing you say,do you?!

Adora said that she wanted to be with Catra again. She said that she wouldn't let her go.

Catra was right. Adora only cares about what she thinks is true, but what about the other side?

Everything in Adora's life is finally perfect. Why couldn't she try and get the only missing piece back?

Adora starts to type.

She deletes it.

She starts typing again, feeling more frustrated this time.

Why is she so scared of this? Not Catra, never of Catra, but afraid of all the new possibilities for Adora to mess things up.

And Adora can't say that she isn't mad at her anymore. She desperately wants to *not* be angry with Catra, but she can't convince herself that everything Catra yelled at her was a lie. No, Catra did want to break her heart again. She did want to get revenge for something Adora doesn't even understand, and it still hurts.

Adora sighs. The very next moment, her phone rings and she accidentally presses send.

"Oh no,"Adora breathes, low and desperate. "No, no, no, no-"

Adora flicks her thumb to the conversation, ignoring the caller.

Catra

Hi, Catra. Iknow this is strange, and you probably dont want to talk to me bu

Oh great. Oh, this is great, this is wonderful. This is just-- alright.

Adora accepts the call, nearly breaking the screen with her thumb.

"What!?"

"W ow, such a strong, healthy voice!" Scorpia says, her voice full of appreciation and joy. Adora growls, pinching the bridge of her nose. "Love to hear that. Feeling better after the surgery, buddy? How are things, hm?"

"Hi, Scorpia," Adora says, trying to take control of her voice. "Im okay. Uh, and you guys?"

"Oh, were great! Weve finished the new greenhouse, youve got to check it out, its beautiful. Perfuma really has an eye for these things." She keeps a necessary pause before she asks in a very obviously fake-casual tone: "That reminds me, just crossed my mind, totally unrelated, youre coming tonight, right?"

"Y eah, of course! ust finished packing the last round of stuff from the kitchen." Adora massages her nape. "Uh, Glimmer and Bow are coming to help, well drop the stuff off at the apartment and well go together, okay?"

"Perfect,"Socrpia says. "I tell Per . She was kinda freaking out since you havent reacted to anything in the group ch- I mean, nothing. No one freaked out. About anything. At all." Scorpia clicks her tongue. "See you tonight!"

"Scorpia," Adora calls before she could stop herself. Her heart is beating fast in her throat as she holds her phone to her ear with both hands.

"Yeah?"

Adora swallows thickly. Her voice is quiet.

"Will Catra be there?"

Scorpia keeps quiet for so long that Adora peeks at the screen, checking if they're still in line.

Scorpia says carefully:

"She… she won't. We invited her, but I doubt she'll come. She's kinda impossible to reach nowadays. So. You know."

"Yeah," is all Adora says.

"Adora, I'm so sorry."

Adora furrows her brows like Scorpia could see her.

"You're sorry? Why are you sorry?"

Scorpia speaks faster now, trying to get through it as soon as possible.

"I got her the job at Etheria. I knew about your history and I knew how Catra always felt about you and I really thought it was going to be good for both of you, but I just made an even bigger mess, and I'm sorry-"

Adora feels the anger bubbling up inside again - not about Scorpia, but for her.

"Don't be," she says firmly. "Catra has no one to blame but herself. And me neither."

Adora hangs up.

The barbeqe is fun, surprisingly. Adora is having a good time, although even the lingering smell of vegan sausage turns her stomach upside down.

Adora mingles and laughs and chats like her heart is not aching still. Catra cut a hole in her chest that seems to feed on Adora's pain, growing and growing, gaping and dripping something sour like acid.

She also doesnt appreciate everyone asking her how she is in that special, annoying tone. She dismisses worries and asks about the others' lives instead, smiling and nodding with a lemonade in hand, pretending to listen.

A couple hours pass and Adora feels nice, but exhausted. She excuses herself from listening to Spinerella and Netossa argue about the plot twist of a thriller they saw last week, and slips through another group of people, coming round Scorpia and Perfuma's greenhouse.

That part of the garden is not lit by fairy-lamps and torches. The glass dulls the voices of the others' as well, so Adora lets her guard down and sighs deeply.

That is until someone screams her name and Adora's fist crumbles the paper cup, soaking her hand and wrist in sticky lemonade.

Great.

"Entrapta," she says, shaking drops off her hand. "Long time no see!"

"It's so exciting to see you!" Entrapta shrills for some reason, raising her tiny fists in front of her chest. "Did it work? Tell me it worked!"

Adora blinks.

"What.what worked? Sorry , do you have a napkin? A tissue?"

"Oh, did you not mean to do that?"

"No, I did not mean to pour lemonade on myself, you just scared me."

"I'm sorry ," Entrapta says quietly .

Adora feels like shit. She knows she is still more hot-headed than usual, and she hates it, but it is so, so difficult to control.

She tries a little smile.

"No, don't- it's okay, really. I'm just... jumpy tonight." Adora finds a crumpled tissue in her pocket and dries the lemonade off her hand. She peeks back at Entrapta who still stares at her with stars in her eyes, unblinking. "Uh-"

"So! Did it work? Did you see the ads?"

Adora stops dabbing on her wrist. She straightens, suspicion melting into her voice.

"Entrapta, what are you talking about?"

"The ads for the apartments I sent you! Did you see them? I heard you were moving, which one did you choose? The one with the balcony, right? That's what-" Entrapta's eyes suddenly widen, her voice falters into something slow and weak. "Oooh. I was not supposed to tell you that."

Adora's head is buzzing.

"Did you *hack* my phone!?"

"Technically, no." Entrapta raises a finger. "I did, however, create personalized advertisements of the apartments I was sent and tinkered with your phone service to only show you those for a limited

amount of time, until you find what's most sufficient. Everything is back to normal now, though."

Adora grabs her hair poof with her still sticky fingers, pulling her hair.

" *You own a cyber security company!* "

Entrapta giggles proudly, raising her shoulders.

"That's why I knew how to do it! Although I really am not supposed to talk to you about this, so I think this conversation is over! It was nice meeting you though!"

Before Adora could vocalize her outrage again, Entrapta literally runs away, leaving her alone in the dark.

Adora's chest is heaving. She gets her phone out of her pocket and unlocks it with shaky fingers.

There is only one person she knows who would ask Entrapta to do such a thing.

She is still on the contact, her unfinished message mocking her. Just like the two little receipts, showing that Catra had seen it and decided to ignore her.

Adora leans her back to the glass wall, slowly letting her phone down.

She hears a high whistle, then a popping rumble. The sky lights up with red flickering dots of light, drizzling down.

Adora looks up. Her eyes tear up from staring straight into the fireworks, arms hanging by her sides.

The suspicion that was so quiet before, only whispering into her ear cannot be ignored now.

She looks at the screen of her phone again, lighting up.

She calls her.

Catra lets it ring for a long time, ignoring Adora still. When the call goes to voicemail, Adora takes a deep breath.

The fireworks keep popping, so Adora puts a finger in her ear and raises her voice above their noise.

"Hi. I know you saw my message. I mean, half-message. You don't have to react to anything I say, but I just talked to Entrapta. I don't know if I'm right, but if I am, and you're doing what I think you're doing… I don't know why you would. I'm… I'm so confused, Catra. I don't understand you. I don't understand so many things you've done, the good and the bad either. I don't care if this is some kind of apology or you just want to keep playing with me, either case I just want you to stop, okay? This isn't *fair* ." Adora's voice breaks a little bit. It was hopefully hidden by the next whistle of the fireworks. "If you don't want anything to do with me anymore, I understand, but let me forget you too. You had your revenge. I'm not going to reach out to you anymore, so you never have to hear from me again. And if it's not about that… then, stop ignoring me. Stop following me in the shadows and say whatever you want to my face." Adora's voice turns sour, and miserable. "You know where I live anyway , I guess."

She ends the voicemail, and decides to go back to her friends. She feels much lighter in her steps, but not in the weight in her chest.

Maybe she is wrong about her suspicions, but either then, Catra deserved to know what Adora thinks. And it feels good to tell her, whether she's right or not.

She grabs another plate of pork chops and potato salad, and finds Spinerella and Netossa to see if they have agreed about the plot twist.

Not a plot twist - they have not.

chapter 8

Adora's anger has finally faded away.

She loves her job. She earned Octavia's respect the first week, and her colleagues warmed up to her as well. She loves the kids team she was assigned to - they are a bit older than the kids at Camp Etheria, but Adora found a common ground with them after a couple hardships and fights for dominance. It really was just like herding cats.

She loves her apartment, too - tiny, cozy and bright, nothing but a small bedroom, a bathroom, and a pretty balcony with golden rails. Her kitchen and the living room space is smaller than her previous one, but she can't say she minds. Her stuff fits into the cupboards and drawers perfectly, and she fell in love with the fluffy white carpet and the wooden feature wall immediately.

Adora stands in front of it now, tape in her hand and a picture between her lips. She decided to have a wall of memories like Catra does, trying to focus on the good. She has polaroids of early years of camp, and family nights either at Glimmer or Bow's parents', parties at Perfuma and Scorpia's, concerts with Mermista and Seahawk, game nights at Spinnerella and Netossa's. Tickets of museums and soccer games, certificates and silly little drawings. She took the shoebox with her own printed out pictures from high school that she kept but hid deep, and chose one.

Adora puts it up in the middle, smoothing a tape over it. She takes a step back, watching it with her head tilted.

It is her first selfie with Catra after they got together. They both look so young and carefree, Catra wearing strong raccoon eye makeup and a squished grin as Adora smears a big kiss on her freckled cheek. Catra's hand is raised and slid on Adora's nape, keeping her

close. The photo is shaky and blurry from Adora shaking with laughter as she took the picture.

This is just because of what day it is, Adora tells herself. She knows Catra hates her birthday, and never celebrates it, which lead to their first fight just two months after they met in junior year - by October, they were already best friends, and Adora felt the first tingles of something warm deep inside her stomach whenever she could make Catra laugh and look at her with those mismatched, gleaming eyes. When she found out it was Catra's birthday, she bought a cupcake on her way to school and organized the class to sing for her which made Catra storm out of the classroom and not come back for three periods. Adora was also skipping those classes, desperately trying to apologize. She found Catra in an abandoned classroom on a floor the school didn't use since it burned down years before and they didn't have the money to fix it. Catra apologized to her too, and they shared the cupcake and a couple lame jokes until they both felt better.

After that, it was their secret hideout to spend time and make out - first, just for jokes and practice after their first time none of them dared to take seriously, and later to find privacy between Horde Academy walls.

Adora tears her gaze away from the picture.

This is just a memory, she tells herself again. Catra took Adora's message seriously and nothing strange has happened in Adora's life since then. Catra also never reached out, so Adora didn't either.

Which is probably for the best, even now when her heart only aches without the flames of anger.

This picture will be the only piece of Catra left, and Adora will have to make peace with that.

She managed to move on once already.

She can do it again.

tter3

Adora stands in front of her cheval glass, observing herself critically. Since she cant sew, she ordered her costume online, the fabric sticking to her skin. t is a little tight, enough to emphasiz her curves but not enough to make Adora want to claw her skin off. The golden gauntlets fit perfectly on her arms, and the long, sharp pauldrons stay on her shoulders unmoved as well. Adora does not know how to put her bomber jacket on like this, is all. At least she gets to wear long pants and platform boots, unlike last year when they were all dressed up from Sailor Moon. Adora wanted to burn those short skirts.

She adjusts her winged mask and rolls her shoulders back, feeling a bit of strain at her chest. Whatever she looks like, she must get moving immediately if she doesnt want to be even later to Glimmers Halloween party. She lives way closer now and still managed to waste time with messing around too much about her appearance, despite wearing her usual hair poof and no makeup.

Glimmer takes her thematic costume parties *way* too seriously, but shell have Adoras head even if she is late, not just for not putting enough time and energy into looking decent and in-character.

Adora grabs her coat and bag, and rushes out of the door.

She barges into Glimmer and Bows apartment without knocking or ringing the bell, just like the flashy neon signs they put up telling her to do.

Their apartment is bigger than hers, on the third floor of a huge, expensive complex.

Adora reaches the door and steps into the apartment. Despite the loud music, she hears Perfuma shout from the living room as soon as Adora appears:

"Look, everyone! The She-Ra is here!"

"Adora!"

Netossa whistles.

"Looking good, girl!"

Adora waves awkwardly at them, shrugging her heavy jacket off; she managed to spread it onto her shoulders at least. Her face warms up as she blushes and hangs her jacket, the frills around her waist follow her every move like they are made of air.

"Hey, guys - sorry I'm late."

Glimmer's head pops out of the kitchen, grinning widely. She wears a tiara and purple spandex, flopping her cape majestically.

"Adora, finally! Bow just got the last plate of cookies out of the oven, wanna decorate some?"

"Yeah, sure! Just a second." She scowls. "Did you… do something with your hair?"

Glimmer twirls a pink strand between her fingers. It makes her look more mature than her usual fluffy cloud.

"Yeah! I might keep it like this, actually."

"It looks great."

After Adora said hi to everybody, she joins her friends in the kitchen. She basically slips inside, her voice heavy with envy as she yells:

"Have you seen Scorpia's pincers? She can *move* them!"

Bow's pink kitchen gloves give a really sweet vibe to his costume with a huge heart on his chest, abs showing.

"Yeah, Entrapta connected it to her bionic arm. It's really cool. Hey, you can find everything you need on the counter," Bow tells her, pointing his jaw towards the piles of decorating supplies Adora doesn't even recognize.

"I'm just *saying* it's not fair," Adora mumbles and steals a warm cookie. She munches on it absentmindedly and goes on: "Why don't I get to have something cool, too? 'Cause, I don't know, I'm just the main character this year?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes at her kindly.

"Oh come on, stop sulking. And eating all the cookies before we even decorate them."

"Ugh, fine."

Adora pushes the rest of the cookie in her mouth in one piece and grabs some colorful pipes then, trying to paint as neat and clean lines as she can. Glimmer and Bow join her, and the whole thing quickly turns into a playful competition - not about making the prettiest cookie, but successfully sabotaging each other's attempts. Adora's hand is full of icing and color when she hears the bell ring despite it not supposed to do that.

She barely catches Glimmer and Bow share a look before Glimmer leaves them, and Adora turns her attention back to her cookie. She is focusing so hard on the fourth leg of the ugliest spider she has ever drawn that she doesn't register the two sets of footsteps

growing louder behind her. She keeps the tip of her tongue pinched between her teeth, when-

"Adora?"

She bites down on it, hard. She hisses and turns around, dropping the pipe. It lands right on top of the unsolidified spider, smudging it like it was whacked with a newspaper.

"Catra?"

Adora comes face to face with Catra, wearing normal clothes, hugging her own arm and looking straight at her with those sad, mismatched eyes that haunted Adora day and night.

Adora feels just like her spider, beaten and smashed, her heart beating so fast it rings in her ears.

"Can I talk to you?" Catra asks quietly. "Alone."

Adora just... stares. She hasn't seen Catra in months now, and she can barely manage to take everything in now.

Catra's hair is short again, cut unevenly and slicked back rough, pushing the curls down. Her skin is pale, the shine gone from it just like the rosiness of her cheeks. The circles under her eyes are puffy and dark grey without any makeup, her cheekbones cut sharper than usual.

Adora must have stared for too long without saying anything, because Catra adds, just as soft as before:

"It won't take long. But if you want me to go, I'll go."

Adora finds her voice, although it is weak and desperate:

"No," she says, taking a step closer. She digs her nails into her palm, stopping herself from taking Catra's wrist in her grip. "Don't go. I - I want to talk."

Catra swallows visibly, but doesn't react otherwise.

Glimmer says, her voice coming from the side where she is leaning on Bow, all too knowing but gentle:

"You can use the guest room. First door on the left from the living room."

"Thank you," Catra says, casting her eyes down and turning on her heels.

Adora follows mindlessly. It still feels like a dream, like her head isn't screwed on right, only playing with her feelings again. The way Catra carries herself, so small and fragile and breaking under a pressure Adora doesn't understand, the whole thing just… it makes more and less sense at the same time, confusing her even more.

She breaks through the crowd on Catra's tail and steps into the guest room first. Catra closes the door on them and flips the switch on.

The room is empty apart from a queen-sized bed and a drawer, the curtains closed off on the window. Adora plops down on the bed, her body hollow, and she is even more surprised that Catra sits down by her side, her fingers gripping the spreadsheet.

Adora sees that Catra is shaking a bit. She stares right at her, but Catra's glance is focused straight ahead, eyelashes fluttering.

Catra takes a deep breath, closing her eyes.

"You were right," she starts, voice trembling too. "I… everything you said on Saturday, in your voicemail. I was never fair to you. And I owe you an explanation for everything."

Adora swallows, afraid to say anything yet. Catra raises her jaw and sets it, her eyes flickering around the room now.

"I'm not here to ask for your forgiveness, but I just wanted to say"… Catra turns towards her, eyes drilling into Adora's. "I wanted to say that I am sorry , Adora. For everything."

Adora sucks her lips in and nods sharply, urging her to go on.

"I am sorry for deceiving you. I'm sorry for breaking up with you. I'm sorry for confusing you, I'm sorry for ignoring you for so long again. I just.didn't trust myself to not fuck it up again before I answered."

Adora scowls, leaning ahead.

"What do you mean?"

Catra looks away again, raising her shoulders.

"I know my… ways were wrong, but I wanted to do enough for you before I face you again."

"Catra, I-"

"I know, okay?" Catra cuts in, gentle despite her choice of words. "I know you don't understand. And I'm here to explain. I should have done this a long time ago, I just… I don't know how to start. It's harder than I thought it would be."

There is a breath of silence then, with Catra collecting courage and her thoughts, and Adora waiting patiently for something she has been craving for years.

Catra clears her throat.

"You were right," she says again. "I've been blaming you for things that were never your fault. That's what I've been doing ever since the breakup… which. Was my fault. I know now. I knew it before, too, I guess, but… ugh, fuck." Catra fidgets, her nails tearing into the bedspread. "I don't.actually know where to start."

Adora asks carefully: "Can I ask you questions?"

Catra furrows her brows, thinking.

"Actually , yeah, Ithink that would be better ."

"Okay ." Adora asks the first thing on her mind, not giving it much thought. "Why did you ghost me in high school?"

Catra nods slowly, understanding why Adora wants to start from there. She starts to speak weakly, but her voice gains strength the more she talks:

"Back then, I… its been a lot. Dating you, it was… a whole new set of emotions I didnt know how to deal with. And it was… uncomfortable." Catra feels Adora stirring beside her, so she adds quickly: "Not- not because of you, you were so good to me, but that just made me raise my walls higher than before. Ive never felt… safe, with someone, and it made me scared to lose it because in my mind that was inevitable. Something healthy was alien to me, and I got this inkling, this little voice inside my head telling me that it was bound to fail. I broke up with you because I convinced myself that you can not only do much better than me, but you will realize that sooner than later. No questio ns about it, you knew it, I knew it, and I took the opportunity because fuck, I wanted to have control of one thing in my life, even if it was the last thing I wanted to do. You were so overprotective, so ready to decide everything for us, do everything for us, and that frustrated me a lot because I didnt... take it as you meant."

Adoras throat is tight and dry as she practically pleads:

"Catra, Itold you Inever wanted to leave you."

"Y ou told me seven years later." Catra bares her teeth, her grin sad. "Not blaming you, just telling you that all I registered of that was… I stepped back and gave you a cold shoulder and you accepted without questio n. I shouldnt have ignored you and expected you to fight for me, but thats what Iwanted."

"I wanted to respect your decision."

Catra smiles faintly.

"That was another unfamiliar thing."

"What?"

"Respect."

"Oh," Adora breathes, mulling over it before she adds: "So if I… if I kept fighting for you, you wouldn't have pushed me away again? We could have..." *Still be together*, she thinks. What she says is: "Stayed together back then?"

Catra tilts her head.

"That feels fucked up to own up to, but yeah. Maybe not right away, I… I don't know what I expected, what was going to be enough for me back then. I think I was already too deep in my mind, so I honestly don't know. All I know is… I was angry with you. I felt like you betrayed me, that you were only playing with me, that your silence was you confessing that I didn't mean much to you." Catra hugs herself. "That, I knew really well."

Adora realizes that she is also gripping the bedspread, her fingers cramping.

"I didn't think I meant much to you," she whispers. Catra jerks, turning towards her again with a dumbfounded expression. Adora shrugs. "That's why I didn't… feel like I had something to fight for. Because you pushed me away, and I thought that was it. That you decided that you didn't want me anymore, and I didn't want to bother you."

"Adora, you meant-" Catra chokes on her words, twisting her whole body towards Adora. "You… you meant everything to me, okay? I'm

sorry. It's this stupid fucking"… Catra gestures wildly at her own head. "It's like. Fuck. I wish my therapist were here."

"You go to therapy?"

"Doesn't show well, does it," Catra chuckles. It sounds hollow. "I did, for a while, and I went back after Etheria. It's like… what I did to you, what… I did on Saturday, it was never about you, it was just me. Only me. I had so much self-hatred for having that fucked up plan and I had so much guilt piling up. You were right, I was projecting that. It's a really fucked up defense mechanism. I can't explain it as well as it was explained to me, but... it feeds on my anger I feel towards being treated poorly and when I'm not my insecurities are acting up and my abandonment issues are telling me that I don't deserve it, and I it's something about the bitch who raised me, I'm working on it. But what's important is - both times I dragged you along with me. And I never should have. I hurt you a lot." Catra's hand shakes like she would reach for Adora's, but she stops herself. "I'm not going to do that again."

Adora's head feels light as a feather. The fog that has been twirling inside her mind finally seems to rise, Catra's words slowly shooing away the confusion and frustration. She lets her body relax, shoulders dropping and muscles slacking, unclenching her jaw.

She wishes it was easier to ignore Catra's hand so close to hers is all.

"Can I ask you something else?"

"Anything."

"About… Etheria." Adora can see Catra wince. Her leather jacket is rustling as she moves. "When you said that you just wanted to hurt me... was that true?"

"At first," Catra confesses quietly.

"For how long?"

Much to Adora's surprise, Catra snickers weakly. Adora is staring at her crinkled nose, her pretty little freckles.

"Adora, I ran away from my feelings for you the very first night because it was too much. And I got… confused. I kept telling myself that I should stop, but for a while, I kept pushing it because I felt justified by the anger. On and off, and I didn't know how to control it. I had moments of acting out, while I just tried to be fucking normal. What I said on Saturday, I… I just said the things I knew would hurt the most."

"When did you stop? Completely."

"At the bar."

Adora nods. That is when she started sensing the shift as well; when Catra's care and attention started to warm up her heart again. When those moments increased, and started to take up most of their time together, getting closer and closer again.

"So when we.when you. When we did the. You know."

Catra scowls, staring at Adora uncomprehendingly. Adora lifts her hands, smashing her fingers together and quirks a brow.

"Wh-- oh my God, Adora-" Catra bursts out laughing, loud and uncontrollable.

She buries her face into her hands, muffling her high, delirious chuckles, fingers raking into her now short hair.

Adora joins in, laughing heartily for the first time in months. She missed this. She missed this so much it hurts, the sensation tight in her chest and her cheeks.

Catra's laughter slowly shifts into something else. Her shoulders are trembling, her noises turn wet and sniffly. Adora's grin fades away;

she is unsure whether or not she is allowed to touch, so she halts her hand just an inch from Catra's shoulder, desperate to embrace her and ease the jolts.

Catra stops quickly with a raspy exhale. She sniffles again and rubs her eyes with the heels of her palms. Her face is rosy and shiny again when she lets her hands fall and licks a teardrop off her lips.

She keeps quiet, breathing heavily. Adora scoots just a little closer, leaning on a hand she rests right by Catra's thigh.

Catra doesn't draw away, and Adora whispers, barely audible:

"Why did you sleep with me?"

Catra turns her head towards her, raising her chin slowly. They are eye to eye now, close enough that Adora can feel the warmth of Catra's body, the huffs of her breath on her own skin. Catra looks straight into Adora's eyes, her gaze flickering between them.

"Isn't that obvious?"

Adora is not sure.

"I want to hear it from you."

Catra casts her eyes down, wandering to Adora's lips before sliding back up. Her irises are burning so sad, and Catra says, simple but shy enough for her voice to stab Adora right in the abdomen:

"Because I love you. I always have, I guess."

Adora feels like she's just been released into the deep from a drop tower; a powerless body falling fast, her stomach in her throat, her blood buzzing in her ears.

Then, the last drops of that clammy, thick darkness melt away from her chest like a curse cast away.

Adora breathes:

"You love me?"

"Yeah? Uh… shit." Catra bites her lip and now she draws back a little, clearing her throat. She adds quickly: "Look, I I know I've hurt you a lot, and I have little to no expectations that you would want to be friends again-"

"I don't want to be friends."

Catra shuts her eyes, breathing out in a lifeless chuckle.

"Yeah, I- I get it."

"No," Adora says, gentle but firm. Her hand closes on Catra's. "You don't."

Catra jerks up, staring at their hands, then up to Adora's face. Adora is aware of the expression she must have, but seeing Catra's absolute shock amuses her even more.

"Adora, what are you-"

"Not letting you go." Adora raises her brows with a little smile. "As promised." Adora is stroking the back of Catra's hand now, reassuring and kind. She raises her other hand to Catra's face, cupping her still wet cheek. "I know you're not a bad person, Catra. But you're deeply hurt. And I failed to see that." Catra opens her mouth, so Adora says: "Wait. I'd like you to hear me out. Maybe I didn't fail to see that, because I saw a lot. I thought that I understood a lot, too. But I think I haven't because I never saw the reason behind what you've been doing. I also know that… I'm not always the best at listening to someone, or reading the room. You were right too. I- I only care about what I think is true."

Catra scoffs without edge. Adora goes on:

"So I think I understand now why you felt like you had no control, and that I didn't feel as serious about you as you have about me. But that's just not true. I can just… get so focused on something that I have to do that and I can't pay attention to anything else. And I thought I was doing the right thing by doing things for you, but I never meant it as… *instead* of you, not because I ever thought you were incapable of getting things done."

Catra's fingers finally move against Adora's, caressing her too. She is careful and gentle, barely touching.

"I know now. When we fought… when I left, it was also about the way we left things in the morning."

"You mean from the date?"

"Yeah." Catra swallows thickly. "I know you were just so focused on being on time that you didn't register anything apart from that. Back then when you did something similar, it always hurt. And now I thought you'd be… happy that we were together again. That you would be proud to have me, and we would act like a couple, shit like that. I felt used. And what's even more fucked up is that if you didn't find me, I would have just left without a word. Wouldn't have made such a mess. Coming to my senses before fucking everything up, maybe."

"I'm sorry, Catra."

"God, don't be." Catra puts her palm on Adora's hand, guiding it away from her cheek. "None of that is your fault. I'm just explaining, still. And there's no excuse for how I treated you in the bungalow. I already asked Perfuma to get me back to the anger management group we met-"

Adora nearly chokes on her spit.

"Wait, what? Our Perfuma?" Catra nods. "But she's so… she's Perfuma!"

Catra shrugs.

"That's how you know it works. And how desperately I need it." Catra lets Adora's hands go again, drawing hers back into her lap. "And seriously, Adora, I'm not… expecting anything from this, you don't have to be careful and sweet to me, I won't lose my shit again. I'm not… nice, but I don't… ever want to be like that again, and I promised you that I would never hurt you again."

Adora draws her leg up onto the bed, leaning on a hand.

"I trust you. And before you say anything to dismiss that" Catra makes a sour face, "I think you should trust yourself more too. Did you think I forgot everything you've done for me? That I didn't see how much you've grown already? You say you're not nice, but I know that you are. I can see that, why can't you?"

Catra looks more shocked than ever, her whole body frozen. She looks like she could spring up and out of the door in any minute, so as soon as she jerks away, Adora grabs her wrist.

"Hey," Adora says softly. "I am not letting you go, but you have to stop running."

Catra exhales with a deep, deep sigh. She scoots closer again, mirroring Adora's body and letting their fingers touch as she leans on her hand too.

"Why are you like this?" Catra asks quietly. "What do you want from me, Adora?"

"What I always wanted. Everything. Anything that you can give me, I will gladly take. And" Adora leans a bit closer until their noses almost touch. Her bright smile softens her voice even more, "I love you, too."

Catra's pretty lips part, the flickers in her eyes are like the fireworks at the barbeque. Her fingers are soft and warm on Adora's cheek,

her palm too.

Catra closes the gap between their lips. Adora kisses back, just as gentle and slow as Catra kisses her, their lips barely moving.

Catra draws back, already a little breathless:

"Ask me again."

"W -what?" Adora mumbles, still dazed from the kiss.

Catra pushes her hand into the pocket of her jacket, and pulls something out. Her moves are hurried, jaggy . Adora's eyes widen.

"Catra-"

Catra unfolds the note, Adora's question written in blue ink. Catra takes Adora's hand and gives her the paper .

"Ask me again."

Adora's fingers are shaking as they clasp around the crumpled message. She doesn't have to look at it to say it from memory, loud and clear:

"Will you be mine again?"

"Y es."

Catra kisses her again, more urgently this time. Adora's hands come up to slide into Catra's short hair, ruffling the tufts as she opens her mouth, pleading. Catra deepens the kiss without hesitation, arms closing up around Adora's shoulders.

Adora nearly loses herself completely when Catra's snickering breaks the kiss and leaves her whimpering.

"What now?" She complains.

"Nothing, it's just"… Catra draws back, smirking up at her. "I open my eyes and I'm making out with She-Ra. It's pretty ridiculous."

Adora just remembers that she is in full costume, at a Halloween party. Her grin is smug, her singing voice too:

"I know you always had a thing for her."

"I did not!"

"Uhh, did too." Adora boops their noses together. "You took that action figure to school and you had those stickers on your calculus book-"

Catra silences Adora with her lips. Adora can't say she minds, although now she wants to laugh desperately. She snorts into the kiss unattractively, trying to keep the air in her lungs.

They both turn away at the same time, wheezing like idiot kids. Adora is laughing without making any noise, her nose whistling.

Once they collect themselves, barely, something else hits Adora in the head.

"Wait, wait. Did you do it?"

Catra sniffs.

"Did what?"

"Breaking into Etheria."

"Oh." Catra blushes deeply, baring her teeth. "Yeah, I- I went back for the note."

Adora scoffs, her voice funny.

"Did you seriously think that was a good idea?"

t was a better idea than asking Sparkles after I threw my keys at her and made her best friend cry."

Fair ,"Adora says. "Also you totally cried, too."

"Oh please." Catra raises a brow. Her voice is sadder than she intended. "Y eah. Im sorry ."

"I know ."Adora kisses her cheek. "Clean slate"?

"Clean slate."

"So… if we agreed on that." Adora smudges a little kiss to the corner of Catra's mouth before continuing, unable to keep herself away. "Did you ask Entrapta to send me those ads"?

"...Y es."

"Anything else"? Adora draws Catra closer, hand on her waist. "I want to know everything."

Catra clears her throat before mumbling shamefully:

"The Fright Zone interview ."

"Are you my reference"?

"T o be perfectly clear, I only got you the interview, not the job, okay? You got it because you deserve it, which Iknew you would."

"How did you even arrange that? Have you played for them"?

"Eh, for a while." Catra fidgets a bit; she looks like she is trying to decide how much she wants to lead Adora on. "Octavia fucking hates me, but she could be..persuaded."

Adora furrows her brows.

"With?..

t’ s nothing.”

“Catra,” Adora pushes softly . “I’d like to know .”

“Ugh, it’s *nothing*, I just had to offer her something she wanted, which was, apparently, four months of free drinks from the coffee shop I work at.”

“That’ s... a lot.”

Surprisingly, Catra giggles.

“My boss thought so too. So technically, they’re not free, because he takes it away from my paycheck.”

Adora’s mouth twists into a grimace.

“Catra, you shouldn’t have-”

“It’ s fine. I wanted to. It’ s not much.”

Adora knows that she can’t say anything to convince Catra. She keeps stroking Catra’s hair instead, and something else comes to her mind.

“Were you at the hospital? When I had my second surgery ."

Catra looks scared, again, wincing in Adora’s embrace. She stays put though, licking her lips.

“I didn’t think you’d remember… fuck, forget everything I said, I was still so freaked out and-"

“Wait, wait- what did you say?”

Catra lets her shoulders drop, relieved. Her blush darkens a couple shades, creeping down her neck and up her ears too.

“Just, you know . Whatever," she grumbles.

"Catra," Adora begs.

"No. Nu-uh. It was very embarrassing. Way more embarrassing than this talk, yes, that is possible." She quickly changes the topic: "Also, the whistle is from me."

Adora squeezes Catra's waist.

"Awww, I love it!"

"Obviously," Catra replies, full of herself. "I knew you would, golden girl."

"Anything else?"

"That was all. I swear."

Adora nods. Now that she knows everything, and sees things more clearly, Catra's little tricks seem to be more romantic and caring than the mocking manipulation she previously thought.

"See," she whispers, pressing their foreheads together. "I knew you were nice. Morally questionable, but nice."

"Your mask looks so stupid."

"There she is."

They both chuckle, their eyes meeting. Adora isn't sure how long they're just staring at each other's eyes, and she wouldn't give a shit if someone wasn't knocking on the door loudly, making them both wince.

Glimmer's voice breaks through the door, shrieking:

"I don't care if you killed each other or you're "making up", but either way could you stop and come out already!? There's a party happening!"

Adora yells:

"We're coming!"

Catra adds immediately:

"Should have phrased that better!"

"Oh great, you're alive."

"Never a dull moment with you, Sparkles."

Adora snorts, turning to Catra again:

"How did you even get her to let you in?"

"I apologized to her first. And Bow, too. For being a dick in general. And told her the gist of everything I just told you. Don't worry, she still hates me deep down, and contemplates pressing charges if I ever break your heart again."

"I can't believe you," Adora says, full of affection she never wants to hide again.

Adora gets off the bed, lending Catra a hand. She helps her up and holds her hand tight, leading her out of the room.

Catra shoots her a questioning look as Adora kicks the door closed with a loud thud. Heads turn towards them when Adora slides her palms on Catra's shoulder and under her knee, scooping her up bridal style. Catra freezes, a bit rigid, freckled cheeks flushed and eyes wide as she hugs Adora's neck impulsively.

Adora winks at her before raising her voice above the music:

"Attention, everyone! We need a costume for my girlfriend ASAP!"

From the corner of her eye, Adora sees Scorpia crash down to the backrest of the closest sofa, wheezing deeply:

"Oh thank God-- oh God. Thank goodness. Huh, I almost passed out. Hooo boy."

People start to try talking each other down now, everyone having a very clear opinion on the matter after they were forced to suffer through the whole drama. (And trying to get Adora a girlfriend for three years.)

Adora ignores all the noise and kisses Catra's lips - a ridiculous, big peck as she gently plops her down on her feet. She raises an eyebrow at her, asking "well?" without words.

Catra's face is still beet red, and she fails to gnaw on her cheek to stop a smile from spreading on her face. Before she could say anything, Glimmer appears behind Catra, pushing a headband on her ruffled hair.

"Hey ," Catra snaps, turning on her heels. Glimmer already leaped round her , Catra spinning with a scowl to catch up.

Catra lifts her hand to touch the headband. She feels out the big, fluffy black ears and whispers a playful threat:

"What the hell did you put on my head?"

Glimmer narrows her eyes, grinning proudly. She raises her hand, holding up a tail to accompany the cat ears.

"Obviously , you gotta be She-Ra's love interest now."

Catra huffs.

"Who, the force captain? Dont they hate each other?"

Adora tilts her head, saying softly:

"It' s surprising what a little misunderstanding can lead to. Even with people who love each other."

Glimmer shrugs, not noticing the look Adora and Catra share above her head.

"I just love a good enemies to lovers trope," she says and shakes the tail. Her grin is bright, almost sadistic. She takes a step closer to Catra, hunching carefully like she is hunting her down: "Now come on, put on the tail."

"I'm not putting on a fucking tail-"

"Catra, put on the tail."

They start playing tag, circling around Adora, giggling and shrieking.

"Adora stop her , she's torturing me!"

"Do you *always* have to be this dramatic?"

"Sorry , Catra," Adora says, crossing her arms. "You must put on the tail or suffer the consequences."

Catra scoffs arrogantly, clinging to Adora's shoulders from behind.

"Oh yeah? And what are those?"

Adora sucks her lips in, thinking. She lets them pop then, warning Catra:

"No PDA."

"Adora you *live* for PDA, that's your punishment too." Adora pouts, glancing up. Catra just giggles and strokes Adora's arm, stepping in front of her again. She purrs, tiptoeing: "Tell you what. I'll strap the tail on if you strap-"

"*Not in my home!* " Glimmer screams and throws the tail to Adora like it burned her hand.

Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist, her right feeling out the belt loops on Catra's ripped jeans. Catra raises an eyebrow, urging Adora to agree to her conditions.

Adora grins widely and nods, buckling the tail on Catra.

"I'll pin you down to your word."

"Not if I pin you first."

"I need a drink," Glimmer mumbles from behind. Before she leaves, she shoots Adora and Catra a warm smile. "Now go be annoyingly in love. And have fun, finally."

"Will do," Adora sighs, squeezing Catra in a tight hug that leaves her gasp for air, but still giggling deliriously.

The party is raging on, Adora having the time of her life. Catra never leaves her side, and she doesn't leave Catra's. They play silly couple games with the others, joining Glimmer's creative contests, dance and drink and laugh like they haven't in a very, very long time.

They leave together around three, racing to their vehicles down the stairs, panting and giggling when they catch up to each other, hands grabbing and tugging as they try to cheat, distracting the other with kisses and tickles.

"I won!" Catra shouts, chest heaving. She throws her hands up and leans onto the handlebar of her Rebel.

Adora joins her a couple leaps late, pressing her body close to Catra's. Her palms clasp on Catra's waist.

"Because you always cheat."

"Is that why you shamelessly tried to distract me with your biceps?"

"I did what I had to do," Adora says dramatically, letting her voice break.

Catra slides her arms on Adora's golden pauldrons, smirking with narrow eyes.

"Still, I won. You know what that means."

"Yeah," Adora whispers, tightening her grip on Catra's waist suggestively. "Your place."

number1

Adora awakens with a content sigh, blinking slowly. Bright, grey light crawls on the blanket in stripes, breaking through the blinds.

Catra stirs beside her. Their legs are entwined under the covers, the bridge of Catra's foot stroking up Adora's shin. Melog is purring, curled into a circle by Adora's head.

"Hey, Adora," Catra murmurs, voice raspy with sleep. She turns her head only, pushing her ass back to Adora's lap.

"Hi, baby," Adora breathes, nuzzling into the crook of Catra's neck. She breathes in the smoky scent of her skin deep. "Slept well?"

Catra just moans, reaching back for Adora's hand and pulling it on her waist. She brings her knuckles to her lips, kissing them one by one.

"You?"

"Yeah."

Truth is, Adora doesn't remember the last time she had such a great sleep. She props up on an elbow, chin rested in her palm. Catra turns on her back, blinking up at her with irises still misty from fractures of a dream.

Catra climbs out of the bed, Adora whining at the loss of warmth and contact. Catra stretches with her arms raised, fingers entwined. Adora gets lost at the sight of her sharp bones, bare shoulders peppered with freckles. No matter how many times she has seen her like this, she can never get enough.

Catra peeks back above her shoulder and catches her staring. She spins around, arms on her hips as she tilts them suggestively.

"Wanna shower?"

"Like, first?" Adora jokes, squinting shamelessly.

Catra shrugs and leaves for the bathroom.

"Your choice, hotshot."

Adora rushes out of bed like she was stung by a bee, nearly stumbling. She hurries after Catra, catching her by the waist just before she could slip out of the door.

Catra shrieks, clinging to Adora's arms around her as she is lifted and twirled.

Adora's heart is so full it is ready to burst. She presses close under the hot shower, fume writhing around them. Catra's careful fingertips are following the drops, mapping Adora's body.

Adora kisses her.

That fateful piece of paper comes to play two more times in their lives.

Three months later, Adora couldn't be happier.

Waking up to Catra's pretty face every day is a luxury she didn't think she would ever be able to afford. Their sleep schedule is based on who gets off work first, so the other can come home to them.

Catra is good to her. The first conversation they had at the Halloween party was followed by many more, quiet and sad and sometimes frustrating, but they have both grown enough that they listen, and understand. Adora realizes that she has never been fully honest herself, and it took Catra's love for her to open up about things she never thought she could be honest about. Where Catra's emotions have overflown, Adora clammed up, and they met halfway - Catra's attention lured Adora out of her shell, and Adora's soothed Catra down.

They are lounging on the sofa, Catra's head in Adora's lap, Adora playing with Catra's short hair absentmindedly. Catra strokes Adora's hand in hers, her thumb caressing her skin.

A series they both got hooked up on is playing on Adora's laptop in front of them. The episode is over, and they let the credits roll, not caring about skipping them as much as they care about not moving from each other's embrace.

Catra stretches with a cute moan, then asks, offhandedly:

"Did you find my present?"

Adora stops petting Catra, her voice full of excitement:

"No. What present?"

I hid it in your backpack," Catra yawns. When Adora stirs to check, she turns towards her stomach and hugs her tight to keep her in place. "Fuck that, I can just tell you."

Adora chuckles, not caring about the next episode starting. She coos:

"You just have to be pampered, don't you?"

Catra grumbles into her stomach:

"Or maybe I don't tell you, and you'll never know what it was because I'll destroy it before you could find it."

"The question is, do you wanna be pampered or not?"

Catra growls. She lifts Adora's shirt up and nips the soft skin above her belly button, making Adora yelp. Now that she came out on top, or at least she thinks, Catra says:

"I've got you a key to the apartment."

Adora feels her grin widen even more, her expression softens.

"Really?" She breathes.

Catra gets up, but doesn't get far; she climbs into Adora's lap, thighs straddling hers. Her smile is intoxicating, her scent too. The white-blue light of the screen crowns her with a mysterious glow, flickering on her ruffled hair and petite shoulders.

"I mean yeah, you basically have half your stuff here already. You should be able to come and go as you want and not wait for me."

Adora wiggles her eyebrows.

"Are we... talking about moving together?"

"...Maybe."

Adora can't stop a giggle from escaping her, or her lips from catching Catra's in a soft peck.

"Okay , don't be weird."

"Says the girl who can't wait to live with me."

"Because the girl who can't keep her lips away from me basically moved into my apartment already." Catra's arms wrap around Adora's neck, hands hanging off from the backrest of the sofa. "I'm just thinking that mine is bigger, cheaper. And still closer to both our jobs. And we have to think of the child. And *Melog* ," Catra adds, when Adora's face falls with confusion.

"Oh, right."

"So"… Catra says coyly and unhooks her arm from Adora's neck to take something out of the pocket of her shorts. She gives it to Adora to read Catra's new message right by Adora's, written in her scratchy writing. "What do you think"?

Adora,

Do you want to live with me?

Adora's lungs are burning, happy tears pooling at the corner of her eyes. She quickly blinks them away, running her thumb across the message.

She looks at Catra, who returns Adora's melting gaze with her own, nervous panic flickering in hers.

"Yes," Adora whispers.

She leans in for a kiss; it’s slow and fond, Adora pouring every drop of love she feels for Catra at the moment, and every single moment for the last couple months. Catra kisses back, deepening it softly, carefully, gratefully.

Adora couldnt be happier .

*

A year later, Adora thinks she might be happier with only one change in her relationship with Catra.

She is waiting for her in their favorite restaurant, small and cozy . She is surrounded by heavy wooden tables with red-checkered tablecloths, bricks walls, fairy lights and candles, plants hanging from the ceiling. She wears her prettiest white dress, frothy tulle and expensive silk with a touch of gold, trying her best not to ruin it by sweating too much.

Her heart is in her throat and on her sleeve, open, devoted, and so anxious she feels like she might throw up on the table at any moment, successfully ruining the single most important night of her life.

The front door opens, and Adora loses her breath.

Her sweaty palm slips into her dress pocket, trying to ground herself with her fingers clasping around a bourbon jewelry box, and the precious, worn-out note.

Adora has a whole speech in her mind that she rehearsed over and over for weeks now, so the note simply reads:

By , you're a real keeper

Will you marry me?

Chapter End Notes

Here we are, babes... The journey is over. And I'm overly emotional about it, not gonna lie. :'DD This story means a lot to me, and I hope you guys have enjoyed the ride. I poured my heart and soul into it, and I'm really gonna miss it. I won't say the Coach Catradora series is over now that the main story is, because if you'd like to read some other short stories like the end of the date (which you can find as "Foul Play" by the way, if you missed it;)), don't hesitate to tell me. I love hearing from you in the comments, or at Tumblr or Twitter! Come hang out with me there, it's a fun time and I really love talking to you. ♡

I can't express how grateful I am for your overwhelming support on this fic! ♡ Truly, you guys had inspired me and made me so happy for so many times, I can only hope I have back a fraction of it with my writing. You're all amazing, and I'm so glad to have you. I hope you'll stick around for my other fics as well, because I'm definitely going to write more Catradora.

If you enjoyed reading, please consider supporting the fic by sharing my post about it, and check out my fic tag for additional content for all my works.

I love you all.
Thank you for everything.

End Notes

Thank you very much for reading! ♡
f you enjoyed it, Iwould really appreciate if you left a comment.
You can also support the fic with reblogging the Tumblr post about it. x

Find me on Tumblr as @ee-ra

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!